

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

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Chapter 1 - Meet the X-Touch

Why "Project XTC"?

XTC stands for X-Touch Companion. This guide is designed to sit alongside the official Behringer, Bitwig and DrivenByMoss documentation, bringing everything together into one practical handbook. If the name raises a knowing smile, that's perfectly fine - but throughout this book, XTC always means X-Touch Companion.

If you've bought a Behringer X-Touch, you've probably already discovered two things. First, it feels like a serious piece of studio equipment. Second, learning to use it effectively with Bitwig can be surprisingly difficult.

The Behringer manual explains the hardware. Bitwig explains the DAW. DrivenByMoss explains the extension. What has been missing is a guide that explains how all three work together. That is the purpose of Project XTC.

Who This Book Is For

This guide assumes you already know the basics of using a computer and Bitwig Studio. It does not assume any previous knowledge of MCU, MIDI protocols or control surfaces. Every important idea is introduced only when it becomes useful.

What the X-Touch Is

The X-Touch is a hardware control surface. It does not process audio or replace Bitwig. It provides tactile control over track selection, transport, mixing, PLUG-IN, automation and much more.

The Four Principles

1. Bitwig is in charge.
2. The selected track matters.
3. Modes change meanings.
4. Feedback is as important as input.

Before You Continue...

Don't worry about memorising every button yet. In the next chapter we'll take a guided tour of the X-Touch so every control has a name and a purpose before we start using it.

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Chapter 2 - A Tour of the Hardware

Before learning individual features, it's worth becoming familiar with the physical layout of the X-Touch. You don't need to memorise every control. The goal is simply to help you recognise where things are, so later chapters can refer to them naturally.

The Eight Channel Strips

The heart of the X-Touch consists of eight identical channel strips. Each strip includes a motor fader, a touch-sensitive V-Pot with an LED ring, a scribble strip display, and buttons such as SELECT, SOLO, MUTE and REC. Because every strip is identical, once you understand one, you understand them all.

The Master Section

To the right of the eight channels is the master section. It includes the master fader and additional navigation controls.

Assignment Buttons

The TRACK, SEND, PAN, PLUG-IN, EQ and INSTRUMENT buttons change what the V-Pots control.

GLOBAL VIEW

The USER button in GLOBAL VIEW opens Browser Mode when using DrivenByMoss.

Reality Check

If the number of buttons feels intimidating, remember that you rarely use them all at once.

Before You Continue...

The next chapter introduces the mental model that makes the X-Touch predictable.

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Chapter 3 - The Mental Model

Most difficulties people experience with the X-Touch come from thinking of it as a mixer with fixed controls. It isn't. The X-Touch is better understood as a window into Bitwig.

Bitwig Is Always in Charge

The X-Touch follows Bitwig's current state. If Bitwig changes, the controller reflects that change.

Selection Comes First

Before adjusting anything ask: What is currently selected? Successful workflows nearly always begin with SELECT.

Modes Change Meaning

The same controls perform different jobs in different contexts. Understanding modes is more important than memorising combinations.

Always Read the Feedback

Motor faders, LED rings and scribble strips constantly tell you what Bitwig is doing.

A Simple Workflow

SELECT -> Observe -> Adjust -> Listen

Notice that adjustment comes third, not first.

Reality Check

If the X-Touch behaves unexpectedly, check the selected track, current mode and scribble strips first.

Field Note

The best X-Touch users don't memorise hundreds of functions. They ask, "What is Bitwig telling me right now?"

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Chapter 4 - Banks and Channels

Banks and Channels

The X-Touch has eight channel strips.

A Bitwig project can have far more than eight tracks.

So one of the first important ideas to understand is this:

The eight channel strips are a window onto the project.

They do not permanently belong to Tracks 1-8.

They represent whichever eight tracks are currently visible to the controller.

The Eight-Channel Window

Imagine a Bitwig project containing 24 tracks:

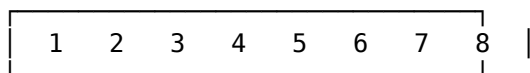
Project

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24

The X-Touch can physically show eight of them at once.

Initially, that might be:

Bitwig Project



X-Touch

The faders, V-Pots, MUTE, SOLO, ARM and SELECT buttons all refer to those eight tracks.

But the window can move.

BANK — Move Eight Tracks at a Time

The BANK buttons move the track-bank focus by eight tracks.

Press:

BANK >

and the controller moves to the next group of eight.

So:

Before

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

 |

becomes:

After BANK >

9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
---	----	----	----	----	----	----	----

 |

Press BANK > again:

17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
----	----	----	----	----	----	----	----

 |

BANK < moves in the opposite direction.

BANK Is the Large Movement

A useful mental model is:

BANK



move by one whole surface

Because the X-Touch has eight channel strips:

BANK



8 tracks

This is the fastest way to move through a large project.

CHANNEL — Move One Track at a Time

The CHANNEL buttons move the track-bank focus by one track.

Suppose the controller currently shows:

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

Press:

CHANNEL >

and the window moves by one:

2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

Press it again:

3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

CHANNEL < moves the window back one track.

CHANNEL Is the Small Movement

So the simplest distinction is:

BANK
→ move 8

CHANNEL
→ move 1

Or:

BANK
→ coarse navigation

CHANNEL
→ fine navigation

That is the fundamental relationship between the two pairs of buttons.

BANK and CHANNEL Work Together

Suppose you have 40 tracks and want to reach Track 19.

You could press CHANNEL > eighteen times.

That would work.

But it would be tedious.

Instead:

Tracks 1–8
|
BANK >
▼
Tracks 9–16
|
BANK >
▼
Tracks 17–24

Now Track 19 is visible.

BANK gets you into the right area.

CHANNEL lets you make smaller adjustments when necessary.

A useful rule is:

BANK for distance. CHANNEL for precision.

The Hardware Does Not Belong to Particular Tracks

This is worth emphasising.

Physical Channel Strip 1 is not:

Track 1.

It means:

The first track in the controller's current bank.

Likewise, Physical Channel Strip 8 means:

The eighth track in the current bank.

So:

Bank 1

Strip	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Track	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8

then:

Bank 2

Strip	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Track	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16

The physical strips remain where they are.

Their targets change.

Watch the Scribble Strips

This is why the scribble strips are so important.

After changing bank, do not continue thinking:

Fader 1 = previous Track 1

Look at the display.

It tells you what Fader 1 represents now.

For example:

Before BANK >

Kick	Snare	Hats	Bass	Pad	Lead	Vox	FX
------	-------	------	------	-----	------	-----	----

then:

After BANK >

Room	Perc	Piano	Gtr1	Gtr2	BVox	Verb	Delay
------	------	-------	------	------	------	------	-------

The controls have not moved.

Their context has.

This gives us one of the most important habits in Project XTC:

Observe before you adjust.

Banking Does Not Select a Track

Moving the bank and selecting a track are different ideas.

BANK and CHANNEL change:

Which tracks are available on the eight channel strips?

SELECT changes:

Which particular track has focus?

So:

BANK / CHANNEL



move the window

whereas:

SELECT



choose something inside the window

This distinction becomes increasingly important later.

Selection Can Move with the Window

Suppose Track 6 is selected.

Your current bank is:

1 2 3 4 5 [6] 7 8

You then move to:

9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16

Track 6 still exists in the project.

It is simply no longer represented by one of the eight visible channel strips.

This distinction between:

selected track

and:

tracks currently exposed by the bank

is useful when understanding more advanced controller behaviour.

The Window Can Overlap

CHANNEL navigation shows us that banks are not necessarily isolated blocks.

For example:

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

followed by CHANNEL > gives:

2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

So the controller window can overlap its previous position.

This is why it is better to think in terms of a movable eight-track window than a set of fixed pages.

A Visual Model

Imagine a long strip of tracks:

01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20

The X-Touch window begins here:

[01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08] 09 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20

BANK >:

01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 [09 10 11 12 13 14 15 16] 17 18 19 20

CHANNEL >:

01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 [10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17] 18 19 20

BANK changes the window dramatically.

CHANNEL nudges it.

Banking and Large Projects

Suppose a project contains:

Drums
Bass
Guitar
Piano
Pad
Lead
Vocal
Backing Vocal
Percussion
Strings
FX 1
FX 2
...

With a mouse, you might scroll horizontally through the mixer.

With the X-Touch:

BANK >

is the equivalent large-scale movement.

The eight physical strips remain a stable workspace while the project moves through them.

This can become much faster than visually hunting for a track.

Track Order Matters

Because BANK and CHANNEL follow the Bitwig track bank, the order of tracks in the project affects the physical workflow.

For example, this:

Kick
Snare
Hats
Percussion
Bass
Guitar
Keys
Vocal

may make more physical sense than:

Kick
Vocal
Keys
Snare
Guitar
Hats
Bass
Percussion

if the first arrangement reflects how you naturally think about the mix.

This is not an X-Touch rule.

It is a workflow observation:

A logically organised Bitwig project is easier to navigate from hardware.

OPTION Changes BANK and CHANNEL

BANK and CHANNEL have another set of functions when used with OPTION.

These are important because they do not navigate the track bank.

Instead, they physically reorganise things in the Bitwig project.

The verified DrivenByMoss mappings are:

OPTION + BANK <
→ Move selected device left

OPTION + BANK >
→ Move selected device right

and:

OPTION + CHANNEL <
→ Move selected track left

OPTION + CHANNEL >
→ Move selected track right

This is a significant distinction.

Without OPTION:

BANK / CHANNEL
→ navigate

With OPTION:

BANK / CHANNEL
→ move project objects

OPTION + CHANNEL — Move the Selected Track

Suppose the project order is:

Drums Bass Guitar Vocal

and Guitar is selected:

Drums Bass [Guitar] Vocal

Use:

OPTION + CHANNEL <

and the selected track moves to the left.

Conceptually:

Before

Drums Bass [Guitar] Vocal

OPTION + CHANNEL <

After

Drums [Guitar] Bass Vocal

Likewise:

OPTION + CHANNEL >

moves the selected track to the right.

This is not scrolling.

It is reordering the project.

Navigation Versus Reorganisation

This difference deserves a clear mental separation:

CHANNEL >

→ show the next track position

but:

OPTION + CHANNEL >

→ move the selected track
to the right

One changes your view.

The other changes the project.

Because moving tracks is consequential, use the modified command deliberately.

OPTION + BANK — Move the Selected Device

OPTION + BANK performs the corresponding operation at device level.

Suppose a track contains:

EQ → Compressor → Delay

and Compressor is selected.

Use:

OPTION + BANK <

to move the selected device left.

Conceptually:

Before

EQ → [Compressor] → Delay

OPTION + BANK <

After

[Compressor] → EQ → Delay

And:

OPTION + BANK >

moves the selected device to the right.

Again, this is not controller navigation.

The device itself is being moved within the Bitwig device chain.

Why BANK for Devices and CHANNEL for Tracks?

At first, this may seem slightly odd:

OPTION + BANK
→ move device

OPTION + CHANNEL
→ move track

But it becomes easier to remember once Device Mode is introduced.

BANK already acquires a strong relationship with devices there.

CHANNEL remains associated with movement at a finer level.

For now, it is enough to learn the verified mapping rather than trying to force every command into a perfect analogy.

Device Mode Is the Important Exception

So far we have said:

BANK
→ move 8 tracks

CHANNEL
→ move 1 track

That is correct during normal track-oriented operation.

But DrivenByMoss explicitly makes Device Mode an exception.

In Device Mode:

BANK <
→ Previous Device

BANK >
→ Next Device

while:

CHANNEL <
→ Previous Parameter Page

CHANNEL >
→ Next Parameter Page

So the same buttons change meaning according to context.

Normal Context Versus Device Context

Outside Device Mode:

BANK
→ 8 tracks

CHANNEL
→ 1 track

Inside Device Mode:

BANK
→ devices

CHANNEL
→ parameter pages

This is not an inconsistency.

It is an example of the X-Touch's contextual design.

The controls are reused for the kind of navigation appropriate to the current mode.

BANK Means "Larger Step"

There is a useful conceptual pattern here.

In ordinary track navigation:

BANK
→ large movement through tracks

In Device Mode:

BANK
→ movement between whole devices

Meanwhile:

CHANNEL

handles the finer-grained movement:

Normal
→ individual tracks

Device Mode
→ individual parameter pages

So even though the literal targets change, the broad relationship remains:

BANK moves at the larger structural level; CHANNEL moves at the finer level.

That is a useful idea to carry into later chapters.

Context Determines Meaning

This gives us an early example of one of the most important ideas in the entire guide.

A physical button does not necessarily have one permanent function.

Its meaning depends on context.

For BANK >:

Normal track context



move track bank by 8

but:

Device Mode



select next device

and:

OPTION + BANK >



move selected device right

One physical button.

Three related but distinct operations.

Do Not Memorise All Three at Once

At this stage of the guide, the most important pair is still:

BANK

→ 8 tracks

CHANNEL

→ 1 track

Learn that first.

The other meanings will become easier when we reach the relevant chapters.

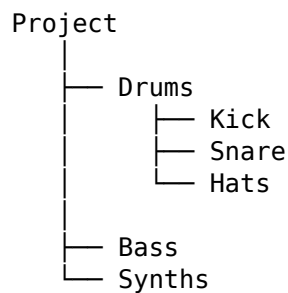
For now, simply remember:

BANK and CHANNEL are contextual navigation controls, and modifiers can turn navigation into editing.

Banks and Hierarchy

Later we will introduce another dimension: hierarchical navigation.

A project might contain:



When working hierarchically, entering the Drums Group changes the level represented by the controller.

BANK and CHANNEL then navigate the tracks available at that level.

So we eventually gain two kinds of movement:

BANK / CHANNEL
→ across the current level

SELECT navigation
→ between levels

This becomes extremely powerful in large projects.

We will explore it properly in Chapter 17.

The Window Model Still Holds

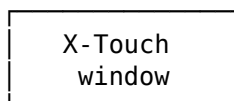
Even after adding Device Mode, Groups, Layers and other contexts, the original window idea remains useful.

The X-Touch has a limited number of physical controls.

DrivenByMoss decides what part of Bitwig those controls currently expose.

Conceptually:

Large Bitwig world



Sometimes that window contains tracks.

Sometimes devices.

Sometimes parameters.

Sometimes Layers or Drum Pads.

The hardware stays finite.

The thing it can explore does not.

A Practical Exercise

Create or open a Bitwig project with at least twelve tracks.

Start with the first eight visible on the X-Touch.

1. Press BANK >

Watch the scribble strips.

You should see the track bank move by eight positions.

2. Press BANK <

Return to the original area.

3. Press CHANNEL >

Watch the window move by one track.

4. Press CHANNEL > several more times

Notice that the eight-strip window overlaps its previous position.

5. Press CHANNEL <

Move back one track at a time.

Do this without touching the mouse.

The aim is to make:

BANK = large move

CHANNEL = small move

feel obvious rather than remembered.

A Second Exercise

Once the basic navigation is comfortable, select a track and try:

OPTION + CHANNEL <

and:

OPTION + CHANNEL >

Watch Bitwig carefully.

The selected track itself should move.

Then compare that with plain CHANNEL.

The distinction should become very clear:

CHANNEL

→ I move my view

OPTION + CHANNEL
→ I move the track

This is an excellent example of why modifiers deserve deliberate use.

The Important Idea

The X-Touch does not have eight permanent tracks.

It has an eight-channel window onto Bitwig.

In normal track-oriented operation:

BANK <
BANK >
→ move track-bank focus by 8

CHANNEL <
CHANNEL >
→ move track-bank focus by 1

With OPTION:

OPTION + BANK
→ move selected device left / right

OPTION + CHANNEL
→ move selected track left / right

And in Device Mode:

BANK
→ previous / next device

CHANNEL
→ previous / next parameter page

So the deeper mental model is:

Physical Control
+
Current Context
+
Modifier, if any
=
Current Function

For now, though, remember the simplest version:

BANK for distance. CHANNEL for precision.

Coming Next

We now know how eight physical channel strips can move through a project containing many more than eight tracks.

But navigation alone does not tell us what the controls mean at any particular moment.

The X-Touch can change the role of its V-Pots and other controls depending on what we are trying to edit.

Next:

Modes.

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Chapter 5 - Modes

The X-Touch is often described as having "lots of buttons". That is true, but it is only half the story.

The more important fact is that many of those buttons do different jobs at different times.

Understanding modes is the key to understanding the X-Touch.

Once this idea becomes familiar, the controller feels logical rather than mysterious.

What Is a Mode?

A mode changes the meaning of one or more controls.

The physical hardware never changes.

Instead, the X-Touch changes how it interprets your button presses, encoder turns and fader movements.

Think of the controller as speaking several different "languages".

Each mode uses the same hardware to perform a different set of tasks.

Field Note

A common mistake is to think that every button has exactly one purpose.

On the X-Touch, many controls are intentionally multifunctional.

Figure 5.1 illustrates this idea. Although the hardware remains exactly the same, selecting a different mode changes the role of the controls rather than the controls themselves.

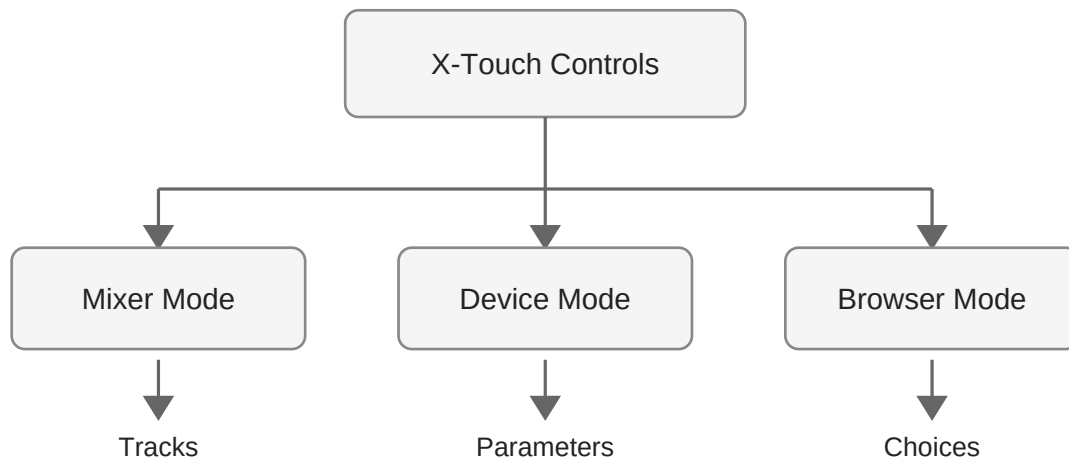


Figure 5.1 — The X-Touch uses the same physical controls in many different operating modes.

The Current Mode Is Always Visible

Fortunately, the X-Touch rarely leaves you guessing.

The scribble strips, LEDs and button illumination usually indicate the current operating mode.

Before pressing a control, take a quick look at the feedback the controller is already providing.

Experienced users develop this habit very quickly.

The Primary Modes

DrivenByMoss makes extensive use of the X-Touch's mode system.

The most frequently used modes include:

- TRACK
- SEND
- PAN/SURROUND
- PLUG-IN
- EQ
- INSTRUMENT
- USER

Each mode changes what the rotary encoders control and, in some cases, what appears on the scribble strips.

The important point is that these are not different layouts of the controller. They are simply different interpretations of the same hardware.

Throughout the remainder of this book we shall examine each of these modes in detail.

TRACK Mode

TRACK mode is the mode most users spend the majority of their time in.

The controller focuses on the Bitwig tracks themselves.

Typical operations include:

- selecting tracks
- adjusting volume
- muting
- soloing
- recording
- automation

Think of TRACK mode as the controller's "home".

Whenever you become unsure where you are, returning to TRACK mode is often a sensible starting point.

SEND Mode

SEND mode changes the rotary encoders so that they adjust send levels instead of pan.

Instead of controlling the stereo position of each track, the encoders now control how much of the signal is sent to an effects bus such as a reverb or delay.

Exactly which send is being adjusted depends upon the current Bitwig project and the selected send.

Reality Check

If turning an encoder suddenly changes a reverb or delay send instead of the pan position, the controller is almost certainly in SEND mode.

PAN/SURROUND Mode

PAN/SURROUND mode returns the rotary encoders to controlling the stereo (or surround) position of each track.

For most stereo projects this simply means moving sounds left or right within the mix.

PLUG-IN Mode

PLUG-IN mode is one of the X-Touch's most powerful capabilities.

Rather than controlling the mixer, the encoders are assigned to parameters exposed by the currently selected Bitwig device.

The scribble strips display parameter names, allowing the hardware to become a tactile extension of the software interface.

Later chapters explore this workflow in depth.

INSTRUMENT Mode

INSTRUMENT mode provides direct access to software instrument parameters.

Depending upon the selected Bitwig device, the encoders may control filter cutoff, resonance, envelopes, oscillator settings or many other synthesis controls.

The exact assignments depend entirely upon the instrument currently in focus.

USER Mode

USER mode deserves special attention.

Unlike the other operating modes, USER mode is not tied to a particular mixer function.

DrivenByMoss uses USER mode to expose additional Bitwig features.

For example, pressing USER immediately opens Bitwig's Browser. The scribble strips are repurposed to display browser information, allowing sounds and presets to be selected directly from the X-Touch.

Field Note

Because USER mode is completely software-defined, it is capable of doing far more than its name might suggest.

Many users overlook it at first, yet it quickly becomes one of the most frequently used buttons on the controller.

Modes Are Temporary

Changing mode does not permanently alter the controller.

It simply changes what the controls do at that moment.

You are free to move between modes whenever your workflow requires.

The motor faders, scribble strips and LEDs update automatically to reflect the current context.

Thinking in Modes

One of the biggest steps towards mastering the X-Touch is learning to ask a simple question:

"What mode am I in?"

Many apparent "problems" disappear the moment you realise that the controller is behaving exactly as expected—it is simply operating in a different mode.

Once this becomes second nature, the X-Touch feels far less complicated than it first appears.

Exercise

Open any Bitwig project.

Press each of the available mode buttons in turn and observe how the scribble strips, encoder assignments and button illumination change.

Do not try to memorise every function immediately.

Instead, become comfortable with the idea that the X-Touch continually adapts its controls to the task at hand.

Recognising the current mode is far more valuable than memorising individual button assignments.

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Chapter 6 - The SELECT Button

The SELECT button is arguably the most important button on the X-Touch.

New users often assume that its only purpose is to highlight a track. In fact, SELECT determines where the controller's attention is focused. Many of the X-Touch's most powerful features depend upon this simple action.

Once you understand SELECT, the behaviour of Device Mode, Browser Mode and many other functions becomes much easier to understand.

Selecting a Track

Each channel strip has its own SELECT button.

Pressing one tells the X-Touch:

"This is the track I want to work with."

Nothing is changed simply by selecting a track.

Instead, you are telling the controller where future actions should take place.

Think of SELECT as moving your attention rather than changing your project.

Field Note

The X-Touch always has a current focus.

Many commands operate on the currently selected track, so selecting the correct track before performing another action quickly becomes second nature.

Focus Rather Than Selection

Although the button is labelled SELECT, it is often more helpful to think of it as a FOCUS button.

When you select a different track:

- Device Mode follows that track.
- Browser Mode follows that track.

- Plug-in parameters follow that track.
- Instrument controls follow that track.

The selected track becomes the centre of attention for the controller.

This idea of focus appears repeatedly throughout the rest of the book.

Watching the Controller Respond

One of the strengths of DrivenByMoss is the excellent feedback it provides.

After pressing a SELECT button you may notice changes to:

- the scribble strips
- encoder assignments
- parameter names
- button illumination
- device information

These are not separate operations.

They are all consequences of changing the controller's focus.

The X-Touch immediately adapts to the newly selected track.

SELECT Comes First

As you become more familiar with the controller, a natural workflow begins to emerge:

1. Select the track.
2. Choose the required mode.
3. Perform the adjustment.

Whether you are controlling a plug-in, adjusting sends or browsing presets, the first step is almost always the same.

Press SELECT.

Reality Check

If the X-Touch appears to be controlling the "wrong" plug-in or instrument, the most likely explanation is that a different track is currently selected.

Before assuming something is broken, check which SELECT button is illuminated.

SELECT and the Motor Faders

A common misunderstanding is that selecting a track should cause the motor faders to move.

They do not.

The motor faders represent the currently visible bank of channels.

SELECT changes the controller's focus, not the mixer layout.

This distinction is important.

The faders show where the tracks are.

SELECT shows which one you are working on.

SELECT in Device Mode

Device Mode always follows the selected track.

Imagine a project containing:

- drums
- bass
- piano
- synthesizer
- vocals

Each track contains different devices.

Simply pressing SELECT on another channel instantly changes which devices the controller is connected to.

The rotary encoders, parameter names and scribble strips all update automatically.

No additional configuration is required.

SELECT in Browser Mode

Browser Mode behaves in exactly the same way.

The currently selected track determines where new devices, presets or samples will be inserted.

This makes SELECT an important part of everyday workflow.

Rather than opening the Browser and then deciding where something should go, experienced users select the destination track first.

Developing Good Habits

The most effective X-Touch users develop a very simple habit:

SELECT → Observe → Adjust

Notice that adjustment comes last.

First establish the correct focus.

Then observe what the controller is telling you.

Only then make changes.

This small change in thinking prevents many mistakes.

Field Note

One of the recurring themes throughout this book is that the X-Touch is constantly providing feedback.

The more you learn to observe that feedback before pressing buttons, the more natural the controller becomes.

A Typical Workflow

A common sequence might look like this:

1. Press SELECT on the desired track.
2. Press PLUG-IN.
3. Adjust the required parameters.
4. Press TRACK to return to mixer control.

Although simple, this workflow is repeated countless times during a typical production session.

It quickly becomes second nature.

The Bigger Picture

At first glance, SELECT appears to be a very ordinary button.

In reality, it sits at the centre of the X-Touch's operating philosophy.

The controller is always asking the same question:

"Which track am I working on?"

The SELECT button provides the answer.

Understanding this idea of focus is one of the biggest steps towards mastering the X-Touch.

Exercise

Open a Bitwig project containing several tracks.

Press the SELECT button on each channel strip in turn.

After each selection:

- enter Device Mode
- enter Browser Mode
- observe the scribble strips
- observe the encoder assignments

Notice that the hardware itself never changes.

Only the controller's focus changes.

Once you begin thinking in terms of focus rather than simply selection, many other features of the X-Touch become much easier to understand.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 7 - Displays and Feedback

The X-Touch is much more than a collection of switches, knobs and motor faders.

It is constantly communicating with you.

Almost every action performed in Bitwig is reflected somewhere on the controller. Likewise, almost every action you perform on the controller is reflected in Bitwig.

Understanding this two-way conversation is one of the keys to using the X-Touch confidently.

More Than a Remote Control

Many MIDI controllers simply send commands to the computer.

The X-Touch goes much further.

It continuously receives information from Bitwig and updates its displays, LEDs and motor faders to match the current state of the project.

Rather than being a passive controller, it becomes an extension of the software itself.

Field Note

A useful way to think about the X-Touch is that it is a window into Bitwig.

Instead of constantly looking at the computer monitor, you can often see exactly what is happening simply by glancing at the controller.

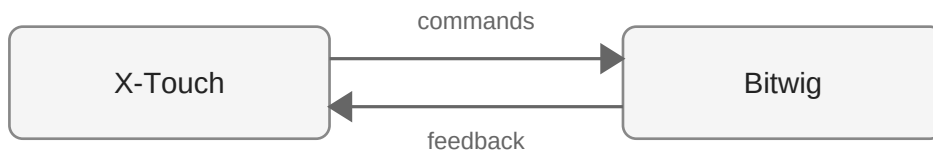


Figure 7.1 — Information flows continuously in both directions between Bitwig and the X-Touch.

Scribble Strips

The eight LCD scribble strips are one of the X-Touch's defining features.

Most of the time they display track names, but that is only one of their many roles.

Depending upon the current operating mode they may display:

- track names
- device names
- plug-in parameters
- browser entries
- send names
- automation information

The important point is not to memorise every display.

Instead, remember that the scribble strips are always showing the information that is most relevant to your current task.

LED Rings

Surrounding each rotary encoder is an LED ring.

These provide immediate visual feedback about the value being controlled.

Different parameters use different display styles.

For example:

- pan controls are centred
- continuous values fill progressively
- switches simply indicate on or off

After a short time you begin to recognise these patterns instinctively.

Often you can tell what a control is doing before you even touch it.

Illuminated Buttons

Many buttons on the X-Touch include built-in LEDs.

These indicate the current state of important functions such as:

- MUTE
- SOLO
- RECORD
- transport operations
- automation modes

The illuminated buttons are constantly reflecting the current state of Bitwig.

They are not merely indicators of what you have pressed.

Motor Faders

The motor faders provide perhaps the most dramatic form of feedback.

Whenever you load a project, switch banks or recall automation, the faders immediately move to their new positions.

This movement is not simply a visual effect.

It confirms that the controller has received updated information from Bitwig and is synchronised with the project.

Reality Check

Never try to prevent a motor fader from moving.

The motors are positioning the fader to match Bitwig's current value.

Allow them to move freely.

Feedback Builds Confidence

Imagine selecting a different track.

Within a fraction of a second you may notice:

- new track names
- different plug-in parameters
- updated LED rings
- illuminated buttons changing state

All of this happens automatically.

The controller is telling you that its focus has changed.

The more you learn to trust this feedback, the more natural the X-Touch becomes.

Observe Before You Adjust

One habit separates experienced users from beginners.

Beginners often press buttons first and try to understand the result afterwards.

Experienced users do the opposite.

Before making any adjustment they glance at the controller and ask:

- Which track is selected?
- Which mode am I in?
- What are the scribble strips showing?
- What do the LED rings indicate?
- Which buttons are illuminated?

Only then do they begin making changes.

This simple habit avoids countless mistakes.

Field Note

Throughout this book we return to a single idea:

Observe before you adjust.

The X-Touch is continually telling you what it is doing.

Learning to read that information is more valuable than memorising button combinations.

The Controller Is Always Working

Even when you are not touching it, the X-Touch is active.

Automation moves.

Track selection changes.

Devices change.

Projects load.

Throughout all of this the controller quietly updates itself to remain synchronised with Bitwig.

That constant feedback is one of the reasons the X-Touch feels so different from simpler MIDI controllers.

Looking Ahead

The next chapters explore the controller's physical controls in more detail.

As you learn about the rotary encoders, motor faders and transport controls, remember that every control performs two roles:

It accepts your input.

It also provides valuable feedback.

Understanding both roles is essential to mastering the X-Touch.

Exercise

Open any Bitwig project and spend two minutes simply observing the controller.

Without pressing any buttons, identify:

- the selected track
- the current mode
- the information shown on the scribble strips
- the LED ring positions
- illuminated buttons
- motor fader positions

Now select a different track.

Watch how the controller updates before touching anything else.

Developing the habit of reading the controller before operating it will make every subsequent chapter easier to understand.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 8 - Modifiers: SHIFT, OPTION, CONTROL and ALT

Modifiers: SHIFT, OPTION, CONTROL and ALT

So far, most of the controls in this guide have been considered one at a time.

Press a button.

Turn a V-Pot.

Move a fader.

But the X-Touch has far more functions than it has physical controls.

One of the ways DrivenByMoss solves this is through modifier buttons.

The four important modifiers are:

- SHIFT
- OPTION
- CONTROL
- ALT

Hold one of these while operating another control, and the second control may perform a different function.

If you are familiar with keyboard shortcuts, the principle is already familiar:

```
control
+
modifier
=
another function
```

The important thing is not to memorise every possible combination immediately.

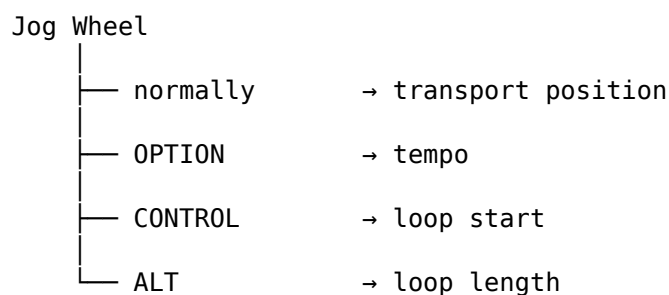
It is to understand the pattern.

One Surface, More Functions

Consider a control we already know: the Jog Wheel.

Turn it normally and it changes the transport position.

But DrivenByMoss can reinterpret that same physical movement when a modifier is held:



The Jog Wheel has not physically changed.

Its context has.

This is the same principle introduced earlier in this guide when we looked at modes.

A modifier creates a temporary context.

Modifiers Are Temporary Modes

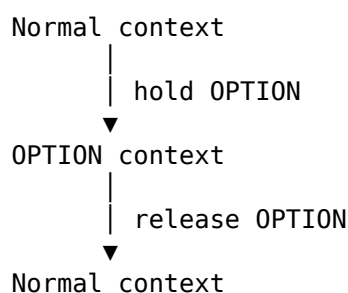
There is a useful way to think about the four modifier buttons:

Holding a modifier temporarily changes the meaning of another control.

A normal mode may remain active until you leave it.

A modifier usually lasts only while you hold its button.

Conceptually:



This makes modifiers particularly useful for secondary operations.

The main function remains immediately available, while the less frequently needed function sits behind a modifier.

SHIFT

SHIFT is probably the modifier you will encounter most often.

It frequently provides:

- a secondary version of an operation;
- finer control;
- reverse movement through a sequence.

For example, when adjusting some continuous parameters, SHIFT gives finer resolution.

With the Jog Wheel:

Jog Wheel
→ move transport position

SHIFT + Jog Wheel
→ move transport position more finely

In other contexts SHIFT selects a related secondary operation.

You will see examples throughout the following chapters.

Do not assume that SHIFT always means "fine adjustment", however.

Its exact meaning depends on the control and the current mode.

OPTION

OPTION often changes what the operation acts upon or exposes a related operation.

For example, BANK and CHANNEL normally move the controller's view through the project.

With OPTION held, DrivenByMoss can instead use those controls to move objects within the project.

Conceptually:

```

BANK / CHANNEL
├── normally
│   move the VIEW
└── OPTION
    move an OBJECT
  
```

OPTION is also important in several workflows we will meet later.

For example:

OPTION + MARKER

creates a marker.

And:

OPTION + REWIND

OPTION + FORWARD

navigate between markers.

OPTION therefore does not have one universal definition.

Think of it as:

Give this control its alternative operation.

CONTROL

CONTROL frequently exposes a structural operation or another dimension of control.

One particularly useful example appears in Device Mode.

Holding CONTROL allows the V-Pots to expose devices so that a particular device can be selected directly.

CONTROL also changes the Jog Wheel:

CONTROL + Jog Wheel

adjusts the loop start.

With SHIFT added:

CONTROL + SHIFT + Jog Wheel

provides finer adjustment.

Again, CONTROL does not have one fixed meaning.

The current mode still matters.

ALT

ALT is another modifier used to expose alternative parameter operations.

With the Jog Wheel:

ALT + Jog Wheel

adjusts loop length.

Adding SHIFT gives finer control:

ALT + SHIFT + Jog Wheel

adjusts loop length more precisely.

ALT also appears in other specialised workflows, including operations concerned with clip length.

These will make more sense when we reach the relevant chapters.

Modifiers Can Be Combined

Modifiers are not necessarily used alone.

SHIFT can be combined with another modifier.

The Jog Wheel gives us an excellent example:

Control	Function
Jog Wheel	Transport position
SHIFT + Jog Wheel	Fine transport position
OPTION + Jog Wheel	Tempo
OPTION + SHIFT + Jog Wheel	Fine tempo
CONTROL + Jog Wheel	Loop start
CONTROL + SHIFT + Jog Wheel	Fine loop start
ALT + Jog Wheel	Loop length
ALT + SHIFT + Jog Wheel	Fine loop length

There is a pattern here.

SHIFT does not change what OPTION, CONTROL or ALT selects.

Instead, it changes the precision with which that parameter is adjusted.

So:

OPTION

↓

Tempo

OPTION + SHIFT

↓

Tempo, but finer

This is exactly the sort of relationship worth learning.

It reduces the number of apparently unrelated commands you need to remember.

Modifier Patterns, Not Modifier Rules

You may already have noticed some tendencies:

SHIFT

→ secondary / finer / reverse

OPTION

→ alternative operation

CONTROL

→ structural or additional control

ALT

→ another specialised parameter

These are useful mental shortcuts.

But they are not rules.

DrivenByMoss assigns modifier combinations according to what is useful in a particular context.

For example:

OPTION + MARKER

creates a marker.

There is no useful way to derive "create marker" from a universal definition of OPTION.

You simply learn that command as part of the Marker workflow.

The purpose of recognising modifier patterns is therefore not to predict every command.

It is to make the controller easier to understand when you encounter one.

Order Matters Less Than the Combination

When this guide writes:

OPTION + MARKER

it means:

1. hold OPTION;
2. press MARKER;
3. release the buttons.

Likewise:

CONTROL + SHIFT + Jog Wheel

means:

1. hold CONTROL;
2. hold SHIFT;
3. turn the Jog Wheel;
4. release the modifiers.

The `+` notation means use these controls together.

It does not mean that you should press them as a rapid sequence.

Modifier Buttons and Modes Work Together

Modifiers do not replace modes.

They work inside them.

This distinction is important.

Suppose the controller is in Device Mode.

The V-Pots already have meanings determined by Device Mode.

Now hold OPTION.

The V-Pots can acquire another set of meanings appropriate to that mode.

So the complete context may be thought of as:

Physical control
+
Current mode
+
Held modifier
=
Current function

This extends the mental model from Chapter 3.

The function of a physical control is not necessarily inherent in the control itself.

It emerges from context.

The Display Is Your Ally

Modifier combinations can make the surface seem complicated if you try to remember everything from button labels alone.

Don't.

As discussed in Chapter 7, the displays are part of the control system.

When a modifier or mode changes what controls mean, look at the feedback the X-Touch and Bitwig provide.

The controller should be treated as a conversation:

You change context
↓
DrivenByMoss changes assignments
↓
The displays provide feedback
↓
You make the next decision

This becomes especially important in Device Mode, Browser Mode and the advanced edit modes.

Don't Learn the Modifier Table

It is tempting at this point to make a huge table containing every possible combination of:

SHIFT
OPTION
CONTROL
ALT

with every button on the X-Touch.

That would turn this guide into exactly the kind of manual we are trying to avoid.

Instead, learn modifier combinations with the task they perform.

When we study markers, we will learn:

OPTION + MARKER

because it is part of the marker workflow.

When we study Device Mode, we will learn CONTROL and OPTION combinations because they help navigate devices and parameter pages.

When we study recording, we will learn the RECORD modifiers because they make sense in the context of recording.

The modifier is not the subject.

The job you are trying to do is the subject.

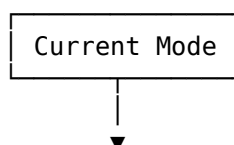
A Useful Mental Model

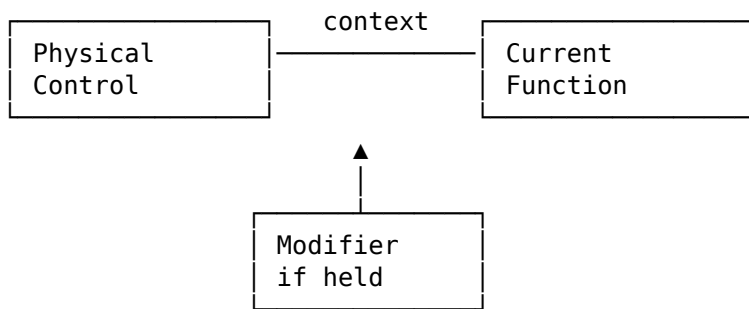
At this point we can expand our model of the X-Touch considerably.

Earlier we had:

physical control
↓
current mode
↓
current function

Now we can add modifiers:





You do not need to consciously think through this diagram every time you touch the controller.

Its purpose is to explain why the same V-Pot, button or wheel can perform so many different jobs without the surface becoming physically enormous.

What Comes Next

Now that we understand modifiers, the next chapters can use them without stopping repeatedly to explain what SHIFT, OPTION, CONTROL and ALT are.

We will see them applied to:

- V-Pots;
- motor faders;
- transport;
- the Jog Wheel;
- devices;
- Browser navigation;
- mixer modes;
- markers;
- automation;
- groups;
- recording.

The individual combinations will be introduced when they become useful.

The Important Idea

If there is one thing to take away from this chapter, it is this:

A modifier temporarily changes the context of another control.

You do not need to memorise every modifier combination.

Learn the basic controls first.

Then learn the modified versions as part of real workflows.

Once that pattern becomes familiar, SHIFT, OPTION, CONTROL and ALT stop looking like four more sets of commands to memorise.

They become something much more useful:

four ways of asking the X-Touch to do a little more.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 9 - V-Pots (Rotary Encoders)

The eight rotary encoders above the channel strips are among the most versatile controls on the X-Touch.

Behringer refers to them as V-Pots.

At first glance they look like ordinary rotary knobs. In reality, each V-Pot combines three useful features:

- a rotary encoder
- a push switch
- an LED ring

More importantly, their purpose changes according to the current mode.

A V-Pot might control pan in one moment, a send level in another, and a plug-in parameter a few seconds later.

This ability to adapt is what makes the V-Pots so powerful.

Encoders Rather Than Pots

Despite the name V-Pot, these controls are not conventional potentiometers.

A traditional potentiometer has physical end stops. Turn it fully anticlockwise and eventually it can go no further. The physical position of the knob therefore represents the current value.

The X-Touch V-Pots work differently.

They are endless rotary encoders.

You can continue turning them in either direction indefinitely.

This matters because the same physical encoder can control many different parameters without its position becoming meaningless when you change from one parameter to another.

Field Note

The word V-Pot is inherited from the Mackie Control terminology.

In practical terms, think of it as a pushable endless rotary encoder surrounded by an LED display.

Why Endless Encoders Matter

Imagine that an ordinary knob is controlling pan and is currently turned fully to the left.

You then switch modes and assign that same knob to a plug-in parameter whose current value is 80%.

What should happen?

With a conventional potentiometer there is an immediate disagreement between the physical position of the knob and the value in the software.

An endless encoder has no such problem.

The X-Touch simply changes the LED ring to show the new value.

The encoder is immediately ready to adjust it.

This is another example of the controller adapting itself to the current context.

The LED Ring

Each V-Pot is surrounded by a ring of LEDs.

As we saw in the previous chapter, this is an important part of the X-Touch's feedback system.

The LEDs provide a visual indication of the value currently assigned to the encoder.

For a pan control, for example, the display can indicate whether the signal is positioned:

- left
- centre
- right

For other parameters the LEDs may instead represent a value progressing from minimum to maximum.

The important point is that the LED ring represents the current software value, not a permanent physical position of the encoder.

Reality Check

When you change modes and the LED rings suddenly change, nothing has gone wrong.

The encoders are simply displaying the values of the parameters they now control.

Turning a V-Pot

Turning an encoder changes the currently assigned parameter.

Which parameter that happens to be depends upon context.

For example, the V-Pots may control:

- track pan
- send levels
- device parameters
- instrument parameters
- plug-in parameters
- browser navigation

You therefore cannot answer the question:

"What does this V-Pot control?"

without first answering another question:

"What mode am I in?"

This is exactly the mental model introduced earlier in the book.

The hardware remains the same.

Its meaning changes.

Pressing a V-Pot

The V-Pots can also be pressed.

This is easy to overlook when first using the X-Touch because they look primarily like rotary controls.

The push action gives DrivenByMoss another command that can be associated with each encoder.

Its precise function depends upon the current context.

In one mode it may perform an action associated with the parameter being displayed; in another, it may be used for navigation or selection.

Do not assume that pressing an encoder always performs the same operation. Instead, look at the current mode and the information displayed on the scribble strips.

Field Note

The V-Pot's push action is one of the reasons it is useful to think of the encoder and the scribble strip beneath it as a pair.

The display tells you the context.

The V-Pot lets you interact with it.

V-Pots and Scribble Strips

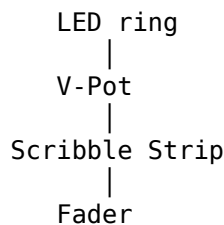
The relationship between the V-Pots and the scribble strips is fundamental.

Each encoder sits directly above a display.

That physical arrangement is deliberate.

When a mode assigns parameters to the encoders, the corresponding scribble strips can tell you what those parameters are.

Conceptually, each channel becomes:



The V-Pot provides the input.

The LED ring shows the value.

The scribble strip provides the context.

Together they form a small control surface within the larger controller.

Pan Control

One of the simplest uses of the V-Pots is track panning.

When the controller is operating in the appropriate pan mode, each encoder controls the pan position of its corresponding channel.

Turn left and the signal moves towards the left.

Turn right and it moves towards the right.

The LED ring provides immediate visual feedback.

This is a good mode in which to become familiar with the physical feel of the encoders because the relationship between movement and result is easy to understand.

Send Control

Switch to SEND mode and the same eight encoders take on a different role.

Instead of controlling pan, they can now adjust send levels.

The physical hardware has not changed.

Only the meaning assigned to it has changed.

This is precisely why endless encoders are so well suited to a controller such as the X-Touch.

The LED rings simply update to show the new values.

Device and Plug-In Control

The real power of the V-Pots becomes apparent when controlling devices.

In Device or PLUG-IN mode, the encoders can be mapped to parameters belonging to the currently selected device.

Instead of:

Pan Pan Pan Pan Pan Pan Pan Pan

you might see parameters representing:

Cutoff Reso Attack Decay Sustain Release Drive Mix

The scribble strips identify the parameters.

The LED rings show their current values.

The V-Pots adjust them.

Suddenly the X-Touch becomes much more than a mixer.

It becomes a hands-on device editor.

One Encoder, Many Jobs

This is worth emphasising.

The first V-Pot is not permanently:

Pan for Track 1

Nor is it permanently:

Parameter 1

It is simply the first encoder in the current context.

Change bank and it may control another track.

Change mode and it may control another type of parameter.

Select another device and it may acquire another purpose entirely.

Understanding this prevents one of the most common sources of confusion when learning a control surface.

Turn, Look, Listen

When adjusting a V-Pot, you have several sources of information available at once.

You can:

- feel the encoder movement
- watch the LED ring
- read the scribble strip
- observe the corresponding change in Bitwig
- hear the result

That combination makes the V-Pots particularly effective for tasks such as sound design.

Instead of concentrating entirely on a graphical plug-in interface, you can begin to adjust parameters by ear.

Field Note

Sometimes the best display in a music production system is no display at all.

Once you know which parameter a V-Pot controls, try listening to the result rather than watching the computer screen.

V-Pots and Focus

The previous chapters introduced two important questions:

"What mode am I in?"

and:

"Which track is selected?"

V-Pots add a third:

"What parameter is this encoder controlling?"

Fortunately, you normally do not need to remember the answer.

The X-Touch tells you.

Read the scribble strip.

Look at the LED ring.

Then make the adjustment.

Once again:

Observe before you adjust.

The Bigger Picture

The V-Pots demonstrate almost everything that makes the X-Touch different from a simple MIDI controller.

They are:

- context-sensitive
- bidirectional
- multifunctional
- visually informative
- integrated with the current selection and mode

A single row of eight encoders can therefore control a remarkable amount of Bitwig.

The trick is not to memorise every possible assignment.

The trick is to understand the context.

Once you do that, the V-Pots become some of the most intuitive controls on the entire surface.

Exercise

Open a Bitwig project containing several tracks and devices.

Begin with the V-Pots controlling pan.

Turn several encoders and observe both the LED rings and Bitwig.

Next, switch to SEND mode.

Notice how the LED rings immediately change to represent the send values.

Finally, select a track containing a device and enter the appropriate device or plug-in mode.

Read the parameter names shown on the scribble strips and adjust several of them using the V-Pots.

Throughout the exercise, keep asking three questions:

1. Which track is selected?
2. Which mode am I in?
3. What parameter does this V-Pot currently represent?

Do not try to memorise the assignments.

Instead, practise reading the controller until the answer becomes obvious from the feedback it provides.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 10 - Motor Faders

The nine motorised faders are probably the first thing most people notice about the X-Touch.

Eight belong to the channel strips, while the ninth sits separately as the master fader.

Move a fader and Bitwig responds.

Change a value in Bitwig and the fader moves by itself.

Switch banks and all eight channel faders can spring into new positions almost simultaneously.

It is impressive to watch, but the motors are not there simply for show.

They solve one of the fundamental problems of using physical controls with software.

The Problem with Ordinary Faders

Imagine a simple MIDI controller with eight conventional faders.

The first fader is controlling Track 1, whose volume is currently fairly high.

Now switch to another bank.

That same physical fader might now control Track 9, whose volume is much lower.

The hardware fader is still sitting near the top of its travel, while the software value it represents is somewhere near the bottom.

The two disagree.

Different controllers solve this problem in different ways, often using techniques such as value pickup or soft takeover.

The X-Touch takes a much more direct approach.

It simply moves the fader.

Field Note

Motorisation means that the physical position of a fader can always reflect the value currently held by Bitwig.

The hardware adapts to the software rather than asking you to compensate for the difference.

Faders as Input and Output

It is tempting to think of a fader purely as an input device.

You move it.

Bitwig receives a new value.

But an X-Touch motor fader works in both directions.

You move the fader

↓
Bitwig

Bitwig
↓

The fader moves

This makes the fader both a control and a display.

Its position is information.

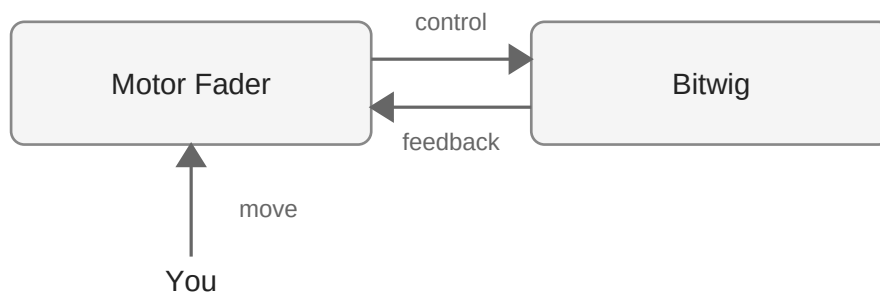


Figure 9.1 — The motor fader is both an input control and a physical display of Bitwig's current value.

Eight Channel Faders

The eight main faders correspond to the eight channels in the current bank.

In a simple project this might mean:

Fader	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Track	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8

Move to the next bank and those same physical faders might represent:

Fader	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Track	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16

As soon as the bank changes, the motors reposition the faders to show the values belonging to the new tracks.

This is the physical manifestation of the banking system introduced in Chapter 4.

Banking Makes Sense of the Motors

Without motorisation, changing banks would create an immediate mismatch between the physical faders and the newly displayed tracks.

With motorised faders, the transition is obvious.

Press a bank control and three things happen together:

- the visible tracks change
- the scribble strips update
- the faders move to their new positions

The X-Touch has physically reconfigured itself for the new bank.

Reality Check

If several faders suddenly move when you change banks, nothing unexpected has happened.

They are simply taking up the positions belonging to the newly displayed tracks.

Touch-Sensitive Faders

The X-Touch faders are not merely motorised.

They are also touch-sensitive.

The controller can detect when your finger is resting on a fader.

This is particularly important when working with automation.

There is a significant difference between:

"The fader is at this position."

and:

"The user is currently touching the fader."

Knowing when you have physically taken control allows Bitwig and the controller to behave appropriately during automation operations.

We will encounter this distinction again when we look at automation in more detail.

Do Not Fight the Motors

When a motor fader moves by itself, let it move.

Do not hold it in position or deliberately push against the motor.

The movement is feedback from Bitwig.

The fader is trying to show you the value that currently exists in the project.

If you want to change that value, wait for the fader to settle and then move it normally.

Field Note

A moving fader is not the X-Touch doing something to your mix.

It is the X-Touch showing you something that has already happened in Bitwig.

That distinction is important.

Automation Comes Alive

Motor faders become particularly valuable when automation is playing.

A track's volume may change continuously during a song.

On a conventional controller, the physical fader would remain stationary while the software value moved.

On the X-Touch, the motor fader can follow those changes.

You can therefore see the automation physically happening.

A vocal may rise slightly during a chorus.

A pad may fade away.

An effects return may increase during a transition.

The corresponding faders can move as those changes occur.

This is one of the moments when the distinction between software and hardware begins to disappear.

Writing Automation

Touch sensitivity and motorisation become especially useful when writing automation.

You can grab a fader and perform a level change naturally with your hand rather than drawing an automation curve with a mouse.

Bitwig records the movement.

When the automation is played back, the fader can reproduce it.

The physical gesture has become part of the project.

For many users this feels much closer to working on a traditional mixing console.

The Master Fader

To the right of the eight channel faders is a ninth motorised fader.

This is the master fader.

Unlike the channel faders, it is not part of the eight-channel banking system.

Its role is associated with the master output rather than whichever eight tracks happen to be visible.

This separation is useful because the master remains available while you move through the project's channel banks.

Faders and SELECT

Remember the distinction introduced in Chapter 6.

A fader represents a track within the current bank.

The SELECT button identifies the track that currently has your attention.

Moving a fader does not mean that you have changed the controller's focus.

Likewise, selecting a track does not mean that its fader must move.

These are different concepts:

Fader position → Track level

SELECT → Current focus

Keeping those two ideas separate prevents a surprising amount of confusion.

Faders as Feedback

Chapter 7 described the various ways in which the X-Touch communicates with you.

Motor faders are perhaps its most physical form of feedback.

You do not have to read a number to know roughly where a track's level is.

You can simply look at the fader.

In fact, you can often see the overall shape of a mix by looking across all eight faders at once.

That is something a row of numerical values on a computer screen does not communicate nearly as naturally.

Mixing with Your Hands

This is where the X-Touch begins to change the experience of using a DAW.

With a mouse, adjusting several track levels usually means moving one virtual fader at a time.

With the X-Touch you have eight physical faders beneath your fingers.

You can bring one track down while raising another.

You can balance several channels together.

You can make small changes without repeatedly pointing at different objects on the screen.

Mixing becomes a physical activity again.

Field Note

The advantage of physical faders is not simply that they replace virtual ones.

The real advantage is that you can control several things at once.

That is something a mouse is fundamentally bad at doing.

Trust the Position

A useful habit is to trust what the faders are showing you.

When you change banks, allow them to settle.

When automation is playing, watch them move.

When you open an existing project, notice how the X-Touch reconstructs the mix physically in front of you.

The faders are not approximations of the software state.

They are part of the feedback system that keeps the controller and Bitwig synchronised.

The Bigger Picture

The motor faders demonstrate the same principle we encountered with the V-Pots.

The X-Touch does not expect its physical controls to have one permanent meaning.

Instead, the hardware adapts itself to the current context.

The V-Pots achieve this by having no fixed physical position and using LED rings to display their values.

The faders achieve it differently.

They physically move.

Two different engineering solutions serve the same underlying idea:

The controller should reflect the current state of the software.

That principle lies at the heart of the X-Touch.

Exercise

Open a Bitwig project containing more than eight tracks.

First, look at the positions of the eight channel faders.

Change to the next bank and watch what happens.

Notice how the scribble strips and faders update together.

Move several faders and confirm that the corresponding Bitwig levels follow them.

Now change those same levels using Bitwig's mixer and watch the X-Touch faders respond.

If the project contains volume automation, play a section containing that automation and observe the appropriate fader.

Finally, return to the first bank.

The faders should return to the positions belonging to those tracks.

The aim of this exercise is not simply to practise moving faders.

It is to experience the central idea of this chapter:

The motor faders are both controls and physical displays.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 11 - Transport Controls

After learning about modes, selection, V-Pots and motor faders, the Transport section of the X-Touch may come as something of a relief.

Most of it does exactly what you expect.

The familiar REWIND, FAST FORWARD, STOP, PLAY and RECORD buttons provide immediate control over Bitwig's transport.

But the Transport section is more than a convenient replacement for clicking Play on the computer screen.

Combined with the jog wheel and navigation controls, it allows you to move around a project, locate a position and control playback without repeatedly reaching for the mouse.

The Five Transport Buttons

At the bottom-right of the X-Touch are five large transport buttons:

- REWIND
- FAST FORWARD
- STOP
- PLAY
- RECORD

Their layout deliberately resembles the transport controls found on tape machines, hardware recorders and traditional mixing systems.

If you have used almost any audio equipment before, they should feel immediately familiar.

PLAY

Press PLAY to start playback from the current position.

Pressing PLAY is one of the simplest examples of the two-way relationship between the X-Touch and Bitwig.

The controller sends the command.

Bitwig begins playback.

The X-Touch then reflects the resulting transport state through its illuminated controls and displays.

Even here, the controller is both issuing a command and providing feedback.

STOP

Press STOP to stop playback.

Simple as this sounds, having a large physical STOP button becomes surprisingly valuable.

There is no need to locate a small transport control on the computer screen.

Your hand quickly learns where STOP is, and after a while you may find yourself using it without looking at the controller at all.

Field Note

Transport controls are particularly good candidates for developing muscle memory.

Unlike context-sensitive controls, their basic purpose remains predictable.

Once your hand knows where PLAY and STOP are, controlling playback becomes almost unconscious.

RECORD

The RECORD button controls Bitwig's recording transport.

Recording involves more than simply pressing one button — tracks must be armed correctly and Bitwig must be ready to record — but once those conditions are satisfied, RECORD gives you direct physical control over the process.

This becomes especially useful when recording instruments or automation.

Instead of preparing everything and then reaching for the mouse, you can remain focused on the performance.

Reality Check

Pressing RECORD does not automatically make every track record.

Track arming and the transport's recording state are separate concepts.

Always check that the intended track is correctly armed before beginning a take.

REWIND and FAST FORWARD

The REWIND and FAST FORWARD buttons allow you to move backwards and forwards through the project.

Their exact behaviour is governed by the integration between the X-Touch, DrivenByMoss and Bitwig, but their purpose is straightforward:

Move the current playback position.

For coarse navigation they provide a quick way of moving through the project without touching the mouse.

For more deliberate positioning, however, another control becomes particularly useful.

The Jog Wheel

The large wheel above the transport buttons is the jog wheel.

It provides a physical way of moving through the project timeline.

Turn it one way to move backwards.

Turn it the other way to move forwards.

Unlike clicking somewhere on a graphical timeline, the jog wheel encourages you to think in terms of movement from the current position.

This can feel much more natural when searching for the beginning of a phrase, a transition or a particular point in a recording.

Coarse and Fine Navigation

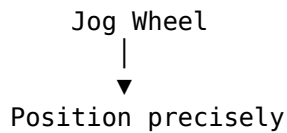
The transport buttons and jog wheel complement each other.

Think of them broadly as two approaches to navigation:

REWIND / FAST FORWARD



Move quickly



You do not need to choose one method exclusively.

A typical workflow might involve moving rapidly towards the required part of the project and then using the jog wheel to refine the position.

Field Note

The most useful navigation method is usually the one that requires the least thought.

Use the transport buttons when you want to move.

Use the jog wheel when you want to arrive somewhere specific.

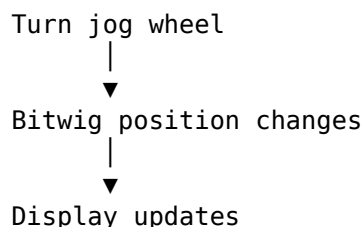
The Time Display

Navigation becomes much more useful when you can see where you are.

The X-Touch's main display provides positional information that helps you keep track of the current location within the project.

As you move through the timeline, the display updates accordingly.

Once again, input and feedback work together:



You move.

The controller tells you where you have arrived.

Transport and the Computer Screen

It is worth noticing how many routine mouse movements disappear once the transport controls become familiar.

Without a control surface, a typical editing or recording session may involve repeatedly moving the pointer between:

- the arrangement
- the mixer

- device controls
- the transport
- the timeline

With the X-Touch, many transport operations remain permanently beneath your hand.

You can keep the computer screen focused on the information that actually needs a graphical display.

Transport While Mixing

Physical transport controls are especially useful while mixing.

Imagine adjusting several faders during playback.

You hear something you want to investigate.

Instead of moving your hand away from the controller and locating Bitwig's transport:

1. Press STOP.
2. Navigate backwards.
3. Press PLAY.
4. Listen again.
5. Continue adjusting the mix.

Your attention remains on the sound and the controller rather than shifting repeatedly between hardware and screen.

This may seem like a small improvement.

Repeated hundreds of times during a session, it becomes a substantial one.

Transport While Recording

The same principle applies when recording.

A typical sequence might be:

1. Select the required track.
2. Arm it for recording.
3. Navigate to the starting position.
4. Press RECORD.
5. Perform the part.
6. Press STOP.
7. Return to the beginning of the take.
8. Press PLAY to review it.

The computer is still doing all the recording.

The X-Touch simply allows the routine operations surrounding that recording to happen physically.

That keeps your attention where it belongs: on the performance.

Visual Feedback

The transport section also reinforces the principle introduced in Chapter 7:

Observe before you adjust.

Illuminated transport buttons tell you about the current state.

The position display tells you where you are.

Bitwig's own interface provides further confirmation.

Do not treat the physical controls and the software interface as two independent systems.

They are two views of the same transport state.

Developing Muscle Memory

Transport is one of the best places to begin operating the X-Touch without constantly looking at it.

The five transport buttons are large, consistently positioned and easy to distinguish by location.

With practice, your hand begins to find them automatically.

The jog wheel is equally unmistakable.

This is an important step towards a more tactile workflow.

You stop thinking:

"Where is the Play button?"

and simply press it.

That small change is one of the reasons a control surface can make a DAW feel more like an instrument and less like a computer application.

A Step Towards Mouse-Lite

The Transport section gives us an early glimpse of the workflow we shall explore more fully in Chapter 13.

The aim is not necessarily to eliminate the mouse.

There are many tasks for which a mouse remains an excellent tool.

The aim is to stop reaching for it when a physical control is faster, clearer or more natural.

Starting playback is a perfect example.

You could move the pointer to Bitwig's PLAY button and click it.

But when a large physical PLAY button is already beneath your hand, why would you?

Field Note

A Mouse-Lite workflow is not about refusing to use the mouse.

It is about using the most appropriate tool for each job.

For transport operations, that tool is very often the X-Touch.

The Bigger Picture

The Transport section may be one of the least mysterious parts of the X-Touch, but it plays an important role in the overall workflow.

The faders allow you to mix.

The V-Pots allow you to adjust parameters.

SELECT establishes focus.

The displays tell you what is happening.

And the Transport section lets you control when it happens.

Together, these controls begin to form a complete working environment.

You are no longer simply controlling individual Bitwig parameters.

You are operating the session.

Exercise

Open an existing Bitwig project.

For the duration of this exercise, avoid using the mouse for transport operations.

Using only the X-Touch:

1. Start playback.
2. Stop playback.
3. Move backwards through the project.
4. Move forwards through the project.
5. Use the jog wheel to locate a particular section.
6. Start playback from that position.
7. Stop again.

Now choose a short section of the project and practise repeatedly navigating to it and playing it.

Do not concentrate on speed.

Instead, concentrate on allowing your hand to learn where the transport controls are.

The goal is to reach the point where PLAY, STOP and basic navigation no longer require conscious thought.

That is one more step towards a Mouse-Free — or Mouse-Lite — workflow.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

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Chapter 12 - Device Mode

So far, much of our attention has been focused on the mixer.

We have selected tracks, changed banks, adjusted levels, controlled pan and navigated through the project.

But a Bitwig track is much more than a channel in a mixer.

It may contain instruments, audio effects and other devices, each with parameters of its own.

Device Mode is where the X-Touch begins to reach inside the selected track and give you physical control over those devices.

From Mixer to Device

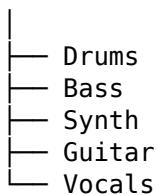
In normal mixer operation, the eight channel strips represent tracks.

Conceptually, the controller looks something like this:

X-Touch



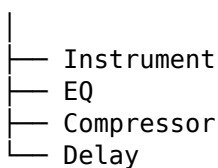
Tracks



Device Mode takes us one level deeper.

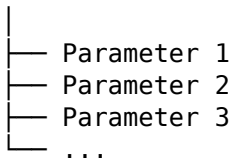
A selected track might contain:

Synth Track



Once a device is selected, we can go deeper again:

Selected Device



This hierarchy is one of the most useful ways to understand Device Mode.

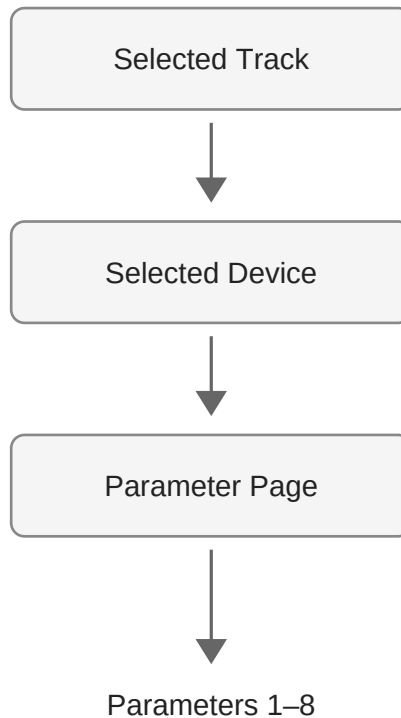


Figure 11.1 — Device Mode moves the controller's focus from the selected track, through its devices, to the parameters of the selected device.

SELECT Comes First

Chapter 6 introduced the idea of focus.

Device Mode is where that idea becomes particularly important.

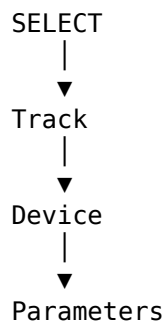
Before controlling a device, the X-Touch needs to know which track contains it.

The first step is therefore familiar:

Select the track.

Once the track is selected, Device Mode can operate on the devices belonging to that track.

This gives us a simple hierarchy:



If Device Mode appears to be showing the wrong instrument or effect, work backwards through that hierarchy.

Start by checking the selected track.

Reality Check

When the X-Touch appears to be controlling the "wrong" device, do not immediately start pressing mode buttons.

First check which track is selected.

The controller may be doing exactly what it should — just on a different track.

A Track Can Contain Many Devices

A Bitwig track can contain an entire chain of devices.

For example:

Polysynth → EQ+ → Compressor → Delay+

Each device has a different purpose and therefore exposes different parameters.

Selecting the Polysynth might give you controls relating to synthesis.

Selecting the EQ might give you frequency and gain controls.

Selecting the delay might expose delay time, feedback and mix.

The same eight V-Pots can control all of them.

The hardware remains unchanged.

The context changes.

The Scribble Strips Become Essential

This is where the scribble strips really earn their keep.

In mixer operation, an encoder's purpose may be fairly predictable.

In Device Mode, it could represent almost anything.

One encoder might control:

- filter cutoff
- resonance
- attack
- release
- frequency
- gain
- feedback
- wet/dry mix

Trying to memorise those assignments would be hopeless.

Fortunately, you do not need to.

The scribble strips tell you what the controls currently represent.

This is precisely the behaviour we explored in Chapter 7.

Observe before you adjust.

In Device Mode, that principle becomes essential.

The V-Pots Become Parameter Controls

Chapter 8 introduced the V-Pots as context-sensitive rotary encoders.

Device Mode demonstrates why that design is so useful.

Suppose the currently selected device exposes eight parameters:

Cutoff Reso Attack Decay Sustain Release Drive Mix

The eight V-Pots can immediately become physical controls for those parameters.

Turn an encoder and the corresponding value changes in Bitwig.

The LED ring provides visual feedback.

The scribble strip tells you what the parameter is.

Suddenly, a software device begins to feel rather more like a piece of hardware.

More Than Eight Parameters

Of course, most devices have considerably more than eight parameters.

The X-Touch only has eight V-Pots.

This creates a familiar problem.

Fortunately, we have already encountered the solution.

Banking.

Just as eight channel strips can provide access to many tracks, eight encoders can provide access to many parameters.

Think of the device parameters as pages:

Page 1

P1 P2 P3 P4 P5 P6 P7 P8

Page 2

P9 P10 P11 P12 P13 P14 P15 P16

Page 3

P17 P18 P19 P20 P21 P22 P23 P24

Move to another parameter page and the V-Pots acquire new assignments.

The scribble strips update.

The LED rings update.

Once again, the controller reconfigures itself around the current context.

Field Note

Parameter pages are really just another form of banking.

You already understand the underlying idea from Chapter 4.

Eight physical controls provide a window onto a much larger collection of software controls.

Devices, Parameters and Pages

It is useful to keep three separate concepts in mind:

Device



Parameter Page



Eight Parameters

First you choose what device you want to control.

Then you choose which page of its parameters you want to see.

The eight V-Pots then control the parameters on that page.

This structure may sound complicated when described in words.

In use, it quickly becomes natural because the X-Touch continually updates its displays as you navigate.

Follow the Feedback

Imagine moving from a synthesizer to a delay.

The controller may immediately change:

- parameter names on the scribble strips
- LED ring positions
- encoder functions

Nothing has physically moved except perhaps your hand.

Yet the entire row of V-Pots now represents a different piece of software.

This is exactly why Chapter 7 placed so much emphasis on feedback.

In Device Mode, the displays are not merely helpful.

They are part of the interface.

Editing by Ear

One of the most enjoyable aspects of Device Mode is that it can change how you interact with plug-ins and instruments.

Consider adjusting a filter cutoff with a mouse.

Your attention naturally goes to the computer screen.

You locate the graphical control.

You watch the pointer.

You watch the value change.

With the X-Touch, you can instead:

1. Read the scribble strip.
2. Place your hand on the appropriate V-Pot.
3. Turn it.
4. Listen.

Once you know which control you are adjusting, there may be very little reason to keep watching the screen.

Field Note

Device Mode is not necessarily about reproducing every control from a plug-in interface on the X-Touch.

Its real value is providing immediate physical access to the parameters you actually want to adjust.

Hardware Feel from Software Instruments

This becomes particularly interesting with software instruments.

A synthesizer may exist entirely inside the computer, but Device Mode gives some of its controls a physical presence.

Instead of dragging a virtual filter knob, you turn an encoder.

Instead of watching an envelope value, you adjust it while listening.

The software has not changed.

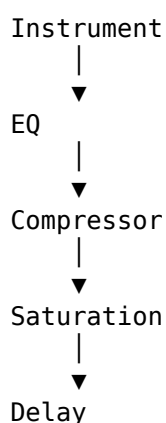
What has changed is your relationship with it.

This is one of the ways in which a control surface can make working with a DAW feel less like operating software and more like playing an instrument.

Device Chains

As projects become more complex, tracks often contain several devices.

For example:



Device Mode allows you to move through that chain and concentrate on one device at a time.

The important thing is not to memorise where every device lives.

Instead, maintain the mental hierarchy:

Track → Device → Parameter Page → Parameter

Whenever you become lost, move back up that hierarchy.

Which track?

Which device?

Which page?

Which parameter?

The displays provide the answers.

Device Mode and Focus

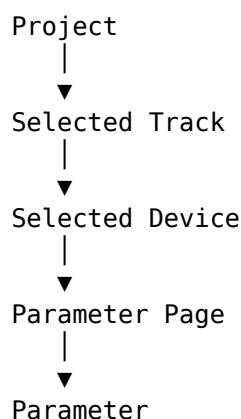
We can now expand the idea introduced in Chapter 6.

SELECT establishes the track focus.

Device Mode establishes the device focus.

Parameter navigation establishes the parameter focus.

Conceptually:



This is not just a description of Device Mode.

It is a useful mental model for navigating Bitwig itself.

Returning to the Mixer

Device Mode is temporary.

Entering it does not alter the structure of your project or permanently reassign the X-Touch.

When you have finished editing the device, you can return to normal mixer operation.

The V-Pots resume their mixer-related roles.

The scribble strips return to displaying the appropriate mixer information.

The controller has not changed identity.

It has simply changed context again.

Device Mode and the Mouse

Device Mode also represents another significant step towards our Mouse-Free — or Mouse-Lite — workflow.

Without a control surface, editing a device often involves:

- locating the device on screen
- locating the required parameter
- moving the pointer to it
- dragging the control
- moving to the next parameter
- repeating the process

With the X-Touch, once the correct device and parameter page are selected, eight physical controls are immediately available.

That does not mean the graphical interface becomes useless.

Some devices contain complex visual information that is much easier to understand on screen.

The point is not to eliminate the screen or the mouse.

The point is to stop depending upon them when a physical control provides a better way to work.

Field Note

Mouse-Lite does not mean "never touch the mouse".

It means:

Use the mouse when it is the best tool — not simply because it is the only tool you know.

The Bigger Picture

Device Mode brings together almost every concept we have encountered so far.

Banks and Channels taught us how a limited number of physical controls can represent a larger system.

Modes taught us that controls change meaning according to context.

SELECT taught us about focus.

Displays and Feedback taught us to read the controller.

V-Pots gave us context-sensitive parameter controls.

Device Mode combines all of those ideas.

That is why it can initially appear complicated.

It is also why, once the earlier concepts are understood, it becomes surprisingly logical.

You do not need to memorise the entire X-Touch.

You simply need to know where you are.

Exercise

Open a Bitwig project containing a track with several devices.

Select that track using the X-Touch.

Enter Device Mode and observe the scribble strips before touching any controls.

Identify the currently selected device.

Now:

1. Locate a parameter shown on one of the scribble strips.
2. Adjust it with the corresponding V-Pot.
3. Watch the LED ring respond.
4. Listen to the result.
5. Move to another parameter page if one is available.
6. Observe how all eight encoder assignments change.
7. Select another device in the chain.
8. Observe how the scribble strips and LED rings change again.

Finally, select a completely different track.

Notice how the available devices change with it.

Throughout the exercise, keep the hierarchy in mind:

Track → Device → Parameter Page → Parameter

If you become lost, do not start pressing buttons at random.

Work backwards through the hierarchy and read the feedback the X-Touch is already providing.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

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Chapter 13 - Browser Mode

Up to this point, most of our work with the X-Touch has involved controlling things that already exist in the project.

We have selected tracks.

We have adjusted levels.

We have navigated devices and changed their parameters.

But sooner or later we need something new.

Perhaps we want to add an instrument.

Perhaps we need an audio effect.

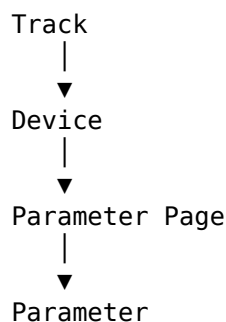
Perhaps we want to replace a preset or search for a particular sound.

This is where Browser Mode becomes particularly interesting.

Instead of reaching immediately for the mouse, we can begin exploring Bitwig's Browser directly from the X-Touch.

From Control to Creation

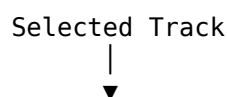
Device Mode allows us to move down through a hierarchy:

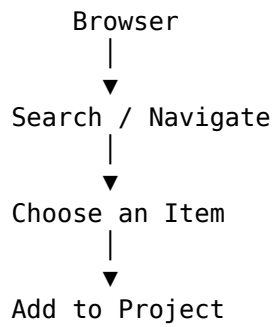


Browser Mode performs a different job.

It allows us to choose something that is not yet part of that hierarchy.

Conceptually:





This is an important change.

The X-Touch is no longer merely editing the project.

It is helping us build it.

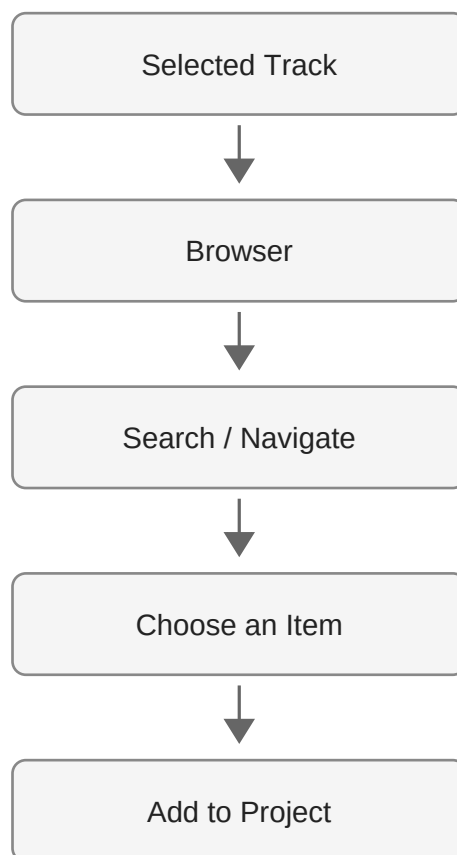


Figure 12.1 — Browser Mode extends the workflow from selecting a destination to finding and adding new material.

SELECT Still Comes First

Once again, the SELECT button plays a central role.

Before opening the Browser, ask:

"Where do I want the new item to go?"

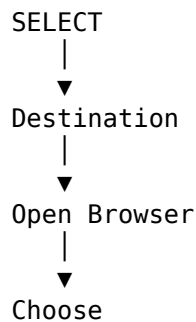
The selected track establishes the context in which browsing takes place.

This is the same idea introduced in Chapter 6.

Selection is not simply about highlighting something.

It establishes focus.

A useful working sequence is therefore:



That first step prevents a surprising amount of confusion.

Reality Check

Before browsing for a new device or sound, check the selected track.

Finding exactly what you wanted and then discovering that you were working in the wrong place is considerably less entertaining than it sounds.

Opening the Browser

With DrivenByMoss, the X-Touch provides access to Bitwig's Browser without requiring you to begin the operation with the mouse.

When Browser Mode is entered, the role of the controller changes.

Controls that previously represented mixer or device parameters can now become navigation and selection controls.

The scribble strips change accordingly.

This should already feel familiar.

The hardware has not changed.

The context has.

Read the Scribble Strips

Browser Mode is another excellent demonstration of why the scribble strips matter.

When browsing, they may present information relating to the available choices rather than track or device parameters.

The labels on the controller therefore become your guide.

Do not assume that an encoder still performs the function it had a few seconds earlier.

Read first.

Then turn or press.

The principle remains:

Observe before you adjust.

Although in Browser Mode we might reasonably amend that to:

Observe before you choose.

Navigation Rather Than Parameter Control

In Device Mode, turning a V-Pot normally changes a value.

Browser Mode can give those same controls a different purpose.

Now an encoder may be involved in navigating choices rather than adjusting a continuous parameter.

This distinction is important.

In one context:

Turn V-Pot
|
▼
Change Parameter

In another:

Turn V-Pot
|
▼
Navigate Choices

The physical action is identical.

Its meaning is determined by the current mode.

This is precisely the mental model we established much earlier in the book.

Narrowing the Search

Bitwig's Browser can contain a huge amount of material.

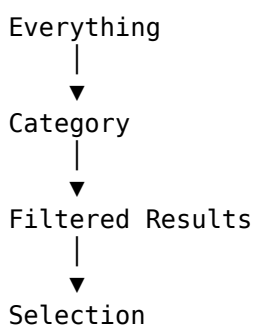
Depending upon your installation, that may include:

- instruments
- audio effects
- note effects
- presets
- samples
- plug-ins
- other device content

Browsing everything at once would quickly become unwieldy.

The useful approach is to narrow the available choices until the required item becomes easy to locate.

Think of browsing as a funnel:



Each decision reduces the number of possibilities.

This is much more effective than treating the Browser as one enormous list.

Browsing Is Contextual

The contents of the Browser depend upon what you are doing.

If you are adding an instrument, the useful choices are different from those involved in adding an audio effect.

If you are choosing a preset, the available material depends upon the device.

If you are looking for a sample, you are dealing with another type of content again.

This means Browser Mode should not be thought of as:

"A list of everything Bitwig contains."

It is better understood as:

"A way of choosing something appropriate for the current context."

That makes the Browser much less intimidating.

Choosing an Item

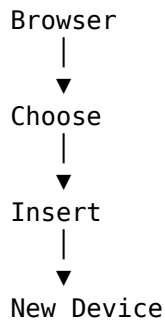
Eventually, browsing leads to a choice.

Once the required item has been located, it can be selected and inserted or loaded in the appropriate context.

At this point the Browser has done its job.

The new item becomes part of the project.

Conceptually:



And something rather satisfying can happen next.

The workflow can move naturally back into Device Mode.

Browser Mode Meets Device Mode

Suppose you want to add a delay to a track.

The workflow might be:

1. SELECT the destination track.
2. Open the Browser.
3. Navigate to an appropriate delay.
4. Choose it.
5. Return to Device Mode.
6. Adjust its parameters with the V-Pots.

Notice what has happened.

You have gone from:

"I want a delay."

to:

"I am adjusting the delay."

without the mouse necessarily being the centre of the operation.

This is where the individual chapters of the book begin joining together into complete workflows.

Field Note

Browser Mode becomes much more powerful when you stop thinking of it as an isolated feature.

It is the bridge between deciding that you need something and then controlling what you have added.

Browsing for Instruments

The same principle applies when building an instrument track.

Imagine starting with an appropriate empty track.

You can:

1. Select the track.
2. Enter the Browser.
3. Locate an instrument.
4. Choose it.
5. Enter Device Mode.
6. Begin adjusting its parameters.

The Browser finds the instrument.

Device Mode controls it.

SELECT establishes where the whole operation takes place.

Three apparently separate features become a single workflow.

Browsing for Presets

Browser Mode is equally useful when searching for sounds rather than devices.

Suppose you already have a synthesizer loaded but want another preset.

Instead of thinking:

"I need to operate the Browser."

think:

"I want another sound for this device."

The Browser is simply the mechanism that helps you find it.

This distinction matters because it keeps your attention on the musical task rather than the software operation.

Browsing with Your Ears

Browsing sounds presents an interesting opportunity.

Computer-based browsing naturally encourages us to look.

We read names.

We study categories.

We watch lists move up and down the screen.

But ultimately, when choosing a sound, the important question is usually:

"Does this sound right?"

The more navigation you can perform from the controller, the easier it becomes to keep your attention on listening rather than pointing and clicking.

Field Note

Names and categories help you find sounds.

Your ears decide whether they belong in the music.

The Screen Still Matters

A Mouse-Lite workflow does not mean pretending the computer display has suddenly become useless.

Bitwig's Browser can present detailed information that simply cannot fit onto the X-Touch's scribble strips.

There will be occasions when looking at the screen is clearly the most efficient way to understand what is available.

That is perfectly fine.

The aim is not:

"Never look at Bitwig."

The aim is:

"Do not reach for the mouse automatically."

If the X-Touch can perform the operation comfortably, use it.

If the graphical Browser is better suited to the task, use that.

The two approaches complement each other.

Do Not Memorise the Browser

As with Device Mode, there is little value in trying to memorise every possible Browser state.

The available choices will change.

Your installed devices may change.

Your plug-ins may change.

Your presets and samples may change.

The useful skill is not remembering where everything lives.

It is understanding how to navigate what is currently in front of you.

Read the feedback.

Make a choice.

Observe the result.

Continue.

When You Become Lost

Browser Mode can initially feel more complicated than the mixer because the controls are being used in a less familiar way.

If you become unsure what is happening, return to the questions we have used throughout the book:

- Which track is selected?
- Which mode am I in?
- What are the scribble strips showing?
- What does the current control represent?

Do not press controls randomly in an attempt to escape.

Read the controller first.

The information you need is often already there.

Reality Check

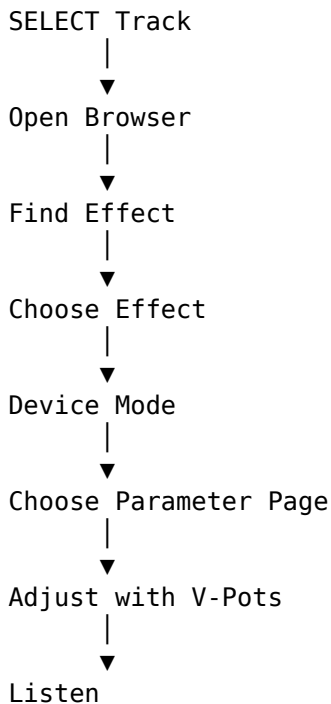
When a control appears to have stopped doing its usual job, check whether you are still in Browser Mode.

A V-Pot that normally adjusts pan cannot adjust pan while it is busy helping you navigate the Browser.

Building a Workflow

We can now combine much of what we have learned into a single sequence.

Imagine adding and adjusting a new effect:



This is more than a collection of X-Touch features.

It is a workflow.

That distinction is important.

The purpose of learning the controller is not to become good at pressing its buttons.

The purpose is to make the controller disappear into the process of making music.

Another Step Towards Mouse-Lite

Browser Mode brings us very close to the subject of the final chapter.

Earlier we used the X-Touch to manipulate a project.

Now we can also begin adding things to it.

That removes another common reason for immediately reaching for the mouse.

Again, the goal is not mouse avoidance for its own sake.

A mouse remains extremely useful for detailed editing, graphical operations and many other tasks.

But opening a Browser, finding something, selecting it and then adjusting it are operations that can increasingly take place from the control surface.

The mouse becomes an option rather than a reflex.

The Bigger Picture

Browser Mode completes an important chain of ideas.

SELECT establishes where we are working.

Browser Mode helps us find something to add.

Device Mode lets us control what we have added.

V-Pots provide the physical controls.

Displays and Feedback tell us what those controls currently mean.

Motor Faders and Transport allow the rest of the session to continue around us.

The individual features of the X-Touch are beginning to disappear.

In their place we are developing workflows.

And that brings us naturally to the final chapter.

Exercise

Open a Bitwig project containing a suitable track.

For this exercise, resist the temptation to begin with the mouse.

First:

1. Select the destination track from the X-Touch.
2. Enter Browser Mode.
3. Observe the scribble strips before touching anything else.
4. Navigate through the available choices.
5. Choose an instrument, effect or other suitable item.
6. Confirm that it has been added in the intended location.

Now move directly into Device Mode.

7. Identify the newly added device.
8. Locate a useful parameter.
9. Adjust it using a V-Pot.
10. Listen to the result.

Finally, return to normal mixer operation.

The purpose of this exercise is not to prove that every operation can be performed without a mouse.

It is to experience the complete sequence:

Select → Browse → Choose → Control → Listen

When that sequence begins to feel like a single operation rather than five separate features, the X-Touch is becoming part of your workflow.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 14 - Mixer Edit Modes

Mixer Edit Modes

By now, we have become used to an important characteristic of the X-Touch:

The physical controls stay in the same place, but what they control can change.

The eight channel strips normally give us a familiar view of the mixer.

We have faders for track levels, V-Pots for parameters, and buttons for operations such as SELECT, MUTE, SOLO and ARM.

DrivenByMoss can take this idea further.

Instead of thinking only in terms of eight complete channel strips, we can temporarily ask the X-Touch to concentrate on one particular aspect of the mixer.

That is the idea behind the mixer edit modes.

Looking Across the Mixer

Imagine eight tracks:

Track 1 Track 2 Track 3 Track 4 Track 5 Track 6 Track 7 Track 8

There are several different ways we might want to look across them.

We could ask:

What are their volumes?

or:

What are their panorama positions?

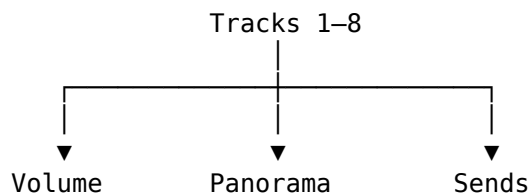
or:

How much of each track is being sent to Send 1?

The tracks have not changed.

What changes is the dimension of the mixer that we are looking at.

Conceptually:



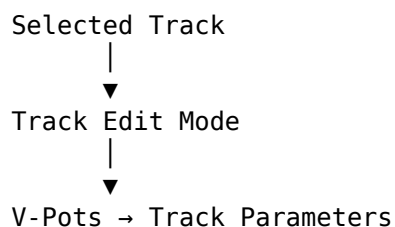
This is a useful way to understand the mixer edit modes.

Track Edit Mode

Press TRACK to enter Track Edit Mode.

Rather than treating each V-Pot simply as the normal control for its channel strip, Track Edit Mode exposes parameters associated with the selected track.

This gives the V-Pots another role:



The precise parameters available can depend on the current DrivenByMoss configuration.

The important point is the change in perspective.

We are no longer primarily looking across eight tracks.

We are looking more deeply at one selected track.

Volume Edit Mode

Press TRACK again and DrivenByMoss switches to Volume Edit Mode.

Now the V-Pots provide another way of controlling the volumes of the eight tracks in the current bank.

Conceptually:

V-Pot 1 → Track 1 Volume
V-Pot 2 → Track 2 Volume
V-Pot 3 → Track 3 Volume
...
V-Pot 8 → Track 8 Volume

Of course, the X-Touch already has eight motor faders.

So why would we want volume on the V-Pots as well?

One answer is FLIP, which we met earlier.

The ability to exchange the roles of faders and rotary controls becomes much more useful when the controller can present parameters in different ways.

The important lesson is not that one control is the "correct" way to adjust volume.

It is that DrivenByMoss allows the surface to be reorganised around the task.

Panorama Edit Mode

Press PAN to enter Panorama Edit Mode.

The eight V-Pots now control the panorama positions of the eight tracks in the current bank:

V-Pot 1 → Track 1 Pan
V-Pot 2 → Track 2 Pan
V-Pot 3 → Track 3 Pan
...
V-Pot 8 → Track 8 Pan

This is perhaps the clearest example of an edit mode.

Instead of thinking:

Channel 1
├── Volume
├── Pan
├── Mute
└── Solo

we temporarily rotate our view through ninety degrees and think:

Pan
├── Track 1
├── Track 2
├── Track 3
├── ...
└── Track 8

The information is the same.

The view onto it has changed.

Fine Adjustment with SHIFT

As we saw in Chapter 8, SHIFT frequently provides finer adjustment of continuous parameters.

That pattern applies here too.

Hold SHIFT while turning a V-Pot when you need more precise control.

Conceptually:

Turn V-Pot

↓
Normal adjustment

SHIFT + Turn V-Pot

↓
Finer adjustment

This is a good example of why we introduced modifiers before exploring the advanced modes.

The modifier itself is no longer something new to learn.

We simply apply an existing idea to a new task.

Send Edit Modes

The SEND control opens another particularly useful family of mixer views.

Press SEND and the V-Pots control a Send across the eight tracks.

For example, in the first Send mode:

SEND 1

Track 1	→	Send 1
Track 2	→	Send 1
Track 3	→	Send 1
Track 4	→	Send 1
Track 5	→	Send 1
Track 6	→	Send 1
Track 7	→	Send 1
Track 8	→	Send 1

The eight V-Pots now answer one question:

How much of each track is being sent to this destination?

This is an especially natural way to work with effects sends.

If Send 1 feeds a reverb, for example, you can adjust the amount of reverb for eight tracks without changing the basic mixer bank.

Moving Through the Sends

A project may contain more than one Send.

Repeated presses of SEND move through the available Send modes.

Conceptually:

SEND
↓
Send 1
↓
SEND
↓

Send 2
↓
SEND
↓
Send 3
↓
...

DrivenByMoss supports Send modes 1-8.

Hold SHIFT while pressing SEND to move through the Sends in the opposite direction.

So:

SEND
→ next Send

SHIFT + SEND
→ previous Send

This is another modifier pattern we have already encountered:

SHIFT can provide the related or reverse operation.

Jumping Directly to a Send

Cycling is useful when moving between neighbouring Sends.

But if you already know which Send you want, DrivenByMoss provides a quicker route.

Hold SEND and use the channel SELECT buttons to choose the Send directly.

Conceptually:

SEND + SELECT 1 → Send 1
SEND + SELECT 2 → Send 2
SEND + SELECT 3 → Send 3
...
SEND + SELECT 8 → Send 8

This is an important example of a control acquiring a new meaning from context.

Normally:

SELECT 3

means:

Select Track 3.

But while SEND is being used as the context:

SEND + SELECT 3

means:

Select Send 3.

The physical SELECT button has not changed.

The context has.

Switching a Send On or Off

Send level and Send state are two different things.

Turning a V-Pot adjusts the amount being sent.

DrivenByMoss also allows the Send itself to be switched on or off.

In Send Mode:

OPTION + V-Pot press

toggles the corresponding Send.

So one rotary control can provide both:

Turn

↓

Send level

OPTION + Press

↓

Send on/off

This is exactly the kind of compact interaction for which modifiers are useful.

The common operation remains immediately available.

The related secondary operation is one modifier away.

Send Mode as a Mixing Tool

Send Mode is worth thinking about as more than a shortcut.

Suppose Send 1 contains a reverb and Send 2 contains a delay.

You can move between two complete views of your mix:

Send 1 – Reverb

Track 1 amount

Track 2 amount

Track 3 amount

...

Track 8 amount

then:

Send 2 – Delay

Track 1 amount

Track 2 amount
Track 3 amount
...
Track 8 amount

Rather than visiting each track and adjusting one Send at a time, you can work across the mix according to the effect you are shaping.

For dub-style mixing in particular, this way of thinking can be extremely useful.

ARM, MUTE and SOLO

The channel-strip buttons continue to provide immediate control over the tracks.

ARM

Press ARM on a channel strip to arm that track for recording.

The bank of ARM buttons allows record state to be managed directly from the surface.

MUTE

Press MUTE to mute the corresponding track.

SOLO

Press SOLO to solo the corresponding track.

These are familiar mixer operations, but DrivenByMoss also provides modified versions for useful bank-wide or related operations.

Clearing Mutes

When several tracks have been muted, clearing them individually can be tedious.

DrivenByMoss provides a global operation for clearing active mutes.

This is particularly useful after using mute creatively during playback.

Rather than searching the surface for every illuminated MUTE button, the controller can return the mixer to an unmuted state in one operation.

The exact global-control combination will be included in the Quick Reference once the final command set has been verified against the current DrivenByMoss version.

Clearing Solos

The same problem occurs with Solo.

During mixing it is easy to accumulate a state in which one or more tracks are soloed.

DrivenByMoss provides a global operation for clearing active solos.

Again, the important workflow idea is:

Experiment

↓

Mute / Solo tracks

↓

Return the mixer to a known state

The controller is not merely a way to activate states.

It also provides efficient ways to recover from them.

Monitoring

SHIFT-modified channel buttons provide access to monitoring-related functions.

These are useful when recording and will become more meaningful when we look at advanced recording workflows later in the guide.

For now, the important distinction is that ARM, MUTE and SOLO buttons are not necessarily limited to the words printed on their caps.

Like the rest of the X-Touch, they participate in the modifier system.

FLIP

FLIP changes the relationship between rotary and fader control.

This becomes especially useful in the mixer edit modes.

A parameter that would normally be controlled from a V-Pot can be placed onto the motor faders.

Why might we want that?

Because a fader gives us:

- a long physical travel;
- touch sensitivity;
- motorised feedback;
- a very different physical feel from a rotary encoder.

For some adjustments, the V-Pot is ideal.

For others, the fader is more expressive.

FLIP lets the controller adapt.

Conceptually:

Before FLIP

V-Pots → parameter
Faders → volume

After FLIP

V-Pots → volume
Faders → parameter

The exact result depends on the current mode, but the principle remains the same:

FLIP exchanges control roles.

Mixing by Dimension

The most useful way to think about this chapter is not as a collection of modes.

Think of it as several different ways to slice through the same mixer.

By channel

Track 1
├─ Volume
├─ Pan
├─ Sends
├─ Mute
└─ Solo

By parameter

Pan
├─ Track 1
├─ Track 2
├─ Track 3
└─ ...

By Send

Reverb Send
├─ Track 1
├─ Track 2
├─ Track 3
└─ ...

None of these is more correct than another.

They are different views of the same project.

Choosing the Useful View

A good control surface should reduce the distance between an intention and an action.

If your intention is:

Turn Track 4 down.

the motor fader is probably already exactly what you want.

If your intention is:

Spread these eight tracks across the stereo field.

Panorama Mode gives you eight related controls together.

If your intention is:

Decide which tracks should feed the delay.

Send Mode gives you a complete view of that Send across the bank.

The important skill is therefore not memorising modes.

It is recognising which view best matches the job you are doing.

The Important Idea

Mixer Edit Modes let you reorganise the X-Touch around a particular mixing task.

Instead of always seeing:

eight tracks

x

many different controls

you can temporarily see:

one kind of control

x

eight tracks

That change of perspective is what makes these modes useful.

The X-Touch is still an eight-channel control surface.

But DrivenByMoss lets those eight channels become eight simultaneous views of:

- volume;
- panorama;
- Sends;
- track parameters;

depending on what you need at that moment.

Once this way of thinking becomes natural, the controller begins to feel less like a fixed bank of knobs and faders and more like a surface that reorganises itself around the mix.

Coming Next

Mixer Edit Modes help us change what we are controlling.

The next chapter deals with another question:

Where are we in the project?

Markers give us named positions in the timeline, and DrivenByMoss gives the X-Touch several ways to create, display and navigate them.

In the next chapter we will look at Markers and Advanced Navigation.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 15 - Markers and Advanced Navigation

Markers and Advanced Navigation

Transport controls let us move through a project.

We can play, stop, rewind, fast-forward and use the Jog Wheel to position the cursor precisely.

But as a project grows, there is another way to think about navigation.

Instead of asking:

How far should I move?

we can ask:

Where do I want to go?

That is where markers become useful.

A marker gives a position in the project a meaningful identity.

Instead of remembering that the chorus begins somewhere around bar 33, we can create a marker called:

Chorus

and navigate directly in terms of the structure of the music.

DrivenByMoss extends this idea onto the X-Touch.

From Position to Structure

Without markers, navigation is principally about position:

1 9 17 25 33 41
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|

With markers, the same timeline can acquire musical meaning:

Intro Verse Chorus Breakdown
↓ ↓ ↓ ↓
● ● ● ●

Now the project is not merely a sequence of bars.

It has landmarks.

And once those landmarks exist, the X-Touch can use them for navigation.

The MARKER Button

The MARKER button is the centre of marker operations.

Pressing MARKER enters Marker Mode.

This changes the context of the controller so that markers can be accessed from the surface.

As with the other modes we have encountered:

The hardware has not changed. Its current meaning has.

Marker Mode turns the X-Touch from a device that moves through time into one that can navigate the structure of the project.

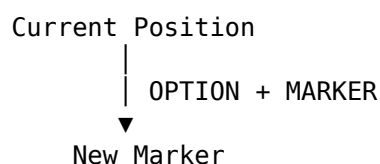
Creating a Marker

Hold OPTION and press MARKER:

OPTION + MARKER

to create a marker at the current position.

Conceptually:



This is particularly useful because creating the marker does not require breaking away from the control surface and reaching for the mouse.

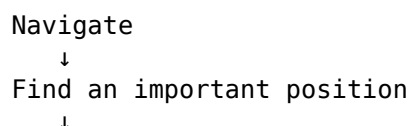
Imagine playback reaching the beginning of an important section.

You stop at the required position and press:

OPTION + MARKER

That position is now represented by a marker in the project.

The operation that originally looked like an obscure modifier combination now makes sense as part of a workflow:



OPTION + MARKER

↓

Create a landmark

Showing and Hiding Markers

Hold SHIFT and press MARKER:

SHIFT + MARKER

to show or hide the markers.

This provides another example of the modifier vocabulary introduced in Chapter 8.

MARKER performs the primary marker operation.

SHIFT + MARKER accesses a related secondary operation.

You do not need to remember this as an isolated shortcut.

Think:

MARKER

→ work with markers

SHIFT + MARKER

→ change their visibility

Previous and Next Marker

Once markers exist, REWIND and FORWARD gain useful alternative functions.

Normally these controls move through the timeline.

Hold OPTION, however, and they navigate between markers:

OPTION + REWIND

→ previous marker

OPTION + FORWARD

→ next marker

This gives us two distinct forms of navigation:

REWIND / FORWARD

├── normally
│ move through time
└── OPTION
 move through structure

That distinction is worth remembering.

Without OPTION, you are navigating distance.

With OPTION, you are navigating landmarks.

A Different Way to Move Through a Song

Suppose a project contains:

Intro
Verse 1
Chorus 1
Verse 2
Chorus 2
Breakdown
Final Chorus
Outro

With markers placed at those positions, moving through the project no longer requires repeatedly turning the Jog Wheel or holding FORWARD.

Instead:

OPTION + FORWARD

can step through the musical sections.

Likewise:

OPTION + REWIND

moves back through them.

So navigation begins to resemble:

Verse 1
|
▼
Chorus 1
|
▼
Verse 2
|
▼
Chorus 2

rather than:

bar 17
|
▼
bar 33
|
▼
bar 49

Both views are useful.

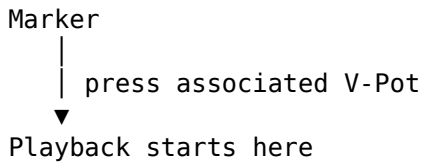
Markers simply add another level of meaning.

Playing from a Marker

In Marker Mode, the V-Pots give us another way to interact with markers.

Press the V-Pot associated with a marker to start playback from that marker.

Conceptually:



This turns the X-Touch into something closer to a set of structural navigation controls.

Instead of moving to a location and then pressing PLAY, the marker itself becomes the starting point.

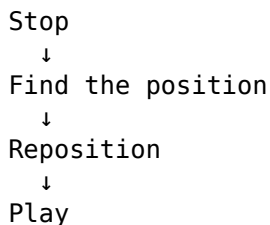
Why Marker Mode Matters

Marker Mode may initially seem like a fairly specialised feature.

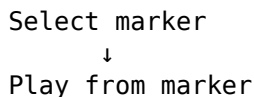
It becomes much more useful when we consider how often navigation interrupts a workflow.

Imagine repeatedly working on a transition between a verse and chorus.

With ordinary transport navigation, the cycle might be:



With a marker already placed at the start of the section:



The mechanical part of the operation becomes smaller.

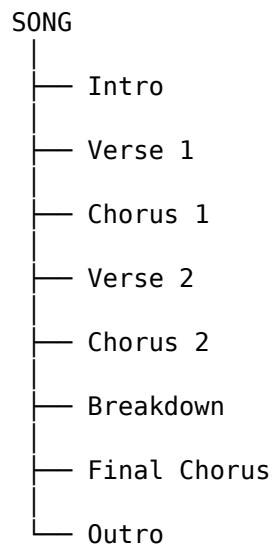
That matters because every navigation operation is something happening between musical decisions.

Markers as a Project Map

There is a broader principle here.

A well-marked project effectively contains a map of itself.

For example:



The X-Touch can then navigate that map.

This is fundamentally different from using the controller merely as a remote transport.

The transport controls know about time.

Markers know about places.

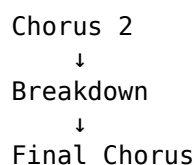
Together they provide both.

Markers During Arrangement

Markers are particularly useful while arranging.

Suppose you are deciding whether the breakdown is too long.

You might repeatedly compare:



Marker navigation lets you move between those structural points quickly.

You can concentrate on questions such as:

- Does the transition work?
- Does the next section arrive soon enough?
- Does the energy drop too far?
- Does the final chorus have enough impact?

The X-Touch handles the navigation while your attention remains on the arrangement.

Markers During Mixing

Markers are equally useful during mixing.

A mix rarely needs attention everywhere at once.

You may want to revisit:

Vocal entrance
Bass drop
Busy chorus
Quiet breakdown
Final hit

Markers can turn these into repeatable destinations.

For example:

```
OPTION + FORWARD
  ↓
Busy Chorus
  ↓
listen
  ↓
OPTION + FORWARD
  ↓
Quiet Breakdown
  ↓
listen
```

This is much faster than repeatedly finding those positions visually.

It also encourages listening rather than screen-watching.

Markers During Performance

Markers can also provide a useful structural framework when Bitwig is being used more performatively.

The important point is not that markers replace clips, scenes or Launcher workflows.

They do not.

Markers describe positions in the Arranger timeline.

But where the Arranger itself forms part of a performance, marker navigation gives the X-Touch another way to interact with that structure.

As always, the appropriate tool depends on the job.

Marker Navigation and the Transport Controls

We first encountered REWIND and FORWARD as transport controls.

Now we can see that they have two related roles.

Ordinary transport

REWIND
FORWARD

move through the timeline.

Structural navigation

OPTION + REWIND
OPTION + FORWARD

move through markers.

This is why modifier commands are best learned in context.

If Chapter 8 had simply presented:

OPTION + FORWARD = next marker

as one line in a large table, it would have been another fact to memorise.

Here, its purpose is obvious.

Marker Mode and the Mental Model

Markers also fit neatly into the mental model developed throughout this guide.

The same physical controls can acquire meaning from context.

For example:

V-Pot
+
Marker Mode
=
Marker interaction

And:

FORWARD
+
OPTION
=
Next Marker

So our increasingly complete model is:

Physical Control
+
Current Mode
+
Modifier
=
Current Function

The surface is not a collection of controls with permanently fixed meanings.

It is a system of contextual controls.

A Practical Marker Workflow

A simple workflow might look like this.

1. Find the beginning of a section

Use the normal transport controls or Jog Wheel.

Navigate

↓

Beginning of Chorus

2. Create the marker

OPTION + MARKER

3. Repeat for other important sections

For example:

Intro

Verse

Chorus

Breakdown

Outro

4. Navigate structurally

Use:

OPTION + REWIND

OPTION + FORWARD

to move between those landmarks.

5. Enter Marker Mode when appropriate

Use MARKER to expose marker-oriented control from the X-Touch.

6. Start playback from the required marker

Press the corresponding V-Pot.

The result is a project that can increasingly be navigated by musical structure rather than screen position.

You Don't Need a Marker Everywhere

Markers are useful because they simplify navigation.

Too many markers can have the opposite effect.

A project containing:

Intro
Verse
Chorus
Breakdown
Outro

provides obvious destinations.

A project containing a marker every few bars may simply replace one navigation problem with another.

Use markers for positions you expect to revisit.

Good candidates include:

- major song sections;
- important transitions;
- difficult edits;
- mix-check locations;
- unusual events;
- positions needed repeatedly during a session.

The aim is not to document every metre of the timeline.

It is to create useful landmarks.

Less Looking, More Listening

There is another benefit to marker navigation that fits the larger aim of Project XTC.

If you know that the next press of:

OPTION + FORWARD

will take you to the next important section, you do not need to locate that section visually.

Your eyes do not need to find the mouse pointer.

The pointer does not need to find the timeline.

The timeline does not need to be zoomed to the right scale.

You simply move to the next landmark.

This is a small example of the mouse-lite principle we will return to later:

The best control-surface operation is often the one that lets your attention remain on the music.

The Important Idea

Transport navigation answers:

How do I move through time?

Marker navigation answers:

How do I move through the structure of my project?

DrivenByMoss gives the X-Touch both.

The essential marker commands are:

MARKER

→ Marker Mode

OPTION + MARKER

→ Create marker

SHIFT + MARKER

→ Show/hide markers

OPTION + REWIND

→ Previous marker

OPTION + FORWARD

→ Next marker

And within Marker Mode, the V-Pots allow markers to become direct playback destinations.

Once markers are part of your normal project workflow, navigation stops being purely a matter of bars, beats and cursor positions.

The project acquires places you can go.

Coming Next

So far we have used the motor faders to control parameters and respond to changes from Bitwig.

But their touch sensitivity becomes particularly powerful when Bitwig is recording those movements.

That brings us to one of the areas where a motorised control surface can feel dramatically different from using a mouse.

Next:

Automation.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 16 - Automation

Automation

The motor faders on the X-Touch do something rather special.

Move a fader and Bitwig responds.

Change the same parameter in Bitwig and the physical fader moves.

We saw this two-way relationship earlier:

You move the fader



Bitwig

Bitwig



The fader moves

Automation adds another dimension.

Bitwig can remember the movement.

Instead of a fader representing one fixed value, it can become part of a performance that changes over time.

From Position to Movement

Suppose a track begins quietly and gradually becomes louder.

Without automation, we might set the fader to one compromise level.

With automation, we can perform the change:



Bitwig records the changing value.

When the project plays again, that movement can be reproduced.

And because the X-Touch has motorised faders, the physical fader can move with it.

That is one of the moments when a control surface stops feeling like a remote control and starts feeling like part of the DAW.

Automation Is About Behaviour

The X-Touch provides five buttons in its AUTOMATION section:

READ/OFF WRITE TRIM TOUCH LATCH

These labels come from the Mackie Control world.

DrivenByMoss maps them onto the automation modes that Bitwig actually provides.

The verified mapping is:

READ/OFF
→ Disable Arranger automation recording

WRITE
→ Enable Arranger automation recording
in Write mode

TRIM
→ Enable Read mode
because Bitwig has no Trim mode

TOUCH
→ Enable Arranger automation recording
in Touch mode

LATCH
→ Enable Arranger automation recording
in Latch mode

There is also:

OPTION + READ/OFF
→ Reset automation overrides

The important lesson is already familiar:

The words printed on the X-Touch tell us where the controls came from. DrivenByMoss determines what they do in Bitwig.

Three Useful Questions

The automation modes become easier to understand if we ask three questions:

What happens before I touch the control?

What happens while I move it?

What happens when I release it?

For a touch-sensitive motor fader, that gives us a simple model:

Touch
↓
Move
↓
Release
↓
What happens now?

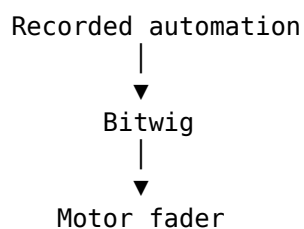
The answer depends on the automation mode.

READ/OFF

Pressing READ/OFF disables Arranger automation recording.

This puts us back into the normal situation where existing automation can be read without our movements being written as a new automation pass.

Conceptually:



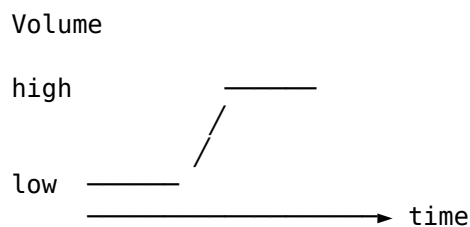
The physical fader follows the changing automated value.

This is useful feedback.

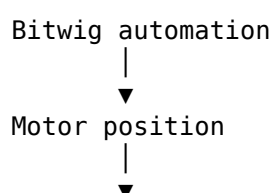
You can see and feel the automation happening rather than merely watching a line move on the screen.

Automation Playback

Imagine that a track contains this volume automation:



During playback, the X-Touch fader follows it:



Fader moves

Do not fight the fader while simply reading automation.

Its movement is information.

The controller is showing you what the project is doing.

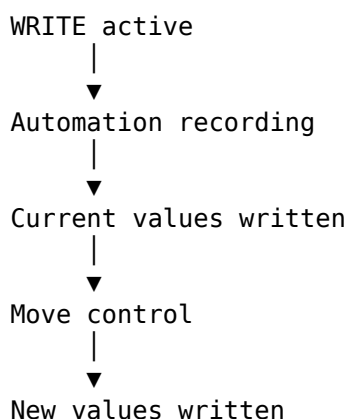
WRITE

Pressing WRITE enables Arranger automation recording in Write mode.

Write is the most direct of the automation-writing modes.

When Write is active, the current parameter values are written into the automation while the automation pass is running.

Conceptually:



Write is powerful precisely because it is direct.

It also deserves care.

If you leave Write active while playing through a section, you can replace automation that you intended to keep.

Think of WRITE as:

Write the current control state into the automation.

That makes it useful when deliberately creating or replacing an automation passage.

TOUCH

Pressing TOUCH enables Arranger automation recording in Touch mode.

TOUCH makes particular sense with the X-Touch because the faders are touch-sensitive.

The important event is not merely moving the fader.

It is touching it.

Conceptually:

Existing automation plays

↓
Touch fader

↓
You take control

↓
Move fader

↓
New movement is written

↓
Release fader

↓
Existing automation resumes

This is one of the most natural ways to make corrections to an existing automation pass.

You can listen to the automated mix, reach for the fader when something needs changing, make the adjustment, and let go.

Bitwig then resumes control.

Touch as an Override

The relationship can be thought of as a temporary handover:

Bitwig

↓ automation playing

Fader

↓ you touch it

YOU

↓ you release it

Bitwig

This is where touch sensitivity becomes much more than a hardware specification.

The fader knows when you have deliberately put your hand on it.

That lets Bitwig distinguish between:

The motor is moving the fader

and:

The user is moving the fader.

That distinction is fundamental to Touch automation.

LATCH

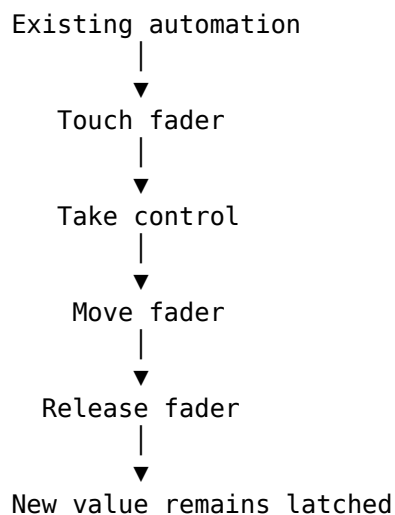
Pressing LATCH enables Arranger automation recording in Latch mode.

LATCH begins similarly to Touch.

Existing automation can play until you take control of the parameter.

The important difference appears when you release it.

Conceptually:



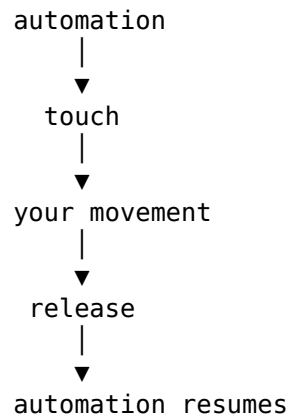
Instead of immediately returning to the previously recorded automation, the new value continues to be written.

That makes Latch useful when you want to establish a new level and keep it there.

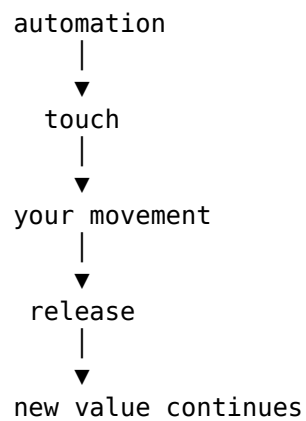
TOUCH and LATCH Compared

These two modes are easier to understand side by side.

TOUCH



LATCH



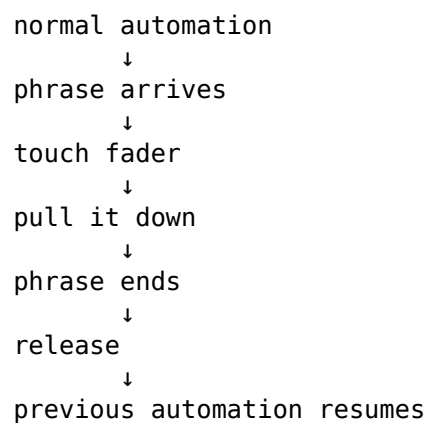
The key difference is therefore not what happens while you are holding the fader.

It is what happens after you let go.

Choosing Between TOUCH and LATCH

Suppose a vocal is slightly too loud for one phrase.

TOUCH is a natural choice:



Now suppose a synth needs to become quieter from the second chorus onwards.

LATCH may make more sense:

```
second chorus
  ↓
touch fader
  ↓
lower level
  ↓
release
  ↓
new level continues
```

The mode follows the musical intention.

What About TRIM?

The X-Touch has a button labelled:

TRIM

On some automation systems, Trim is a distinct mode for making relative changes to existing automation.

Bitwig does not provide a Trim automation mode.

DrivenByMoss therefore maps the X-Touch's TRIM button to:

```
TRIM
  ↓
Read mode
```

This is important because we should not infer functionality from the word printed on the hardware.

Pressing TRIM does not give Bitwig a console-style Trim automation mode that Bitwig itself does not possess.

The button exists because it is part of the Mackie Control layout.

DrivenByMoss gives it the closest useful Bitwig behaviour.

The Labels Belong to the MCU

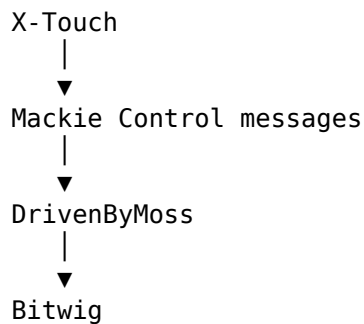
TRIM gives us a particularly clear example of a principle that applies throughout the X-Touch.

The hardware carries labels such as:

```
READ/OFF
WRITE
TRIM
TOUCH
LATCH
```

because those controls belong to the Mackie Control design.

But our actual system is:



So:

Trust the current DrivenByMoss mapping, not assumptions based solely on the button legend.

We have encountered the same principle elsewhere with controls such as USER, DROP and the function buttons.

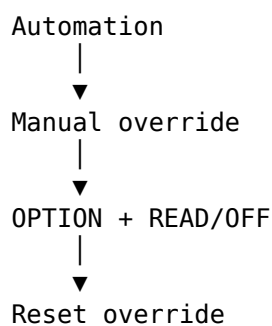
Resetting Automation Overrides

DrivenByMoss provides a particularly useful modified command:

OPTION + READ/OFF

This resets automation overrides.

Conceptually:



This gives you a quick way to clear overridden automation states and return parameters to normal automation control.

Arranger Automation

There is one more important word in the mappings above:

Arranger.

The automation buttons normally control Arranger automation recording.

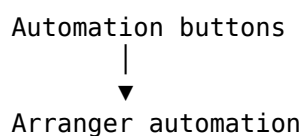
That distinction becomes important because Bitwig also has its Launcher environment.

As we saw in Chapter 19, Arranger and Launcher recording states are related but separate concepts.

DrivenByMoss also provides configuration that can change the priority between Arranger and Clip automation behaviour.

We will return to that in Chapter 21.

For now, the normal automation-button model is:



Performing Automation

Automation does not have to be drawn.

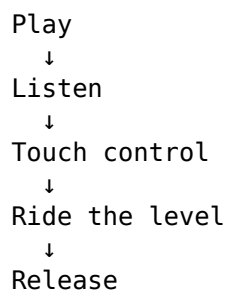
It can be performed.

That distinction is especially important with a control surface.

Suppose you want a delay return to rise dramatically into the end of a phrase.

With a mouse, you might create automation points and draw a curve.

With the X-Touch, you can approach the same problem musically:



The automation becomes a recorded gesture.

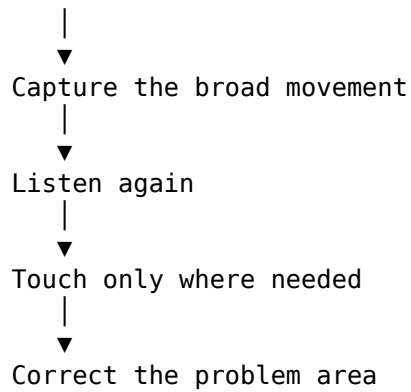
That is much closer to the way levels were traditionally ridden on a mixing console.

The First Pass Does Not Have to Be Perfect

One advantage of automation modes such as Touch is that automation can be refined.

A workflow might be:

First pass

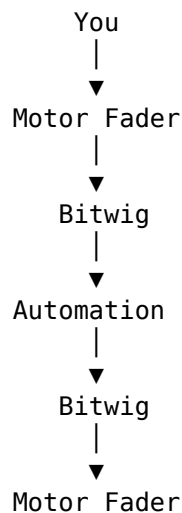


This is often more natural than trying to perform an entire complicated automation move perfectly in one pass.

Automation can be treated like any other performance:
record it, listen, and improve it.

Automation and the Motor Fader

The motor fader gives us a particularly clear feedback loop:



Information travels both ways.

When you perform a move, the X-Touch sends control information to Bitwig.

When Bitwig plays the automation back, it sends the resulting state back to the X-Touch.

The fader therefore becomes both:

- an input device;
- an output display.

That is one of the defining advantages of a motorised control surface.

Don't Grab a Moving Fader Casually

A moving motor fader is telling you that Bitwig is controlling that parameter. Touching it may have meaning depending on the current automation mode. So before grabbing a moving fader, know which automation mode is active. With automation recording disabled, you may simply be observing playback. In TOUCH, touching the fader can deliberately hand control to you. In WRITE, parameter states may be written continuously. The same physical gesture can therefore have very different consequences. The current mode matters.

Automation Is Not Just Volume

Faders make volume automation particularly obvious, but automation in Bitwig is much broader.

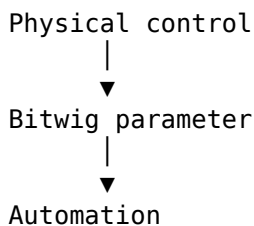
Parameters throughout the project can change over time.

The X-Touch may expose those parameters through:

- faders;
- V-Pots;
- Device Mode;
- Mixer Edit Modes;
- FLIP.

So the same general automation ideas apply beyond channel volume.

Conceptually:



If the parameter is automatable and the current X-Touch context gives you control over it, the surface can become part of the automation workflow.

FLIP and Automation

FLIP becomes particularly interesting here.

Suppose a parameter is normally assigned to a V-Pot.

FLIP can place the relevant control onto a fader in supported contexts.

That gives the parameter:

- longer physical travel;
- touch sensitivity;
- motorised position feedback.

So FLIP is not merely a convenience for mixing.

It can change the physical way in which an automation performance is made.

For expressive automation, that can be significant.

Watching Automation Come Back

There is something worth doing at least once simply to understand the system.

Record a deliberate fader movement.

Then:

1. stop;
2. return to a point before the movement;
3. disable automation recording;
4. press PLAY;
5. take your hand away.

Watch the fader reproduce what you performed.

The movement you made has become part of the project.

That simple demonstration makes the feedback loop tangible:

```
You moved it
      ↓
Bitwig remembered it
      ↓
Bitwig plays it
      ↓
The X-Touch moves it
```

A Practical Automation Workflow

A straightforward automation pass might look like this.

1. Choose the parameter

For example, track volume.

2. Choose the automation mode

For an existing automated mix that needs correction, TOUCH may be appropriate.

3. Start playback

Listen rather than watching the screen.

4. Touch the fader

Take control when the musical moment arrives.

5. Perform the movement

Ride the level by ear.

6. Release

In TOUCH, Bitwig returns to the existing automation behaviour.

7. Play the section again

Disable automation recording if necessary and listen to the result while the motor fader reproduces the automation.

8. Correct it if necessary

Automation is editable and repeatable.

You are not committing to a one-take performance.

Automation and Mouse-Lite Working

Automation provides another example of why a control surface can change the relationship with a DAW.

With a mouse, automation often encourages this:

Look
↓
Point
↓
Click
↓
Draw
↓
Adjust

With a touch-sensitive fader:

Listen
↓
Touch
↓

Move

↓

Release

Neither approach is universally better.

Drawing automation is invaluable when exact editing is required.

But for a musical gesture, the physical approach can be far more immediate.

The aim of Project XTC is not to prohibit the mouse.

It is to make reaching for it a choice rather than a reflex.

Automation as Performance

This leads to perhaps the most useful way to think about automation with the X-Touch.

Do not think only:

I am programming a parameter change.

Think:

I am performing a parameter change and asking Bitwig to remember it.

That shift in perspective matters.

A fade becomes something you play.

A Send ride becomes something you play.

A filter movement becomes something you play.

And because the X-Touch can reproduce the resulting movement, the surface remains connected to that performance afterwards.

The Important Idea

The automation buttons determine what happens when control passes between Bitwig and you.

The verified normal mappings are:

READ/OFF

→ Disable Arranger automation recording

WRITE

→ Write mode

TRIM

→ Read mode

(Bitwig has no Trim mode)

TOUCH

→ Touch mode

LATCH

→ Latch mode

OPTION + READ/OFF

→ Reset automation overrides

For Touch and Latch, the particularly useful question is:

Before I touch:

Who has control?

While I move:

What is being written?

When I release:

What happens next?

And the motor fader makes that relationship physical.

You move it.

Bitwig remembers.

Then Bitwig moves it back.

Coming Next

So far, most of our navigation has treated the eight visible channels as a relatively flat bank.

But Bitwig projects can contain structures within structures:

- Groups;
- instruments;
- layers;
- drum pads.

DrivenByMoss allows the X-Touch to navigate those structures too.

Next we will look at:

Groups, Layers and Drum Pads.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 17 - Groups, Layers and Drum Pads

Groups, Layers and Drum Pads

So far, we have often treated the eight channel strips as a window onto a simple row of tracks.

Something like:

Track 1	Track 2	Track 3	Track 4
Track 5	Track 6	Track 7	Track 8

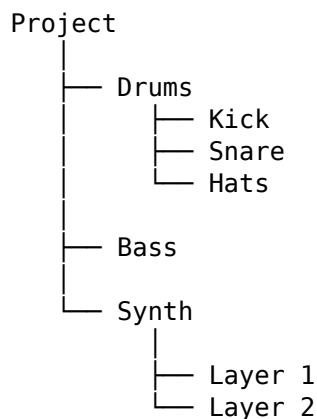
Real Bitwig projects are rarely that simple.

A track may be a Group containing other tracks.

An instrument may contain Layers.

A Drum Machine may contain many Drum Pads.

So the project can have structure within structure:



DrivenByMoss allows the X-Touch to move through these structures.

The eight channel strips do not merely move sideways through the project.

They can also move deeper into it.

A Correction to an Easy Assumption

It would be natural to imagine hierarchical navigation working like this:

```
SELECT
  ↓
ENTER
```

↓
work inside
↓
CANCEL
↓
go back

That is not how DrivenByMoss navigates Groups and Layers.

The actual mechanism is built primarily around the channel SELECT buttons.

For hierarchical Group navigation:

SELECT Group
↓
Group becomes selected
↓
Press the same SELECT again
↓
Enter Group
↓
Long-press any SELECT
↓
Leave Group

For Layers and Drum Pads:

SELECT Track
↓
Track becomes selected
↓
Press the same SELECT again
↓
Enter Layers / Drum Pads
↓
Long-press any SELECT
↓
Leave Layers / Drum Pads

This repeated-SELECT behaviour is central to understanding the chapter.

Why ENTER and CANCEL Are Not Used Here

The X-Touch does have ENTER and CANCEL buttons.

They simply have different jobs.

When the Browser is active:

ENTER
→ confirm Browser selection

CANCEL
→ discard Browser selection

Outside the Browser they behave like the computer keyboard's Enter and Escape keys.

They are therefore useful controls.

They are just not the mechanism for entering and leaving Groups or Layers.

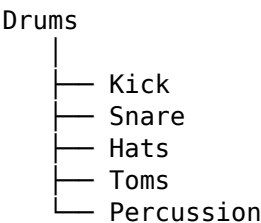
For the structures in this chapter, think:

- SELECT
 - choose
- SELECT again
 - go inside
- Long-press SELECT
 - come back out

Groups

A Bitwig Group is a track that contains other tracks.

For example:



At the top level of the project, the X-Touch may initially show:

Drums Bass Guitars Keys Vocals FX

The individual drum tracks are not necessarily part of this top-level view.

They live inside the Drums Group.

Hierarchical Track Navigation

DrivenByMoss provides a Track navigation preference.

When it is set to:

Hierarchical

the controller presents the project according to its Group structure.

At the top level, that might look like:

Drums	Bass	Guitars	Keys	Vocals	FX
-------	------	---------	------	--------	----

The contents of the Drums Group do not have to consume channel strips until you actually enter that Group.

This allows a large project to remain manageable on an eight-channel surface.

Entering a Group

Suppose the Drums Group is on Channel 1.

First press its SELECT button:

Drums
|
▼
SELECT

The Drums Group becomes the selected track.

Now press the same SELECT button again:

Drums selected
|
▼
SELECT again
|
▼
Enter Drums Group

The eight channel strips now represent tracks inside the Group.

For example:

Kick Snare Hats Toms Perc Room

The physical hardware has not changed.

The level of the project represented by it has changed.

Leaving a Group

To leave the current Group:

Long-press any SELECT button

Conceptually:

Kick Snare Hats Toms Perc
|
▼
long-press SELECT
|
▼
Drums Bass Guitars Keys Vocals

This takes the controller back up to the parent level.

So the essential hierarchical movement is:

SELECT
↓
select object

SELECT again
↓

enter object

long-press SELECT

↓

leave object

SELECT Has Acquired a Second Dimension

Earlier in Project XTC, SELECT primarily meant:

This one.

That remains true.

But in a hierarchical project, repeated SELECT can also mean:

Show me inside this one.

So SELECT now has two related roles:

First press

→ focus

Second press

→ descend, where appropriate

and:

Long press

→ ascend

This is a compact navigation system built into buttons that already have an obvious relationship with the channel strips.

Think of It as Zooming Into the Mixer

Another useful mental model is magnification.

At first:

Drums Bass Guitars Keys Vocals

Then:

SELECT Drums

SELECT Drums again

and the controller effectively zooms in:

Kick Snare Hats Toms Percussion

Long-press SELECT and it zooms back out:

Drums Bass Guitars Keys Vocals

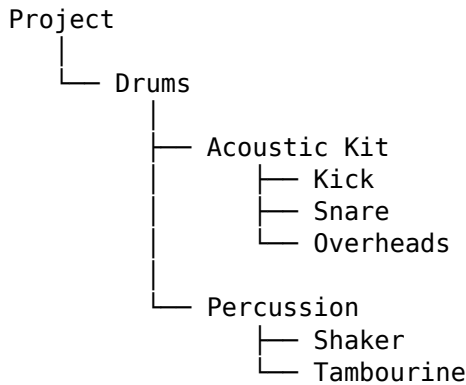
Nothing has moved physically.

The X-Touch has changed the scale at which you are viewing the project.

Nested Groups

Groups may themselves contain Groups.

Conceptually:



The same principle can be applied repeatedly.

At the top level:

Drums

Enter Drums:

Acoustic Kit Percussion

Enter Acoustic Kit:

Kick Snare Overheads

Then long-press SELECT to move back towards the parent level.

The important point is not how many levels exist.

It is that the navigation rule remains understandable.

The Eight Strips Are a Window

This gives us a more powerful version of the idea introduced in Chapter 4.

Originally:

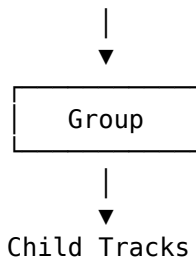
Large project

8 visible tracks

Banking moved that window sideways.

Hierarchical navigation adds another direction:

Project



So the X-Touch can now move:

← sideways through banks →

and

↓ deeper into structure

↑ back towards the parent

This is how eight physical channel strips can remain useful in a much larger project.

Flat Track Navigation

Hierarchical navigation is not the only option.

DrivenByMoss also provides:

Track navigation: Flat

In Flat mode, all tracks are presented in one flat track bank rather than using the Group structure as the controller's navigation hierarchy.

That changes what happens when an already-selected Group is selected again.

Repeated SELECT in Flat Mode

With flat navigation:

SELECT an already-selected Group

does not enter the Group as a new controller level.

Instead it toggles the Group's expanded state.

Conceptually:

Drums ►

becomes:

Drums ▼
 Kick
 Snare
 Hats

and vice versa.

This is an important distinction.

The same physical gesture:

SELECT again

has different Group behaviour depending on the Track navigation preference.

Flat or Hierarchical?

Neither mode is universally correct.

They represent two different ways of thinking about a project.

Flat

Think:

Show me the tracks as one long mixer.

Hierarchical

Think:

Show me the project structure, and let me enter the part I need.

For a small project, Flat may be extremely convenient.

For a large project containing many Groups, Hierarchical navigation can make eight channel strips feel much less restrictive.

The choice is made in the DrivenByMoss settings, which we discuss in Chapter 21.

Opening and Closing Groups Without Entering Them

DrivenByMoss provides another useful Group command:

CONTROL + SELECT

If the selected channel is a Group, this opens or closes the Group folder.

So we should distinguish between two ideas:

SELECT again

- hierarchical navigation into the Group
when Hierarchical navigation is configured

and:

CONTROL + SELECT

- open / close the Group folder

They are related, but they are not the same operation.

Navigation Versus Presentation

This distinction is easier to understand if we think in terms of:

Where am I?

versus:

How is the Group displayed?

Hierarchical SELECT navigation changes the controller's current level.

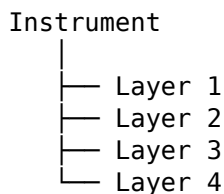
CONTROL + SELECT changes the Group's open/closed state.

That gives us two different kinds of Group control without requiring a separate bank of dedicated Group buttons.

Layers

Bitwig instruments can contain Layers.

For example:



DrivenByMoss allows the X-Touch channel strips to represent those Layers.

The mechanism is deliberately similar to Group navigation.

Entering Layers Mode

First select the track containing the instrument.

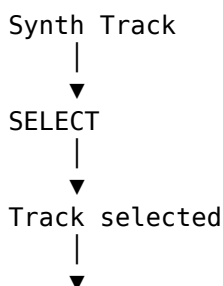
If it is not already selected:

SELECT Track

Once that track is selected, press its SELECT button again.

If the track contains an instrument with Layers or Drum Pads at the top level, DrivenByMoss enters Layers mode.

Conceptually:



SELECT again



Layer 1 Layer 2 Layer 3 Layer 4

The channel strips now represent the instrument's internal elements rather than normal project tracks.

Leaving Layers Mode

The exit mechanism is the same principle used for hierarchical Groups:

Long-press any SELECT button

So:

Layer 1 Layer 2 Layer 3 Layer 4



long-press SELECT



Synth Track

This consistency is useful.

Once the repeated-SELECT / long-press-SELECT model becomes familiar, it can be applied to more than one kind of hierarchy.

Layer Mixing

Once Layers mode is active, the Layers can be edited using familiar mixer concepts.

DrivenByMoss supports Layer control for:

Volume

Pan

Sends

Mute

Solo

So a layered instrument can effectively become a small mixer inside the larger project mixer.

For example:

Layer A	Layer B	Layer C	Layer D
Volume	Volume	Volume	Volume

You can balance the Layers without needing to treat the instrument as one indivisible sound.

Familiar Modes at a Different Level

The important point is that many of the controls you already know continue to make sense.

The context has changed.

Instead of:

Track 1 Track 2 Track 3 Track 4

you may now have:

Layer 1 Layer 2 Layer 3 Layer 4

But concepts such as:

Volume
Pan
Send
Mute
Solo

remain familiar.

This is a recurring DrivenByMoss design idea:

Learn a small number of interaction patterns, then reuse them at different levels of the project.

Drum Pads

Drum Pads follow the same general model.

Suppose a Bitwig Drum Machine contains:

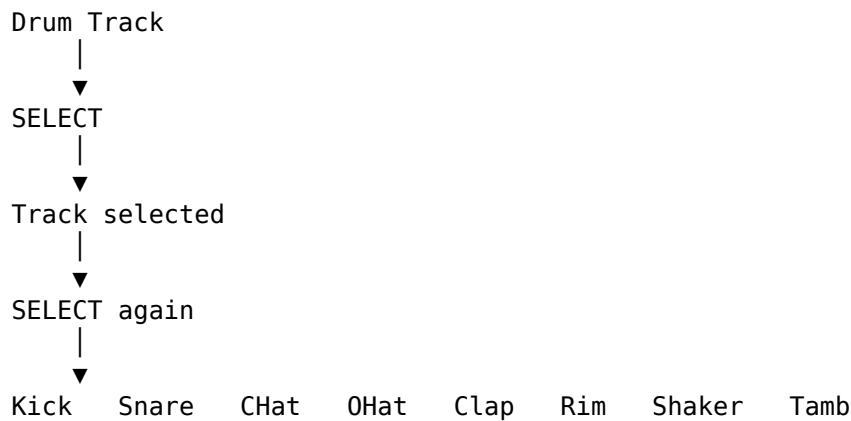
Kick
Snare
Closed Hat
Open Hat
Clap
Rim
Shaker
Tambourine

The X-Touch can expose these through its channel strips when the containing track is entered in Layers/Drum Pad mode.

Entering Drum Pad Mode

Select the track containing the Drum Machine.

Then press SELECT again:

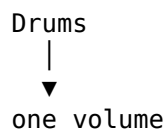


The eight physical channel strips are now a window onto the Drum Machine's pads.

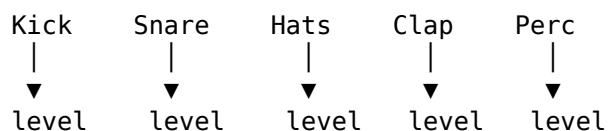
A Drum Machine Becomes a Mixer

This is where the idea becomes particularly useful.

Instead of treating the Drum Machine as one track:



you can work with its internal sounds:



That gives the X-Touch access to a level of detail that would otherwise require returning to Bitwig's graphical device interface.

Drum Pad Mute and Solo

Mute and Solo become especially useful here.

Suppose you want to hear only the kick and snare.

You can use the familiar SOLO buttons at the Drum Pad level.

Or perhaps one percussion sound is getting in the way.

Use MUTE on that pad.

The physical controls have not changed.

Their targets have.

This is another example of why the current context matters so much on the X-Touch.

Drum Pad Sends

Sends can also be useful at the Layer or Drum Pad level.

Imagine a Drum Machine where:

Kick
→ mostly dry

Snare
→ some reverb

Clap
→ more reverb

Percussion
→ delay

Rather than processing the entire Drum Machine identically, individual elements can participate differently in the mix.

This can be particularly useful in electronic music and dub-style workflows.

The Same Surface at Different Scales

We can now see several possible meanings for one physical channel strip.

At one moment it may represent:

Track

At another:

Group child

At another:

Instrument Layer

At another:

Drum Pad

Yet the controls remain recognisable:

V-Pot

ARM

SOLO

MUTE

SELECT
Fader

The X-Touch is not changing physically.

DrivenByMoss is changing the context represented by the hardware.

Context Is Everything

This is why the scribble strips and displays matter.

If Channel 3 represents:

Bass

you need to know that.

If you enter a Group and Channel 3 now represents:

Hi-Hat

you need to know that too.

If you then enter a layered instrument and Channel 3 represents:

Noise Layer

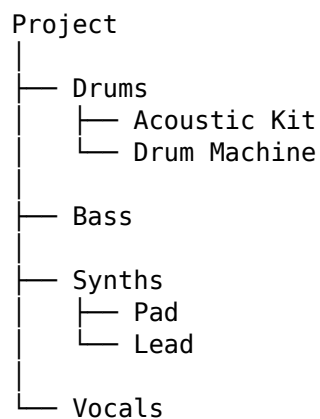
the same physical controls have acquired yet another meaning.

The surface is contextual.

The feedback tells you what the current context is.

A Complete Hierarchical Example

Imagine this project:



Assume Track navigation is set to Hierarchical.

At the top level, the X-Touch might show:

Drums Bass Synths Vocals

You want the snare inside the Drum Machine.

Step 1 — Select Drums

SELECT Drums

Drums becomes the selected Group.

Step 2 — Enter Drums

Press the same SELECT again:

SELECT Drums again

The surface now shows:

Acoustic Kit Drum Machine

Step 3 — Select Drum Machine

SELECT Drum Machine

The Drum Machine track becomes selected.

Step 4 — Enter its Drum Pads

Press the same SELECT again:

SELECT Drum Machine again

Now the surface might show:

Kick Snare CHat OHat Clap Rim Perc Tamb

Step 5 — Adjust the Snare

The Snare is now simply one of the visible channel-strip targets.

Use the appropriate edit mode to adjust:

Volume

Pan

Send

Mute

Solo

Step 6 — Leave Drum Pad Mode

Long-press any SELECT button.

You return from the Drum Pads to the containing track context.

Step 7 — Leave the Drums Group

Long-press SELECT again as appropriate to return to the parent Group level.

Eventually:

Drums Bass Synths Vocals

is visible again.

We have moved:

```
Project
  ↓
Drums Group
  ↓
Drum Machine
  ↓
Drum Pads
  ↓
Snare
```

and then back out again.

All without needing ENTER or CANCEL for the hierarchy.

SELECT as Navigation

We can now refine the mental model of SELECT that began much earlier in this guide.

At its simplest:

```
SELECT
  → this one
```

But in a hierarchical context:

```
SELECT
  → focus this object
```

```
SELECT again
  → enter its internal level,
     where supported
```

```
long-press SELECT
  → leave the current internal level
```

And with a modifier:

```
CONTROL + SELECT
  → open / close a Group folder
```

That is a remarkable amount of navigation built around one consistent row of buttons.

Other Useful SELECT Modifiers

DrivenByMoss also provides several other operations on the channel SELECT buttons.

These are worth recognising even though they are not all specifically about hierarchy.

SHIFT + SELECT

- Multi-select tracks,
where supported by the DAW

OPTION + SELECT

- Stop the playing clip
on that track

CONTROL + SELECT

- Open / close Group folder

ALT + SELECT

- Set New Clip Length

SEND + SELECT

- Select Send 1–8

So SELECT is not merely a row of eight identical track-selection switches.

It is one of the most contextually useful parts of the surface.

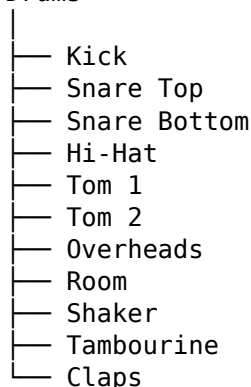
Hierarchy and Banking Work Together

Entering a Group does not mean that banking ceases to matter.

A Group may contain more than eight child tracks.

For example:

Drums



The first bank might expose:

Kick SnTop SnBot Hat Tom1 Tom2 OH Room

Then BANK can move the eight-channel window further through the Group.

So we now have two complementary navigation systems:

Hierarchy

→ choose the level

Banking

→ choose the portion of that level

This is how the X-Touch scales.

A Useful Mental Picture

Imagine the Bitwig project as a building.

Groups are rooms.

Tracks, Layers and Pads are things inside those rooms.

The X-Touch gives you a window.

BANK moves the window sideways:

← →

Hierarchical SELECT navigation moves you through the structure:

↓ enter

↑ leave

The eight physical strips remain the same size.

But the space they can explore becomes much larger.

Why Hierarchical Navigation Matters

Without hierarchy, a controller with eight channel strips can seem limited.

A project may contain:

40 tracks

or:

80 tracks

or more.

But a large project is often organised into meaningful structures:

Drums

Bass

Guitars

Synths

Vocals

FX

Hierarchical navigation lets the controller work with those structures rather than treating the project as one enormous flat list.

At the top level, the project can remain comprehensible.

When detail is needed, you descend into it.

Then you come back out.

The Controller Follows Your Attention

This leads to a useful way of thinking about the X-Touch.

Your attention may move like this:

```
Whole Project
  ↓
Drums
  ↓
Drum Machine
  ↓
Snare
```

The X-Touch can follow that attention.

Then:

```
Snare
  ↑
Drum Machine
  ↑
Drums
  ↑
Whole Project
```

The controller moves back out with you.

That is more useful than thinking merely in terms of button combinations.

The buttons are implementing a change in attention.

Hierarchical Versus Flat Is a Workflow Choice

There is no requirement to use hierarchical navigation.

If you prefer:

one long mixer

choose Flat.

If you prefer:

top-level structure

```
  ↓
drill into detail
  ↓
```


return

choose Hierarchical.

This is a configuration choice, not a test of whether you are using the X-Touch correctly.

Chapter 21 discusses the DrivenByMoss settings in more detail.

A Mouse-Lite Benefit

Groups, Layers and Drum Pads provide a good example of the Mouse-Lite idea.

Without hardware navigation, a common sequence might be:

```
look at screen
  ↓
find Group
  ↓
open Group
  ↓
find track
  ↓
open device
  ↓
find Drum Machine
  ↓
find pad
  ↓
adjust control
```

With a familiar X-Touch workflow:

```
SELECT
  ↓
SELECT again
  ↓
SELECT
  ↓
SELECT again
  ↓
adjust
```

That does not mean the graphical route is wrong.

Sometimes it will be clearer or faster.

But the physical route can allow your hands and ears to remain engaged with the mix.

Don't Descend Further Than You Need

Hierarchy is useful, but there is no prize for navigating to the deepest possible level.

If the problem is:

The entire drum Group is too loud

adjust the Group.

Do not enter it.

If the problem is:

The snare is too loud

then descend far enough to reach the snare.

A useful rule is:

Work at the highest level that solves the problem.

This keeps the workflow efficient.

The Important Idea

The X-Touch's eight channel strips are not tied permanently to eight top-level tracks.

They can represent different levels of the Bitwig project.

With hierarchical Track navigation:

SELECT

→ select

SELECT again

→ enter Group

long-press SELECT

→ leave Group

For a selected track containing top-level Layers or Drum Pads:

SELECT again

→ enter Layers / Drum Pads

long-press SELECT

→ leave Layers / Drum Pads

With Flat Track navigation:

SELECT an already-selected Group

→ toggle its expanded state

And independently:

CONTROL + SELECT

→ open / close Group folder

Once inside Layers or Drum Pads, familiar mixer concepts continue to apply:

Volume

Pan

Sends

Mute
Solo

So the controller can move from:

Project

to:

Group

to:

Track

to:

Layer / Drum Pad

and back again.

The physical surface stays the same.

Its meaning changes with your attention.

Coming Next

Hierarchy lets us move downward into the details of a project.

But the X-Touch can also move in the opposite direction — upwards to the level of the project itself.

Touching the Master fader enters a special DrivenByMoss context where the V-Pots no longer represent ordinary track controls.

They can control the Master channel, the audio engine and even project navigation.

Next:

Master Mode and Project Control.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 18 - Master Mode and Project Control

Master Mode and Project Control

Most of the X-Touch is concerned with the tracks that make up a project.

We select them.

We bank through them.

We mix them.

We control their devices and parameters.

But Bitwig also has a level above the individual tracks.

The Master track belongs to the project as a whole.

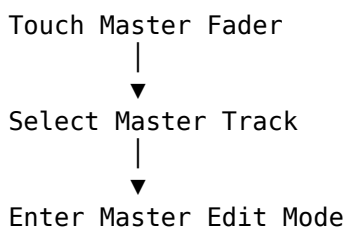
DrivenByMoss gives the X-Touch a specialised Master Edit Mode for working at that level.

The Master Fader Is More Than a Fader

The obvious job of the Master fader is to control the project's overall output level.

That is already useful.

But with DrivenByMoss, touching the Master fader also changes the controller's context:



So the Master fader performs two related jobs:

- it controls the Master level;
- touching it establishes the Master context.

This is another example of a familiar Project XTC principle:

An action can both control a value and establish focus.

From Track Focus to Project Focus

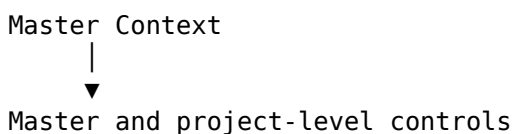
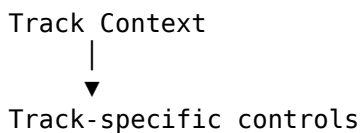
Earlier chapters concentrated on questions such as:

Which track am I controlling?

Master Mode asks a different question:

What if the thing I want to control belongs to the whole project?

Conceptually:



The physical V-Pots are the same.

What they represent has changed.

Entering Master Edit Mode

Touch the Master fader.

DrivenByMoss selects the Master track and enters Master Edit Mode.

The V-Pots then acquire these assignments:

Master Edit Mode

V-Pot 1 → Master Volume

V-Pot 2 → Master Panorama

V-Pots 3–5 → Press to toggle
the project's audio engine

V-Pot 7 → Press for Previous Project

V-Pot 8 → Press for Next Project

V-Pot 6 has no Master Mode function documented in the current DrivenByMoss MCU reference.

The important point is not merely the list.

The important point is that the X-Touch has moved from:

one track in the project

to:

the project-level Master context

V-Pot 1 — Master Volume

V-Pot 1 controls the Master volume.

The Master fader already provides a large physical control for the same parameter, so this may initially seem redundant.

But redundancy is not necessarily wasteful on a control surface.

It means the current mode remains internally consistent: the V-Pots themselves expose the parameters belonging to the Master context.

Turn V-Pot 1:

V-Pot 1
|
▼
Master Volume

Press V-Pot 1:

V-Pot 1 Press
|
▼
Reset Master Volume

The press behaviour follows the general V-Pot principle we met earlier:

Pressing a parameter knob resets it to its default value.

V-Pot 2 — Master Panorama

V-Pot 2 controls the Master panorama.

Turn it:

V-Pot 2
|
▼
Master Panorama

Press it:

V-Pot 2 Press
|
▼
Reset Master Panorama

So the first two V-Pots form a straightforward pair:

V-Pot 1 Master Volume

V-Pot 2 Master Panorama

Both can be pressed to reset their parameter.

V-Pots 3-5 — Audio Engine Control

V-Pots 3, 4 and 5 have a different kind of assignment.

They are not continuous parameter controls.

Pressing any of them toggles the audio engine on or off for the current project.

Conceptually:

Press V-Pot 3, 4 or 5



Toggle Project Audio Engine

This is an important distinction.

With V-Pots 1 and 2:

TURN

→ change a value

With V-Pots 3-5:

PRESS

→ perform an action

The same physical row therefore contains both parameter controls and project-level commands.

Why Three Knobs?

The current DrivenByMoss documentation assigns the same audio-engine toggle behaviour to V-Pots 3, 4 and 5.

Project XTC should describe that behaviour exactly as documented rather than inventing separate meanings for the three controls.

So the useful fact to remember is simply:

V-Pots 3-5



Press



Toggle Audio Engine

There is no need to assign a different conceptual role to each one.

What Does Toggling the Audio Engine Mean?

This is a project-level action.

It affects Bitwig's audio engine for the current project rather than a single track, device or parameter.

That makes it qualitatively different from most of the controls we have used so far.

The hierarchy is roughly:

```
Parameter
  ↓
Device
  ↓
Track
  ↓
Group
  ↓
Project
  ↓
Audio Engine
```

Master Edit Mode is one of the places where the X-Touch reaches that upper level.

Use Project-Level Actions Deliberately

Because the audio-engine control affects the project as a whole, it deserves more care than changing one track parameter.

A good habit is:

Check that you are in Master Mode before pressing project-level controls.

The displays and current context should confirm what the V-Pots represent.

As throughout this guide:

Observe before you adjust.

V-Pot 7 — Previous Project

Press V-Pot 7 to switch to the previous project.

Conceptually:

```
Current Project
  |
  | press V-Pot 7
  ▼
Previous Project
```

This is a surprisingly powerful operation to have on the control surface.

Project navigation itself becomes part of the hardware workflow.

V-Pot 8 — Next Project

Press V-Pot 8 to switch to the next project.

So V-Pots 7 and 8 form a natural pair:

V-Pot 7
← Previous Project

V-Pot 8
Next Project →

The spatial relationship is easy to remember.

Left means previous.

Right means next.

Moving Between Projects from the Surface

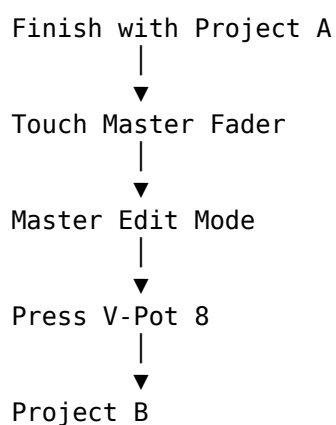
Imagine working through several related Bitwig projects.

Perhaps they are:

- different songs in a set;
- alternative versions;
- works in progress;
- test projects.

Instead of returning to project-selection controls with the mouse, Master Mode can provide direct navigation.

The workflow becomes:



This is not a glamorous function.

But it can make the overall workflow feel much more continuous.

The Master Fader and Metronome Volume

The Master fader also participates in another useful command:

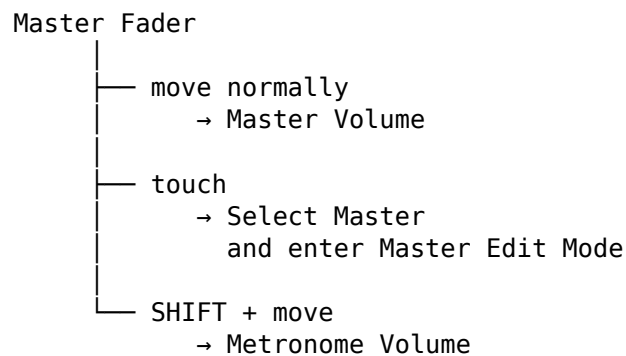
SHIFT + Master Fader

changes the Metronome volume.

This is not part of Master Edit Mode itself.

It is a modifier operation on the Master fader.

So the Master area now illustrates three different kinds of context:



One physical fader participates in several related workflows.

Master Mode and Context

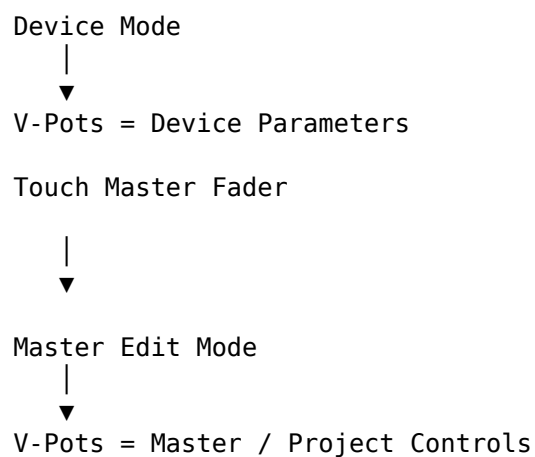
Suppose you were just working in Device Mode.

The V-Pots represented device parameters.

Then you touch the Master fader.

Now those same V-Pots represent Master and project-level functions.

Conceptually:



Nothing about the hardware has changed.

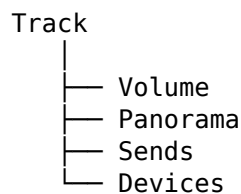
The current focus has changed.

This is precisely the mental model Project XTC has been building throughout the guide.

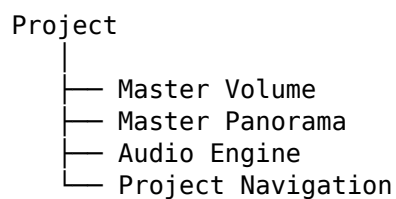
The Master Track Is a Different Scale

There is a useful way to think about this.

Ordinary track control is local:



Master control is global:



The X-Touch lets you change scale.

You can work on:

one parameter

then:

one track

then:

one Group

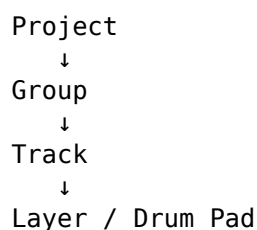
then:

the project as a whole

without changing control surfaces.

Moving Up and Down the Project

Chapter 17 showed how the controller can descend:



Master Mode reminds us that the controller can also move in the other direction.

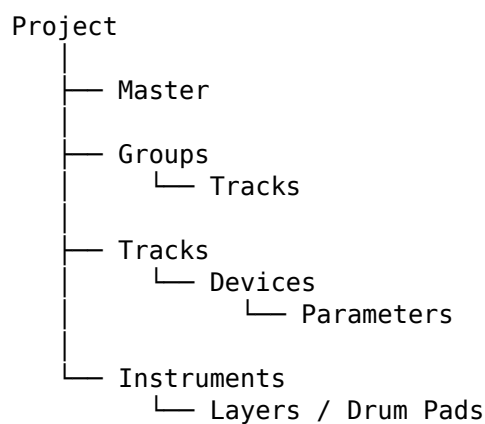
From a detailed track or device context:

```
Parameter
  ↑
Device
  ↑
Track
  ↑
Project
```

Touching the Master fader gives us a direct route to that project-level view.

The Hierarchy Keeps Expanding

At this point, our conceptual model looks something like:



The X-Touch does not expose all of this at once.

It exposes the level that is currently useful.

That is what keeps the surface manageable.

Project Control Is Still Feedback-Driven

Master Mode is another context where displays matter.

When the V-Pots no longer represent ordinary mixer or device parameters, the feedback tells you what they now mean.

That is especially important when some V-Pots are controlling values while others perform project-level actions.

Do not assume that a V-Pot still does what it did moments ago.

Read the controller.

Check the context.

Then act.

The same rule continues to pay off:

Observe before you adjust.

A Practical Master Workflow

A simple Master Mode workflow might look like this.

1. Touch the Master fader

This selects the Master track and enters Master Edit Mode.

2. Check the displays

Confirm that the controller is showing the Master/project context.

3. Adjust Master level if required

Use the Master fader or V-Pot 1.

4. Adjust Master panorama if required

Use V-Pot 2.

5. Toggle the audio engine only deliberately

Press V-Pot 3, 4 or 5 when you actually intend to change the project's audio-engine state.

6. Navigate projects if required

Use:

V-Pot 7

→ Previous Project

V-Pot 8

→ Next Project

7. Return to ordinary work

Select the required track or mode and continue.

The important thing is the shift in scale.

You temporarily step out of the track-level view, work at the project level, then return.

Project Navigation and Mouse-Lite Working

Project switching is another good example of Mouse-Lite philosophy.

The goal is not:

Never use Bitwig's project interface.

The goal is:

If you already know you want the previous or next project, why should that necessarily require the mouse?

The X-Touch gives you a direct physical route.

That is the recurring theme of this guide:

use the physical surface when it shortens the path between intention and action.

One Surface, Several Scales

By this point, the same X-Touch may have represented:

Project Tracks

Group Contents

Instrument Layers

Drum Pads

Device Parameters

Mixer Dimensions

Master / Project Controls

The hardware has not become larger.

The conceptual surface has.

That is the power of context.

The Important Idea

Master Mode changes the X-Touch's point of view from:

one part of the project

to:

the project-level Master context.

Touching the Master fader enters that mode.

The verified Master Edit Mode assignments are:

V-Pot 1

→ Master Volume

→ Press to reset

V-Pot 2

→ Master Panorama
→ Press to reset

V-Pots 3–5

→ Press to toggle
the project's audio engine

V-Pot 7

→ Previous Project

V-Pot 8

→ Next Project

And independently:

SHIFT + Master Fader
→ Metronome Volume

So our mental model expands once more:

Physical Control

+

Current Focus

+

Current Mode

+

Modifier, if any

=

Current Function

At track level, the focus is a track.

At Device level, it is a device.

Inside a Group, it may be a child track.

In Master Edit Mode, it is the Master and project context.

The same surface moves between all of them.

Coming Next

So far, we have looked at how to navigate, mix, automate and control increasingly complex structures.

The next chapter turns to another fundamental workflow:
recording.

DrivenByMoss gives the X-Touch explicit operations for:

- normal recording;
- Launcher overdub;
- Arranger overdub;

- clip creation;
- New Clip Length.

Next:

Advanced Recording and Overdub.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 19 - Advanced Recording and Overdub

Advanced Recording and Overdub

Recording sounds simple.

Press RECORD.

Play something.

Press STOP.

And for straightforward Arranger recording, that may be all you need.

But Bitwig has more than one recording environment.

It has the linear Arranger.

It has the performance-oriented Clip Launcher.

And it has overdub, where new material is added without replacing what is already there.

DrivenByMoss gives the X-Touch direct access to these different recording workflows.

The important thing is knowing which kind of recording you are asking Bitwig to perform.

The Basic RECORD Button

The normal RECORD button performs the most obvious function:

RECORD



Start / Stop Recording

This is the standard recording command.

For a conventional linear recording workflow:

Arm Track



Position Play Cursor



RECORD

↓

Perform

↓

STOP

there is nothing mysterious about it.

But RECORD also participates in two important modifier combinations.

Three RECORD Operations

DrivenByMoss documents these three RECORD commands:

RECORD

→ Start / Stop recording

SHIFT + RECORD

→ Toggle Launcher overdub

OPTION + RECORD

→ Create a new clip on the selected
track and slot,
start playback,
and enable overdub

These are not three variations of the same operation.

They represent three different recording intentions.

RECORD — Record Normally

Think:

Record.

RECORD

↓

Normal recording

This is the direct transport operation.

It is the appropriate starting point when your intention is simply to record in the normal Bitwig workflow.

SHIFT + RECORD — Launcher Overdub

Hold SHIFT and press RECORD:

SHIFT + RECORD

|

▼

Toggle Launcher Overdub

This does not merely start another ordinary recording pass.

It changes the Launcher overdub state.

Think:

When working with Launcher clips, allow new material to be added to what is already there.

OPTION + RECORD — Create, Play and Overdub

This is the more specialised command:

OPTION + RECORD

↓
Create new clip
on selected track and slot

↓
Start playback

↓
Enable overdub

That combination is particularly interesting because one physical command establishes an entire clip-recording state.

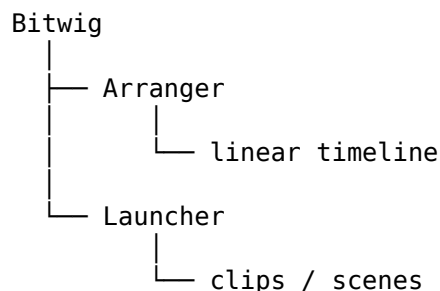
It does not merely toggle an existing setting.

It creates something and gets it ready for performance.

Arranger and Launcher

To understand these commands, we need to distinguish Bitwig's two principal working environments.

Conceptually:



Both can contain musical material.

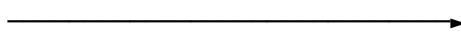
Both can participate in recording.

But they encourage different ways of working.

Arranger Thinking

The Arranger is fundamentally linear.

Think:

START  END

A song develops through time.

Recording naturally fits a model such as:

Bar 1
↓
Bar 2
↓
Bar 3
↓
Bar 4
↓
...

This is familiar tape-machine-style thinking.

Launcher Thinking

The Launcher is more modular.

Think:

Clip A Clip B Clip C
Clip D Clip E Clip F
Clip G Clip H Clip I

A clip can repeat.

Another clip can be launched.

Material can be built incrementally.

That makes overdub particularly important.

What Is Overdub?

Suppose a MIDI clip already contains:

Kick
Kick
Kick
Kick

You want to add a hi-hat pattern without losing the kicks.

Ordinary replacement recording would be the wrong idea.

Overdub means:

Existing material
+
New performance
=
Combined clip

So:

Pass 1
Kick Kick Kick Kick

Pass 2
 Hat Hat Hat Hat Hat Hat Hat Hat

Result
Kick+Hat Kick+Hat Kick+Hat Kick+Hat

The second pass adds to the first.

Overdub Is Layering in Time

A useful mental model is:

First pass
↓
Listen
↓
Second pass
↓
Add
↓
Third pass
↓
Add

The clip grows through repeated performances.

This is especially useful for:

- drum programming;
- percussion;
- layered MIDI parts;
- loop-based composition;
- performance-oriented workflows.

The OVR Button

The X-Touch has an OVR button.

In DrivenByMoss:

OVR
 → Toggle Arranger Overdub

and:

SHIFT + OVR
→ Toggle Launcher Overdub

This gives us a very useful pair:

OVR
→ Arranger overdub

SHIFT + OVR
→ Launcher overdub

The modifier changes the target environment.

RECORD and OVR Are Related but Different

It is worth separating two concepts.

RECORD answers:

Should recording run?

OVR answers:

When recording, should new material be added to existing material?

Conceptually:

RECORD
|
▼
Recording state

OVR
|
▼
Overdub behaviour

They interact, but they are not interchangeable.

A Useful Recording Map

The verified normal mapping can be summarised as:

RECORD
→ Start / Stop recording

SHIFT + RECORD
→ Toggle Launcher overdub

OPTION + RECORD
→ Create new clip
+ start playback
+ enable overdub

OVR
→ Toggle Arranger overdub
SHIFT + OVR

→ Toggle Launcher overdub

Notice something interesting:

SHIFT + RECORD

and:

SHIFT + OVR

both give access to Launcher overdub.

That is not a documentation mistake.

DrivenByMoss provides more than one physical route to the same state.

Why Provide Two Routes?

The two routes make sense in different contexts.

If your hand is already around the transport controls:

SHIFT + RECORD

may feel natural.

If you are thinking specifically in terms of overdub state:

SHIFT + OVR

may be easier to remember.

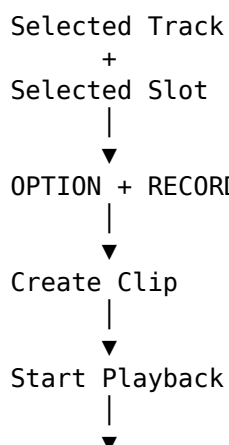
A control surface does not always need one and only one route to every function.

Sometimes redundancy makes a workflow easier.

OPTION + RECORD Is Different

OPTION + RECORD deserves special attention because it does more than toggle Launcher overdub.

It performs a sequence:



Enable Overdub

This is a workflow command.

One button combination prepares the selected Launcher location for loop-oriented recording.

Selected Track and Selected Slot Matter

OPTION + RECORD operates on:

Selected Track

+

Selected Slot

So before invoking it, establish the destination.

The command is powerful because it acts immediately.

That means focus matters.

A useful habit is:

Select destination

↓

Check destination

↓

OPTION + RECORD

As always:

Establish focus before performing an action that creates something.

New Clip Length

When creating clips from the controller, another setting becomes important:

New Clip Length

DrivenByMoss allows the default length for newly created clips to be configured.

This means the recording workflow can be prepared before the performance begins.

For example:

New Clip Length

↓

4 bars

↓

Create new clip

↓

Four-bar working structure

The exact choice depends on the music.

Setting New Clip Length from the Surface

DrivenByMoss also lets the X-Touch choose a new clip length using the track SELECT buttons with a modifier.

The eight choices are:

SHIFT + SELECT 1 → 16 bars

SHIFT + SELECT 2 → 8 bars

SHIFT + SELECT 3 → 4 bars

SHIFT + SELECT 4 → 2 bars

SHIFT + SELECT 5 → 1 bar

SHIFT + SELECT 6 → 2 beats

SHIFT + SELECT 7 → 1 beat

SHIFT + SELECT 8 → 32 bars

So New Clip Length does not necessarily require a trip to the DrivenByMoss preferences.

It can be changed directly from the surface.

The Order Is Worth Learning

The sequence is not simply shortest-to-longest or longest-to-shortest.

It is:

SELECT 1	16 bars
SELECT 2	8 bars
SELECT 3	4 bars
SELECT 4	2 bars
SELECT 5	1 bar
SELECT 6	2 beats
SELECT 7	1 beat
SELECT 8	32 bars

That final 32-bar assignment means it is worth learning the mapping rather than assuming the buttons form a perfectly linear progression.

This is exactly the sort of detail that will belong in the Quick Reference later.

ALT + SELECT and New Clip Length

DrivenByMoss's common edit-mode functions also document:

ALT + Track SELECT
→ Set the length of a new clip

The important conceptual point is that the channel SELECT row can participate in clip-length selection as well as track selection.

This is another example of modifiers turning familiar controls into a temporary command surface.

The exact controller feedback should always be observed when using these modified functions.

A Four-Bar Loop Workflow

Suppose you want to build a four-bar MIDI percussion loop.

A controller-oriented workflow could be:

1. Select four bars

Use the appropriate New Clip Length selection:

SHIFT + SELECT 3

2. Select the destination track and slot

Establish where the new clip should be created.

3. Press OPTION + RECORD

DrivenByMoss creates the clip, starts playback and enables overdub.

4. Play the first layer

For example:

Kick

5. Let the clip repeat

Listen to what you recorded.

6. Add another layer

For example:

Snare

7. Add another

Perhaps:

Hi-Hat

The clip grows while playback continues.

Building Rather Than Recording

This workflow changes the meaning of the word recording.

Instead of:

Record complete performance



Stop

we have:

Create loop



Add idea



Listen



Add idea



Listen



Add idea

That is closer to building than traditional recording.

The X-Touch can participate in both approaches.

Arranger Overdub

Now consider the Arranger.

Suppose a MIDI passage already exists and you want to add notes without replacing the existing performance.

Enable:

OVR

DrivenByMoss toggles Arranger overdub.

Conceptually:

Existing Arranger material



New recorded material



Combined result

This is the linear-timeline counterpart to Launcher overdub.

Launcher Overdub

For Launcher clips:

SHIFT + OVR

toggles Launcher overdub.

Or:

SHIFT + RECORD

can toggle the same Launcher overdub state.

So the conceptual distinction remains simple:

OVR

→ Arranger

SHIFT + OVR

→ Launcher

even though Launcher overdub also has the SHIFT + RECORD route.

A Note About Audio and MIDI

Overdub is particularly easy to understand with MIDI because new notes can be added to an existing clip.

For example:

Pass 1 Kick

Pass 2 Snare

Pass 3 Hats

produces one increasingly complete MIDI performance.

Do not assume that every audio-recording situation behaves identically.

Bitwig's recording behaviour depends on the type of track, clip and recording context.

Project XTC's concern here is the X-Touch command mapping:

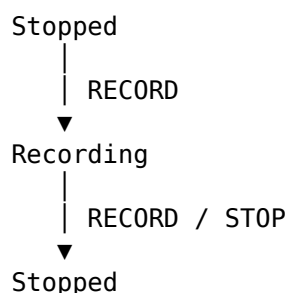
which recording state
or overdub state
does the controller request?

The detailed editing consequences remain Bitwig behaviour.

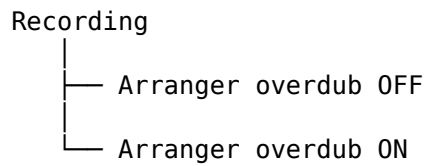
Recording Is a State Machine

It can help to think of the recording controls as changing states.

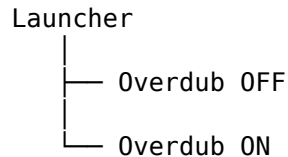
For example:



Then overdub adds another dimension:



And Launcher operation has its own overdub state:



Thinking in terms of states helps explain why several buttons can appear to affect “recording” while actually controlling different aspects of it.

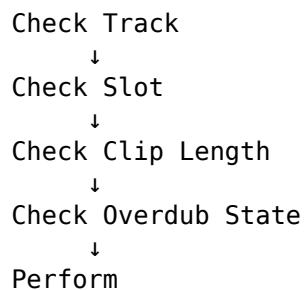
Check the State Before Performing

Recording commands are consequential.

A mistaken Pan value is easy to undo.

Recording into the wrong clip or changing the wrong overdub state can be more disruptive.

So before beginning:



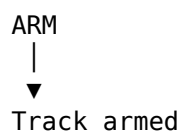
The more fluent you become, the faster this check becomes.

Eventually it is no more cumbersome than glancing at a mixer before moving a fader.

Arm Is Still Important

The channel-strip ARM buttons remain the obvious way to establish recording targets.

Press the ARM button for the appropriate track:



DrivenByMoss also provides:

SHIFT + ARM

to toggle the record-arm state across all tracks in the active Bitwig bank page.

That can be powerful, so use it deliberately.

One Track Versus the Bank

The distinction is:

ARM

→ specific track

versus:

SHIFT + ARM

→ toggle record-arm state
across tracks in active bank page

Again, the modifier changes the scale of the command.

This is a pattern we have seen throughout the X-Touch.

Monitoring from the Surface

DrivenByMoss also provides channel-strip monitoring commands:

SHIFT + MUTE

→ Toggle monitor

SHIFT + SOLO

→ Toggle auto monitor

These functions belong naturally to a recording workflow.

Before recording, you may need to determine how the armed track is monitored.

The X-Touch can therefore participate not only in:

recording

but also:

arming
monitoring
overdubbing

Recording Without Constant Screen Attention

A hardware-oriented recording workflow might become:

SELECT track

↓

ARM

↓

Set monitoring if needed
↓
Choose recording / overdub state
↓
RECORD
↓
Perform
↓
STOP

For Launcher loop building:

Choose clip length
↓
Select track / slot
↓
OPTION + RECORD
↓
Perform
↓
Overdub
↓
Listen

The computer screen remains available.

It simply does not have to mediate every step.

Recording and Musical Attention

This matters because recording is one of the moments when you least want to be thinking about software.

You may be:

- playing a keyboard;
- holding a guitar;
- singing;
- programming drums;
- manipulating another controller.

Every unnecessary mouse operation interrupts that activity.

A control surface can move routine recording operations into physical memory.

Eventually:

I want another pass

becomes:

hand moves
button pressed
continue playing

without requiring a menu search.

Launcher-Oriented Users

There is an important DrivenByMoss preference that affects the recording controls:

Flip arranger and clip record / automation

When enabled, the normal and SHIFT functions of the Record and Automation buttons are flipped between Arranger-oriented and Clip-oriented behaviour.

This exists for users who spend more time in the Clip Launcher than the Arranger.

Conceptually:

Default configuration

Normal

→ Arranger-oriented function

SHIFT

→ Launcher-oriented function

can become:

Flipped configuration

Normal

→ Launcher-oriented function

SHIFT

→ Arranger-oriented function

We will discuss this preference properly in Chapter 21.

Why the Flip Preference Matters

Without knowing about this preference, two people can press the same physical buttons and report apparently contradictory behaviour.

One says:

RECORD does this.

Another says:

No, SHIFT + RECORD does that.

Both controllers may be behaving correctly.

Their DrivenByMoss configuration may simply differ.

This reinforces an important documentation rule:

When behaviour can be configured, describe the default and identify the preference that can change it.

Recording and Automation Are Parallel Ideas

Recording musical notes and recording automation are conceptually related.

In both cases:

You perform something

↓

Bitwig captures it

↓

Bitwig reproduces it later

For notes:

play notes

↓

record MIDI

For automation:

move fader

↓

record automation

This is one reason the X-Touch can feel so natural in both roles.

It turns software recording into a physical act.

Overdub as a Performance Tool

Overdub is not merely a technical recording option.

It can become part of a performance.

Imagine building a rhythmic clip:

Loop 1

→ kick

Loop 2

→ add snare

Loop 3

→ add hats

Loop 4

→ add percussion

The arrangement develops through physical performance rather than through drawing notes.

The X-Touch's role is not to create the musical material.

Its role is to make the recording state accessible while the musical material is being created.

A Practical Launcher Workflow

A useful practice exercise is:

1. Create an empty MIDI track

Load an instrument.

2. Select a four-bar New Clip Length

Use:

SHIFT + SELECT 3

3. Select an empty Launcher slot

Make sure the intended track and slot are selected.

4. Press OPTION + RECORD

The clip is created, playback starts and overdub is enabled.

5. Play a simple pattern

Do not try to make it complicated.

6. Let it loop

Listen.

7. Add another part

Use the active overdub state to layer another performance.

8. Toggle Launcher overdub if required

Use:

SHIFT + RECORD

or:

SHIFT + OVR

9. Listen again

The aim of the exercise is not the music.

It is learning the physical relationship between:

Clip

+

Recording

+

Overdub

+

X-Touch

A Practical Arranger Workflow

For comparison:

1. Select and arm the track

Use the channel-strip controls.

2. Position the play cursor

Use the transport controls or Jog Wheel.

3. Decide whether Arranger overdub is required

If yes:

OVR

4. Press RECORD

Begin recording.

5. Perform

Concentrate on the music.

6. Press STOP

Finish the pass.

7. Listen

Decide whether another pass is required.

This is much closer to a traditional linear recording workflow.

The same hardware supports both models.

Do Not Memorise Everything at Once

There are several commands in this chapter.

You do not need to learn all of them simultaneously.

Start with:

RECORD

→ Record

OVR

→ Arranger overdub

Then add:

SHIFT + RECORD

→ Launcher overdub

Then:

OPTION + RECORD

→ New clip + play + overdub

Once those are familiar, the rest becomes easier to place around them.

This is the same learning strategy we have used throughout Project XTC:

Build a mental model first. Add commands to it gradually.

The Important Idea

The X-Touch does not have one generic concept called “recording”.

DrivenByMoss exposes several related states and operations.

The verified normal mappings are:

RECORD

→ Start / Stop recording

SHIFT + RECORD

→ Toggle Launcher overdub

OPTION + RECORD

→ Create a new clip on the
selected track and slot,
start playback,
enable overdub

OVR

→ Toggle Arranger overdub

SHIFT + OVR

→ Toggle Launcher overdub

And the channel strips contribute:

ARM

→ Arm specific track

SHIFT + ARM

→ Toggle record-arm state
across the active bank

SHIFT + MUTE

→ Toggle monitor

SHIFT + SOLO

→ Toggle auto monitor

The important question is therefore not simply:

How do I record?

It is:

What am I recording, where am I recording it, and do I want to replace or add to what is already there?

Once that intention is clear, the X-Touch command becomes much easier to choose.

Coming Next

We now have most of the pieces.

We can:

- navigate tracks and banks;
- control devices;
- browse;
- mix;
- use modifiers;
- work with markers;
- perform automation;
- enter Groups, Layers and Drum Pads;
- control the Master context;
- record and overdub.

The next question is:

What does all of this feel like when we stop thinking about individual features and actually use the X-Touch to make music?

Next:

Towards a Mouse-Free — or Mouse-Lite — Workflow.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 20 - Towards a Mouse-Free — or Mouse-Lite — Workflow

Towards a Mouse-Free — or Mouse-Lite — Workflow

We now know a great many things the X-Touch can do.

We can:

- select tracks;
- move through banks;
- control volume, panorama and Sends;
- navigate devices and parameter pages;
- browse for devices and presets;
- work with markers;
- control automation;
- enter Groups, Layers and Drum Pads;
- record and overdub;
- navigate the project.

But knowing a collection of commands is not the same thing as having a workflow.

The real question is:

Can the X-Touch disappear into the process of making music?

That is what this chapter is about.

Mouse-Free Is Not the Goal

The phrase mouse-free sounds attractive.

It suggests complete command of the DAW from hardware.

But taken literally, it can become a trap.

You may find yourself performing six button presses merely to avoid one easy mouse click.

That is not efficiency.

That is ideology.

So Project XTC prefers another phrase:

Mouse-Lite.

The aim is not to eliminate the mouse.

The aim is to stop reaching for it automatically.

The Mouse Is Still Excellent at Some Things

A mouse or trackpad is extremely good for:

- detailed editing;
- drawing;
- dragging;
- arranging clips visually;
- inspecting complex interfaces;
- operations you perform rarely;
- tasks where the screen itself contains the useful information.

The X-Touch is extremely good for:

- repeated mixer operations;
- simultaneous controls;
- tactile adjustments;
- transport;
- navigation;
- performance;
- automation;
- operations that benefit from muscle memory.

So the useful question is not:

Can I do this without the mouse?

It is:

Which tool gives me the shortest and clearest route to what I want?

Intention Before Control

Throughout this guide, we have gradually moved away from thinking in terms of buttons.

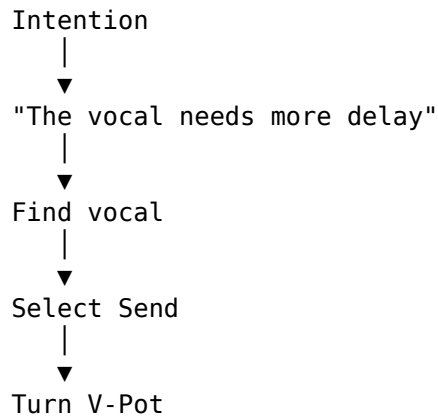
Instead of:

Which button does what?

we can increasingly think:

What am I trying to do?

For example:



The hardware becomes a route from intention to result.

That is the real goal.

A Working Vocabulary

By now, a relatively small set of concepts explains a large proportion of the controller.

SELECT

→ establish focus

BANK / CHANNEL

→ move the window

MODE

→ change what the controls represent

MODIFIER

→ temporarily extend a control

V-POT

→ adjust the current parameter

FADER

→ make a continuous physical adjustment

DISPLAY

→ tell us what the controls currently mean

And hierarchical navigation adds:

SELECT again

→ enter, where appropriate

Long-press SELECT

→ leave

This vocabulary matters more than memorising hundreds of isolated commands.

Observe Before You Adjust

The X-Touch is contextual.

A V-Pot may control:

Pan

then:

Send level

then:

Device parameter

then:

Drum Pad level

then:

Master panorama

The physical control has not changed.

Its meaning has.

So before turning something:

Look at the feedback.

This simple habit prevents a large proportion of control-surface mistakes.

A Three-Step Habit

A useful general workflow is:

1. Establish focus
2. Establish mode
3. Adjust

For example:

Select Bass

↓

SEND

↓

Turn V-Pot

Or:

Select Synth

↓

DEVICE

↓

Turn parameter V-Pot

Or:

Select Drums

↓

SELECT again

↓

Work inside Group

Once that sequence becomes habitual, the X-Touch feels far less complicated.

Navigation Without Losing the Plot

Large projects create a particular problem.

It is easy to lose track of:

Where am I?

The X-Touch may currently represent:

- top-level tracks;
- tracks inside a Group;
- Layers;
- Drum Pads;
- Device parameters;
- Sends;
- Master controls.

So Mouse-Lite working depends on having a reliable mental route back.

Hierarchical Navigation

With hierarchical Track navigation, the verified Group workflow is:

SELECT Group

↓

Group selected

↓

SELECT same Group again

↓

Enter Group

↓

Long-press any SELECT

↓

Leave Group

Layers and Drum Pads follow the same broad idea:

SELECT containing track

↓

SELECT same track again

↓

Enter Layers / Drum Pads

↓

Long-press any SELECT

↓

Leave

This gives us a compact navigation vocabulary:

SELECT
→ focus

SELECT again
→ descend

Long SELECT
→ ascend

Don't Use ENTER and CANCEL for Hierarchy

ENTER and CANCEL are useful X-Touch controls, but they are not the Group-navigation pair.

Their particularly important role is in Browser Mode:

ENTER
→ confirm Browser selection

CANCEL
→ discard Browser selection

So when navigating project hierarchy, keep the mental model centred on SELECT.

When browsing, ENTER and CANCEL regain their obvious confirm/cancel roles.

This separation makes both workflows easier to remember.

Work at the Highest Useful Level

Suppose the drums are too loud.

There are several possible responses.

You could enter the Drums Group, adjust the kick, snare, hats and percussion individually, then rebalance everything.

Or:

Drums Group
|
▼
Lower Group fader

If that solves the problem, stop there.

A useful rule is:

Work at the highest level that solves the musical problem.

Only descend into detail when the problem itself is detailed.

Banks Are Not an Obstacle

An eight-channel controller cannot show a forty-track project simultaneously.

That does not mean it cannot control one efficiently.

Think of the X-Touch as a window:

Project

eight channels

BANK moves the window by eight.

CHANNEL moves it by one.

Hierarchy changes the level at which the window is looking.

Together:

BANK

→ move widely

CHANNEL

→ move precisely

SELECT again

→ move deeper

Long SELECT

→ move outward

That is a surprisingly capable navigation system.

Keep Related Tracks Together

The controller becomes easier to use when the Bitwig project itself has a sensible structure.

For example:

Drums

Bass

Guitars

Keys

Vocals

FX

is easier to navigate than a project whose tracks are scattered arbitrarily.

Hardware workflow and project organisation reinforce one another.

A well-organised Bitwig project makes the X-Touch feel more intelligent.

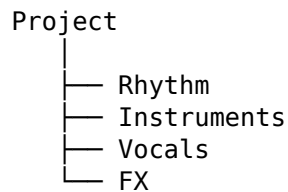
A chaotic project makes the controller work harder.

Use Groups as Navigation Landmarks

Groups are not only useful for audio routing.

They can become landmarks.

For example:



With hierarchical navigation, those top-level Groups form a compact map of the project.

Enter only the area you currently need.

This can be much easier than continually banking through a long flat list of tracks.

Device Work Without Hunting

Suppose you want to change a synthesizer parameter.

A screen-first workflow might be:

```
find track
↓
click track
↓
find device
↓
click device
↓
find parameter
↓
drag parameter
```

With a familiar X-Touch workflow:

```
SELECT track
↓
DEVICE
↓
choose device / page
↓
turn V-Pot
```

In Device Mode:

```
BANK ← / →
      → previous / next device
```

```
CHANNEL ← / →
        → previous / next parameter page
```

And the modifiers give us faster direct selection:

Hold CONTROL

- display devices
- press V-Pot to choose one

Hold OPTION

- display parameter pages
- press V-Pot to choose one

The aim is not to avoid looking at the device forever.

It is to make routine parameter work available physically.

Pin What Matters

DrivenByMoss provides:

OPTION + TRACK

- Pin cursor track

OPTION + DEVICE

- Pin cursor device

Pinning can be useful when you want the controller's focus to remain attached to something while other activity happens in Bitwig.

This is another Mouse-Lite principle:

If the thing you care about keeps moving away, pin it rather than repeatedly finding it again.

Mixing by Ear

The X-Touch becomes particularly valuable when the screen is no longer the centre of attention.

Try balancing several tracks while deliberately looking away from Bitwig.

Use the faders.

Listen.

Then look back.

This exercise reveals something important.

With a mouse, mixing can easily become:

look

↓

move

↓

look

↓

move

With physical faders:

listen
↓
move
↓
listen

That is a different relationship with the music.

More Than One Control at Once

A mouse pointer controls one thing at a time.

Your hands do not have that limitation.

For example:

Left hand
→ Vocal fader

Right hand
→ Delay return fader

or:

Finger 1
→ Kick

Finger 2
→ Bass

This is one of the strongest arguments for a physical mixing surface.

The advantage is not merely that a fader is nicer than a mouse.

It is that several physical controls can be part of one gesture.

FLIP When the Fader Is the Better Instrument

Sometimes a parameter normally lives on a V-Pot but would be easier to perform with a fader.

That is where FLIP becomes useful.

Conceptually:

Parameter on V-Pot
↓
▼
FLIP
↓
▼
Parameter on Fader

The fader gives you:

- longer travel;
- touch sensitivity;

- motorised feedback;
- a different physical gesture.

For automation or expressive Send rides, this can be much more natural.

Automation as Performance

With a mouse, automation often means drawing.

With the X-Touch it can mean performing.

```

Listen
  ↓
Touch fader
  ↓
Move
  ↓
Release
  ↓
Listen back

```

In TOUCH mode, the automation can return to the existing behaviour after you release the fader.

In LATCH, the new value continues.

So instead of thinking:

I need to edit the automation curve.

you can sometimes think:

I need to play this movement.

Recording Without Breaking the Performance

Recording is another area where physical controls can preserve musical attention.

A normal recording workflow might be:

```

SELECT track
  ↓
ARM
  ↓
RECORD
  ↓
perform
  ↓
STOP

```

For Launcher-oriented loop building:

```

Select track / slot
  ↓
Choose New Clip Length

```


↓
OPTION + RECORD
↓
New clip created
↓
Playback starts
↓
Overdub enabled
↓
Perform

The point is not that the X-Touch magically creates the performance.

It removes some of the software-management interruption surrounding it.

Markers as Musical Landmarks

Markers are another powerful Mouse-Lite tool.

Instead of dragging the play cursor around a long arrangement, use meaningful locations.

For example:

Intro

Verse

Chorus

Breakdown

Outro

DrivenByMoss provides:

OPTION + MARKER
→ Insert marker at current play position

OPTION + REWIND
→ Previous marker

OPTION + FORWARD
→ Next marker

And Marker Mode allows the V-Pots to start playback from marker positions.

Markers turn a long timeline into a set of named musical destinations.

A Practical Mixing Session

Let's put several ideas together.

Imagine a project containing:

Drums
Bass
Skank Guitar
Organ

Percussion
Lead
Vocal
FX

You press PLAY.

The mix begins.

The Bass Is Too Loud

Your hand goes directly to the Bass fader.

Bass too loud
↓
Bass fader
↓
lower

No menu.

No cursor.

No visual search.

The Vocal Needs More Delay

Select the Vocal track.

Enter the appropriate Send context.

Turn the V-Pot.

SELECT Vocal
↓
SEND
↓
choose delay Send
↓
turn

Listen to the result.

The Delay Needs a Performance Ride

Perhaps a simple static Send level is not enough.

You want the final word of the phrase to explode into delay.

Use FLIP if appropriate to place the Send on a fader.

Then perform the movement.

phrase plays
↓
raise Send

↓
word hits delay
↓
pull Send back

That is not merely editing.

It is mixing as performance.

A Dub-Oriented Example

This becomes especially interesting in dub.

A traditional dub mix treats the mixer almost like an instrument.

Channels disappear.

Echoes appear.

Reverb blooms.

Elements are dropped and returned.

The X-Touch is well suited to this because the physical controls encourage exactly that kind of interaction.

Start with a Stable Mix

Imagine:

- 1 Drums
- 2 Bass
- 3 Skank
- 4 Organ
- 5 Percussion
- 6 Vocal
- 7 FX Return 1
- 8 FX Return 2

First establish a sensible balance.

The point is to have a stable place from which to perform.

Drop the Vocal

At the end of a phrase:

Vocal
↓
MUTE

The space suddenly opens.

Throw the Last Word into Delay

Before muting or dropping the vocal, increase its delay Send.

Vocal Send
↑
last word
↓
delay repeats

Then bring the Send back.

The echo continues while the dry vocal disappears.

That is a classic dub gesture.

Ride the Return

The effect return itself can be treated dynamically.

Delay Return
|
— raise
— lower
— mute
— return

The effect becomes part of the performance rather than a static processor.

Work with Several Controls

One hand might ride the vocal Send.

The other might ride the effect return.

Left hand
→ Vocal Send

Right hand
→ Delay Return

That interaction is extremely awkward with one mouse pointer.

With physical controls it is natural.

Groups Make Performance Mixes Manageable

Suppose the project is larger than eight tracks.

Create meaningful Groups:

Drums
Bass
Instruments
Vocals
FX

At the top level, those Groups become performance landmarks.

If the whole drum section needs changing:

Drums Group fader

may be enough.

If the snare needs changing:

SELECT Drums

↓

SELECT Drums again

↓

find Snare

↓

adjust

Then long-press SELECT to leave the Group.

The hierarchy follows the level of musical attention.

Drum Machines Can Become Performance Mixers

A Drum Machine can itself become a physical submixer.

Select the containing track.

Press SELECT again to enter its Drum Pads.

Now the channel strips may represent:

Kick

Snare

Hat

Clap

Perc

Rim

Shaker

Tamb

You can now:

- mute individual elements;
- solo them;
- change levels;
- change panorama;
- adjust Sends.

This can turn a single Bitwig track into a surprisingly tactile performance environment.

Don't Forget the Displays

In a fast performance workflow, the danger is assuming.

You think Channel 4 is still the Organ.

But perhaps you entered a Group.

Or changed bank.

Or switched mode.

Now Channel 4 means something else.

So develop a glance habit:

Intention



quick glance



physical action

Not:

physical action



"Oh."

The displays are there to keep the contextual surface understandable.

Use the Screen for Confirmation, Not Permission

A mature Mouse-Lite workflow often changes the role of the computer display.

Initially:

Look at screen



decide



act

Later:

hear / decide



act physically



glance if confirmation is useful

The screen remains important.

It simply stops being the starting point for every operation.

Learn the Surface in Layers

Do not try to become Mouse-Lite by memorising the entire manual.

Build the workflow gradually.

A useful progression is:

Transport



Volume

↓
Pan
↓
Mute / Solo
↓
Banks
↓
Sends
↓
Devices
↓
Modifiers
↓
Markers
↓
Hierarchy
↓
Automation
↓
Recording

At each stage, use the physical control until it becomes automatic.

Then add another layer.

Muscle Memory Is the Real Upgrade

The X-Touch becomes faster not because its buttons change.

It becomes faster because you stop thinking about them.

At first:

I want Send 2
↓
Which button?
↓
Which mode?
↓
Which knob?

Later:

I want more delay
↓
hand moves

That is the transition we are aiming for.

Do Not Optimise Rare Tasks

Suppose you perform an operation once every six months.

You discover that it can technically be achieved through:

modifier
+
mode
+

three button presses

+

V-Pot

but you cannot remember the sequence.

Use the mouse.

There is no failure in that.

Hardware shortcuts earn their value through repetition.

A useful rule is:

The more often you perform something, the more valuable a physical workflow becomes.

Use Customisation to Remove Repeated Friction

Later, Chapter 22 will look at assignable controls.

The principle is simple.

Do not customise because a button is available.

Customise because you repeatedly encounter this:

intention

↓

awkward route

↓

same awkward route

↓

same awkward route

Then a custom control can turn it into:

intention

↓

button

Customisation should simplify an established workflow, not replace the process of learning one.

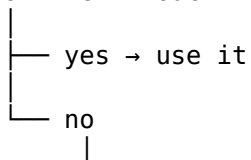
A Mouse-Lite Test

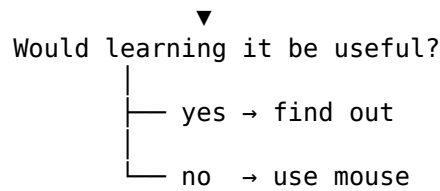
Try working for ten minutes with one rule:

Do not reach for the mouse immediately.

When you want to do something, ask:

Do I know the X-Touch route?



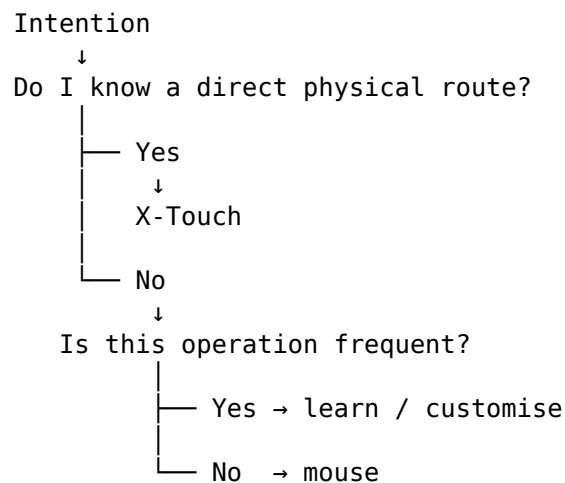


This avoids both extremes.

You are neither mouse-dependent nor hardware-dogmatic.

The Mouse-Lite Loop

Over time, the process becomes:



That is a sustainable workflow.

A Controller Should Reduce Thought

This may sound paradoxical after a guide containing twenty chapters.

But the purpose of learning the controller is eventually to think about it less.

At first:

hardware
↓
thinking
↓
music

Eventually:

intention
↓
movement
↓
music

The hardware disappears from conscious attention.

That is when it becomes useful.

What Should Stay on the Screen?

Even in a strongly hardware-oriented workflow, the screen remains excellent for information that is fundamentally visual.

For example:

- waveform editing;
- piano-roll editing;
- arrangement structure;
- automation detail;
- plugin interfaces;
- complex routing;
- naming;
- file management.

The X-Touch does not need to replace these things.

It complements them.

What Should Move to the Surface?

Operations that benefit particularly from hardware include:

- transport;
- volume;
- panorama;
- Sends;
- Mute and Solo;
- track selection;
- bank navigation;
- device parameters;
- automation performance;
- marker navigation;
- recording;
- repeated performance actions.

These are operations where physical location and muscle memory can outperform pointing and clicking.

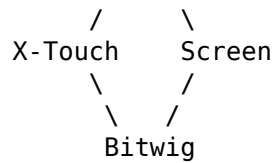
The Screen and Surface Are Partners

The most productive model is therefore not:

X-Touch
VS
Mouse

It is:

You
/ \



Each interface does the work it is best suited to.

The skill lies in moving naturally between them.

A Complete Example

Imagine you are working on a song.

You want to:

1. move to the chorus;
2. lower the bass slightly;
3. add delay to the vocal;
4. adjust a synth parameter;
5. ride the vocal level;
6. record another percussion layer.

A Mouse-Lite workflow might be:

Marker navigation

```
↓
Chorus
↓
Bass fader
↓
SELECT Vocal
↓
SEND
↓
adjust delay
↓
SELECT Synth
↓
DEVICE
↓
adjust parameter
↓
SELECT Vocal
↓
TOUCH automation
↓
perform fader ride
↓
SELECT percussion track / slot
↓
OPTION + RECORD
↓
perform overdub
```

The mouse may not be needed.

But if you then decide to redraw one MIDI note:

use the mouse

That is exactly what Mouse-Lite means.

Fluency Beats Purity

The best X-Touch workflow is not the one with the fewest mouse clicks.

It is the one with the least unnecessary friction.

Sometimes that means:

fader

Sometimes:

V-Pot

Sometimes:

button

Sometimes:

mouse

The important thing is that the choice becomes deliberate rather than habitual.

The Important Idea

A control surface becomes powerful when you stop thinking of it as a collection of features.

Think instead in terms of musical intentions:

"That is too loud."

"That needs more delay."

"Take me to the chorus."

"Open the synth."

"Let me ride this level."

"Record another layer."

"Show me the snare."

Then let the X-Touch provide the physical route.

The recurring model is:

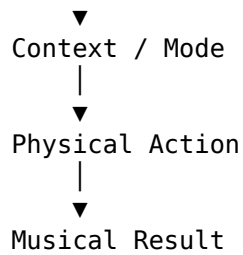
Intention

|



Focus

|



And when another interface is genuinely better:

use it

Mouse-Lite is not a restriction.

It is the freedom to choose the right interface without automatically defaulting to the mouse.

Coming Next

The workflow is becoming increasingly physical.

But much of that fluency depends on how DrivenByMoss itself is configured.

Choices such as:

- Flat or Hierarchical track navigation;
- New Clip Length;
- fader-touch behaviour;
- startup mode;
- Arranger versus Launcher priority;
- knob sensitivity;

can change how the controller behaves.

So before customising individual buttons, we should make sure the underlying system is configured deliberately.

Next:

Configuring DrivenByMoss for the X-Touch.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 21 - Configuring DrivenByMoss for the X-Touch

Configuring DrivenByMoss for the X-Touch

For most of this guide, we have concentrated on the X-Touch itself.

Press this button.

Turn this V-Pot.

Move this fader.

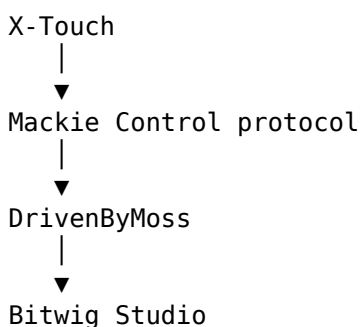
Enter this mode.

But there is another part of the system that we have deliberately kept in the background:

DrivenByMoss configuration.

The X-Touch does not communicate with Bitwig in isolation.

The complete system is:



DrivenByMoss sits between the hardware and the DAW.

Its configuration therefore determines some important aspects of how the surface behaves.

Configuration Is Part of the Instrument

It is tempting to think of configuration as something separate from actually making music.

Open Settings.

Choose some options.

Close Settings.

Forget about them.

But configuration can have a direct effect on the musical workflow.

Consider New Clip Length.

If you regularly create four-bar clips, configuring that behaviour in advance removes a decision from the recording process.

Instead of:

```
Create clip
  ↓
Choose length
  ↓
Confirm
  ↓
Record
```

you can move towards:

```
Create
  ↓
Record
```

The configuration has become part of the workflow.

A useful principle is:

Configure beforehand so that you have less to configure while making music.

The Configuration Page

DrivenByMoss settings are accessed from Bitwig's controller configuration.

The precise appearance may vary slightly between Bitwig and DrivenByMoss versions, but the basic idea is the same.

The controller entry represents the connection between:

```
Bitwig
  ↑
DrivenByMoss
  ↑
X-Touch
```

This is where the controller's MIDI ports and behaviour are configured.

Choose the Correct Controller

The X-Touch should be configured using the appropriate Mackie MCU controller implementation supplied by DrivenByMoss.

This matters because the X-Touch can operate in several hardware protocols.

Project XTC assumes that the unit is operating in:

MC — Mackie Control mode.

If the X-Touch is operating in another protocol, the behaviour described throughout this guide should not be expected to match.

Confirm MC Mode on the X-Touch

The X-Touch's operating mode is selected on the hardware.

For use with this guide, confirm:

Mode



MC

rather than one of the alternative controller protocols.

Once selected and confirmed, the X-Touch communicates using the Mackie Control protocol expected by DrivenByMoss.

This is the foundation on which everything else depends.

MIDI Ports

The X-Touch exposes MIDI ports to the computer.

On a typical system these may include names such as:

X-Touch INT

X-Touch EXT

The INT connection is the one associated with the main internal X-Touch control surface.

The EXT connection exists for expansion-related communication.

For a single X-Touch used as the main controller, make sure the DrivenByMoss controller entry is connected to the appropriate X-Touch MIDI input and output.

The important relationship is:

X-Touch MIDI OUT



DrivenByMoss Input

DrivenByMoss Output



X-Touch MIDI IN

Communication must work in both directions.

Why Both Directions Matter

The X-Touch is not merely sending commands to Bitwig.

Bitwig is also sending information back.

For example:

Move fader

↓

Bitwig parameter changes

but also:

Bitwig parameter changes

↓

Motor fader moves

Likewise, DrivenByMoss sends information for:

- displays;
- LEDs;
- V-Pot rings;
- motor faders.

So an apparently half-working controller can be a useful diagnostic clue.

If Bitwig responds to the X-Touch but the X-Touch does not update correctly, check the return path.

The control surface needs a conversation, not a monologue.

A Simple Connection Test

After configuring the ports, perform a few basic tests.

Test 1 — Fader to Bitwig

Move a channel fader.

Does the corresponding Bitwig value move?

Test 2 — Bitwig to Fader

Change that value in Bitwig.

Does the physical fader move?

Test 3 — Track Selection

Press SELECT.

Does Bitwig select the expected track?

Test 4 — Display Feedback

Does the X-Touch display meaningful track or parameter information?

Test 5 — Transport

Press PLAY and STOP.

Does Bitwig respond correctly?

If all five work, the basic two-way connection is in good shape.

Don't Troubleshoot Advanced Features First

If Device Mode or Browser Mode appears not to work, it can be tempting to start changing advanced settings.

Before doing that, verify the basics.

A useful troubleshooting order is:

```
Hardware mode
  ↓
MIDI ports
  ↓
Basic transport
  ↓
Track control
  ↓
Feedback
  ↓
Advanced modes
```

There is little value debugging an advanced feature while the underlying controller connection is incorrect.

DrivenByMoss Behaviour Settings

Once the basic connection works, the more interesting configuration begins.

DrivenByMoss provides settings that influence how the MCU surface behaves.

Not every user will want the same choices.

That is intentional.

The controller should adapt to the workflow.

Flat or Hierarchical Track Navigation

Chapter 17 introduced two ways of thinking about project tracks:

Flat

and:

Hierarchical

The choice affects how Groups are represented and navigated.

Flat Navigation

A flatter approach prioritises moving through tracks as a sequence.

Conceptually:

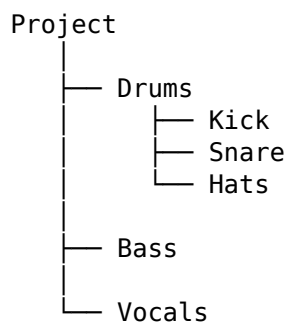
Track 1
Track 2
Track 3
Track 4
Track 5
...

This can be convenient if you mostly want rapid access to individual tracks regardless of Group structure.

Hierarchical Navigation

A hierarchical approach preserves the structure of Groups.

Conceptually:



This allows the controller's view to move into and out of Groups.

Neither approach is inherently better.

They answer different needs.

Choosing the Navigation Style

Ask how you think about large projects.

If your mental model is:

Give me a long mixer and let me move along it.

a flatter approach may feel natural.

If your mental model is:

Let me see the broad structure and then drill into what I need.

hierarchical navigation may be more useful.

The second approach fits particularly well with the workflow developed in Chapters 17 and 20:

```
Project
  ↓
Group
  ↓
Track
  ↓
work
  ↓
back out
```

But the correct choice is the one that matches the way you actually work.

New Clip Length

Chapter 19 introduced New Clip Length.

This determines the length used when the controller creates a new Launcher clip.

For example:

1 bar

2 bars

4 bars

8 bars

The useful setting depends on the music.

If you frequently build four-bar patterns, a four-bar default may reduce unnecessary interaction.

If you normally work with longer phrases, another value may make more sense.

This is a good example of configuration serving muscle memory.

Once the setting matches your normal workflow, you stop thinking about it.

Configure for the Common Case

A useful general principle is:

Set defaults for what you do most often, not for every theoretical possibility.

Suppose:

70% of new clips → 4 bars
20% → 8 bars
10% → something else

A four-bar default is probably sensible.

The fact that some clips require another length does not make the default wrong.

A good default reduces work most of the time.

V-Pot Behaviour

Rotary encoders can behave differently depending on the type of parameter and the controller configuration.

DrivenByMoss translates the MCU encoder messages into Bitwig parameter changes and returns feedback to the V-Pot rings and displays.

The practical goal is simple:

Turn
↓
Predictable change
↓
Useful visual feedback

If V-Pots seem excessively fast, slow or otherwise unintuitive, check the available DrivenByMoss configuration before assuming that the hardware itself is at fault.

Touch Sensitivity and Motor Faders

The X-Touch's touch-sensitive motor faders are central to:

- automation;
- parameter feedback;
- FLIP;
- track volume control.

They depend on correct two-way communication.

A useful diagnostic distinction is:

Fader sends values but does not move

Check the controller's output path back to the X-Touch.

Fader moves but touch behaviour is unexpected

Check:

- the current automation mode;
- the current controller context;
- relevant DrivenByMoss behaviour.

Do not immediately assume a mechanical fault.

Context matters.

Display Configuration

The scribble strips are not decoration.

As Chapter 7 established, they are part of the control system.

They tell you what the physical controls currently represent.

A useful configuration should therefore favour readable, meaningful feedback.

Remember the relationship:

Mode changes

↓

Assignments change

↓

Displays change

↓

You know what the controls mean

Without the last step, a deeply contextual control surface becomes much harder to use.

Parameter Names and Values

When Device Mode exposes parameters, the X-Touch has limited display space.

DrivenByMoss must compress information that Bitwig may normally display in a much larger graphical interface.

So do not expect the scribble strip to reproduce the entire Bitwig parameter description.

The aim is:

enough information to identify the control confidently.

That is another reason familiarity matters.

A short parameter label that initially looks cryptic may become immediately recognisable after repeated use.

Configuration for Particular Workflows

Rather than asking which settings are "best", it is often more useful to ask:

Best for what?

Configuration for Conventional Mixing

If the X-Touch is primarily being used as a mixer, priorities may include:

- predictable track banking;
- clear track names;
- immediate fader control;
- panorama access;
- Sends;
- Mute and Solo;
- automation.

The desired experience is:

```
Select
  ↓
Mix
  ↓
Bank
  ↓
Continue mixing
```

Complex hierarchical navigation may be less important if the project structure is relatively simple.

Configuration for Large Projects

For projects containing many Groups, hierarchical navigation becomes more attractive.

For example:

```
Drums
Bass
Guitars
Keys
Vocals
FX
```

can provide a compact top-level view.

Then:

SELECT Drums



ENTER



Kick

Snare

Hats

Toms

Percussion

gives access to detail only when needed.

The configuration is helping the eight channel strips scale to a much larger project.

Configuration for Launcher-Based Work

For Launcher-oriented composition, priorities may include:

- New Clip Length;
- overdub behaviour;
- clip creation;
- navigation;
- Clip Based Looper options.

The goal is to reduce interruptions to the loop-building cycle:

Create



Record



Loop



Overdub



Listen

A well-chosen default clip length can be more valuable here than an advanced option that is rarely touched.

Configuration for Device-Heavy Work

If much of your work involves instruments and effects, Device Mode becomes especially important.

Priorities include:

- useful parameter feedback;
- predictable page navigation;
- easy device selection;
- effective V-Pot behaviour;
- FLIP where appropriate.

The desired path is:

Track
↓
Device
↓
Parameter Page
↓
Parameter

with as little unnecessary navigation as possible.

Configuration for Dub and Performance Mixing

Our Chapter 20 example suggests another set of priorities.

For performance-oriented mixing, useful behaviour includes:

- immediate fader access;
- fast Send selection;
- reliable Mute state;
- clear feedback;
- responsive automation;
- predictable banking.

The workflow might move rapidly between:

Faders
↓
Mutes
↓
Send 1 – Reverb
↓
Send 2 – Delay
↓
Faders

Here, predictability matters more than novelty.

When performing a mix, you do not want to stop and wonder what the surface is going to do.

The DrivenByMoss Settings Are Not a Test

There is a temptation with sophisticated software to assume that there must be one expert configuration.

There isn't.

A setting is not more advanced merely because it is more complicated.

The best configuration is the one that makes the controller behave predictably for your work.

That may be surprisingly simple.

Change One Thing at a Time

When experimenting with configuration, avoid changing many settings simultaneously.

Use:

Change one setting

↓

Test

↓

Understand the effect

↓

Keep or revert

rather than:

Change six settings

↓

Something is different

↓

Which setting did that?

This is particularly important with a contextual controller where one configuration choice may affect several workflows.

Test Changes Musically

A setting can look sensible in a preferences panel and still feel awkward in practice.

After changing something, use the controller for a real task.

If you change track navigation, navigate a real project.

If you change clip behaviour, create some clips.

If you change an encoder-related option, adjust real parameters.

The question is not:

Does the setting work?

It is:

Does the setting improve the workflow?

Keep a Known-Good Configuration

Once the X-Touch is behaving reliably, it is worth knowing what that working configuration looks like.

If a future update changes behaviour, a known-good setup gives you something to compare against.

Useful things to record include:

Bitwig version

DrivenByMoss version

X-Touch firmware version

X-Touch operating mode

MIDI port assignments

important DrivenByMoss options

This turns:

Something has changed.

into the much more useful:

What changed between these two known configurations?

Version Matters

DrivenByMoss continues to develop.

Bitwig continues to develop.

Behaviour may therefore change after this guide is published.

Project XTC should always state the versions against which its instructions were verified.

That does not mean the guide instantly becomes useless when a new version appears.

It means the reader knows the reference point.

For example:

Verified with:

Bitwig Studio 6.1 beta 4

DrivenByMoss 26.3.3

X-Touch firmware 1.22

A later version can then be compared with something concrete.

Updates Can Add Functionality

This guide itself grew because we discovered functionality that had not yet been represented adequately.

Features such as:

OPTION + MARKER

were easy to miss if we looked only at the most obvious controls.

DrivenByMoss development may introduce further capabilities.

So configuration and documentation should both be treated as living things.

The controller you know today may be able to do more tomorrow.

After an Update

After updating Bitwig or DrivenByMoss, do not immediately assume that every existing workflow remains identical.

Perform a quick sanity check.

For example:

Transport

✓

Faders

✓

SELECT

✓

Banking

✓

Displays

✓

Device Mode

✓

Sends

✓

If those fundamentals behave normally, continue to the more specialised functions you use.

This takes very little time and can prevent considerable confusion later.

Troubleshooting by Layer

Remember the complete system:

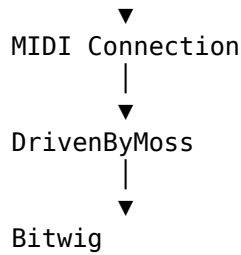
X-Touch Hardware

|

▼

MC Protocol

|



When something fails, work through those layers.

Is the X-Touch in MC mode?

If not, fix that first.

Are the MIDI ports correct?

If not, DrivenByMoss cannot communicate properly.

Does basic transport work?

If not, the problem is probably more fundamental than Device Mode.

Does feedback return to the X-Touch?

If commands work but displays or motors do not, investigate the return path.

Does only one advanced feature fail?

Now look at the relevant mode or configuration.

Troubleshooting from the bottom upwards is much more efficient than randomly changing settings.

Don't Forget the Obvious Things

Control-surface problems can sometimes have wonderfully uninteresting causes.

Before investigating obscure protocol behaviour, check:

- the X-Touch is powered on;
- the correct mode is selected;
- the correct MIDI ports are assigned;
- the controller entry is active;
- the expected track or mode is selected;
- the current project actually contains the object you are trying to control.

The more sophisticated the system becomes, the easier it is to overlook something simple.

A Sensible Starting Configuration

Project XTC is not going to prescribe one mandatory configuration.

But for someone following the workflows in this guide, a sensible starting point is:

X-Touch Mode

→ MC

MIDI

→ X-Touch internal ports

Track Navigation

→ choose deliberately:
flat or hierarchical

New Clip Length

→ set to your most common loop length

Feedback

→ verify displays, LEDs,
V-Pots and motor faders

Advanced options

→ leave at known defaults
until you have a reason
to change them

Then use the controller.

Let actual workflow problems tell you which configuration deserves attention.

Configuration Should Eventually Disappear

This may sound strange in a chapter about configuration, but the goal of good configuration is to stop thinking about configuration.

When the system is set up well:

Turn on X-Touch

↓

Open Bitwig

↓

Work

You should not need to reconsider the controller architecture every session.

The configuration has done its job when it becomes invisible.

The Important Idea

DrivenByMoss configuration determines the environment in which all the controls described in this guide operate.

The aim is not to discover the most complicated setup.

It is to create a predictable one.

Configure:

- the correct MCU mode;
- the correct MIDI ports;
- the navigation style that suits your projects;
- useful defaults such as New Clip Length;
- the behaviour required by your normal workflow.

Then verify the two-way conversation:

```
You
↓
X-Touch
↓
DrivenByMoss
↓
Bitwig
and
Bitwig
↓
DrivenByMoss
↓
X-Touch
↓
You
```

When that loop works reliably, the technology begins to recede.

And the controller becomes what we wanted from the beginning:

a predictable physical route into the project.

Coming Next

We now have a working controller, a mental model for understanding it, and a configuration that supports the way we want to work.

But DrivenByMoss goes further.

There are specialised options and expansion possibilities that not every user will need immediately.

The final chapter looks beyond the core workflow at:

- customisation;
- specialised options;
- Clip Based Looper;
- expansion;
- extending the surface;

- adapting the system as DrivenByMoss evolves.

Next:

Customisation and Expansion.

Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

Chapter 22 - Customisation and Expansion

Customisation and Expansion

We began Project XTC with a fixed piece of hardware.

Eight channel strips.

Eight V-Pots.

Motor faders.

Transport controls.

Mode buttons.

A Jog Wheel.

It would be easy to assume that this defines the limits of the system.

But DrivenByMoss provides another layer:

some parts of the X-Touch can be adapted to the way you work.

And if one X-Touch is not enough, the Mackie MCU implementation can also support additional control surfaces.

So this final chapter is about two related ideas:

Customisation



Make the existing surface suit you

Expansion



Make the physical surface larger

Neither is required.

A single X-Touch with its normal mappings is already a very capable controller.

But once the basic workflow is familiar, these options allow the system to become more personal.

Customise After You Understand

There is a temptation to customise a new controller immediately.

Change the function buttons.

Reassign the footswitches.

Modify preferences.

Create the perfect setup before making any music.

That is usually backwards.

A better progression is:

Use the standard workflow

↓

Notice repeated friction

↓

Identify the missing action

↓

Customise deliberately

In other words:

Solve problems you actually have.

Do not solve theoretical problems merely because a configuration option exists.

The Value of an Unused Button

A programmable button is valuable because it can shorten a repeated workflow.

Suppose you perform an operation twenty times during a session.

If that operation normally requires:

open menu

↓

find command

↓

click

but can instead become:

press button

that assignment may be worth making.

The best custom controls often feel surprisingly mundane.

They remove tiny interruptions.

And tiny interruptions repeated many times become significant.

Function Buttons

The X-Touch provides a row of function buttons labelled:

F1 F2 F3 F4 F5 F6 F7 F8

DrivenByMoss allows function-button behaviour to be assigned through its settings.

This makes the F-buttons a useful area for personal workflow commands.

Instead of asking:

What are F1-F8 supposed to do?

a better question is:

What would I benefit from having one button away?

Choose Functions by Frequency

A useful assignment is normally something that is:

- performed frequently;
- slightly awkward to reach otherwise;
- unambiguous;
- safe to trigger accidentally;
- easy to remember.

Suppose you repeatedly use a particular Bitwig operation.

Giving it an F-button may turn:

```
intention
  ↓
search
  ↓
mouse
  ↓
command
```

into:

```
intention
  ↓
F-button
```

That is exactly the kind of compression a control surface is good at.

Don't Fill Every Button

Eight labelled buttons can create a strange psychological pressure:

I must find eight things to assign.

You don't.

An unused button is not wasted.

A button assigned to something you never remember is more useless than an intentionally empty one.

Start with one or two functions that genuinely improve the workflow.

Then let experience tell you whether more are needed.

A Documentation Detail to Verify

There is currently a small discrepancy in the DrivenByMoss MCU documentation.

The general Functions section describes:

F1–F8

as assignable function buttons.

The Preferences section specifically lists configurable assignments for:

F1–F5

Project XTC should therefore not claim that all eight buttons are independently assignable in the current configuration interface until this has been verified against the exact DrivenByMoss version covered by the final guide.

This is a useful example of an important documentation principle:

When two sources inside the same reference disagree, test rather than guess.

The Quick Reference should contain only the verified behaviour.

Actions

One of the assignable function types in DrivenByMoss is an Action.

This allows an available Bitwig action to be selected and triggered from the controller.

Conceptually:

Physical Button



DrivenByMoss



Selected Bitwig Action

This opens the door to a much more personal controller layout.

Actions Turn Workflow into Hardware

Suppose Bitwig provides an action that you use constantly.

Without customisation:

remember shortcut
or
find command

With an assigned controller button:

press

The software command has acquired a physical location.

And once an action has a physical location, muscle memory can develop around it.

This is one of the subtle advantages of programmable hardware.

Pick Actions You Can Explain in One Sentence

A good custom assignment should normally have an obvious purpose.

For example:

This button does X.

If you need a paragraph to remember why you assigned it, the mapping may be too clever.

Simple mappings survive.

Complicated mappings get forgotten.

A useful test is:

If I return to this project after a month, will I still know what this button does?

If not, either simplify the assignment or document it.

Label Your Customisations

The X-Touch's printed F-button labels obviously cannot change.

If you create important custom assignments, keep a record.

For example:

F1 → [your chosen action]
F2 → [your chosen action]
F3 → unused
F4 → [your chosen action]

This record could live:

- in your Project XTC notes;
- beside the controller;
- in a small text file;
- in the project documentation.

The important thing is that a personal mapping should not become a personal mystery.

Footswitches

DrivenByMoss exposes two MCU footswitch functions:

Footswitch 1 – USER A

Footswitch 2 – USER B

Their functions can be selected in the DrivenByMoss settings.

This adds something fundamentally different from another button on the control surface.

A footswitch can be operated while both hands are busy.

Why Feet Matter

Consider a recording situation.

Your left hand may be on an instrument.

Your right hand may also be on the instrument.

Reaching for the X-Touch interrupts the performance.

A footswitch gives us another input channel:

Hands

└─ perform music

Foot

└─ control recording function

That separation can be extremely useful.

Good Footswitch Jobs

A footswitch is particularly suitable for actions that are:

- performance-related;
- time-sensitive;
- simple;
- safe to trigger without looking.

The best assignments depend entirely on the workflow.

For one person, a footswitch may belong to recording.

For another, it may trigger a transport or navigation function.

For someone else, it may never be needed.

Again:

Customisation follows the work.

Clip Based Looper

One particularly interesting assignable function is Clip Based Looper.

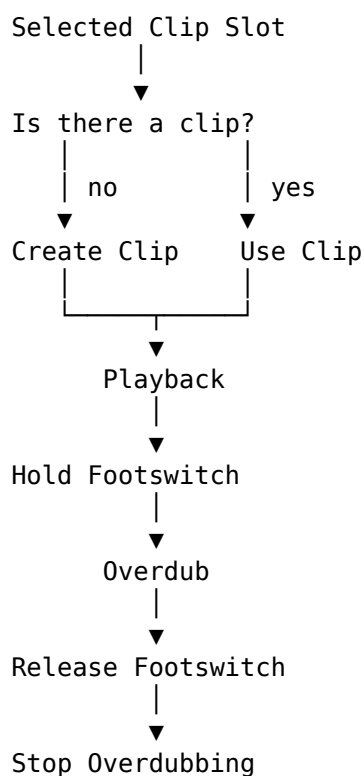
This connects directly with the recording concepts from Chapter 19.

DrivenByMoss uses the currently selected MIDI clip slot.

If that slot is empty, a new clip is created using the configured New Clip Length, and playback begins.

The footswitch then controls overdub according to whether it is held.

Conceptually:



That is considerably more than a simple button assignment.

It creates a performance workflow.

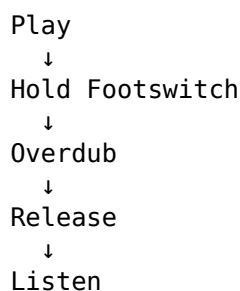
Hands-Free Loop Building

Imagine playing a MIDI keyboard.

Both hands are occupied.

The basic loop exists, and you want to add another layer.

With an appropriately assigned footswitch:



The hands remain on the instrument.

The recording state is controlled by the foot.

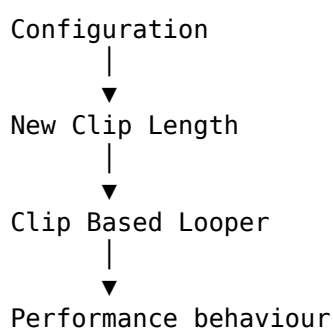
This can feel much more natural than reaching away from the keyboard every time the loop changes state.

New Clip Length Matters Here

Clip Based Looper also demonstrates why the configuration choices from Chapter 21 matter.

If the selected slot is empty, the new clip uses the configured New Clip Length.

So:



A setting made before the session affects what happens during the session.

This is exactly what we meant by:

Configure beforehand so that you have less to configure while making music.

A Simple Looper Workflow

Suppose New Clip Length is set to four bars.

A workflow might be:

1. Select the destination track and slot

Establish where the loop belongs.

2. Begin the Clip Based Looper operation

If necessary, the new four-bar clip is created.

3. Play the foundation

Record the basic musical idea.

4. Let it loop

Listen.

5. Hold the footswitch

Overdub becomes active.

6. Add another part

Continue playing.

7. Release the footswitch

Overdub stops.

8. Listen again

Decide whether the clip needs another layer.

This is the kind of workflow where hardware customisation becomes genuinely musical.

Customisation Can Reduce Mode Switching

A useful custom control can sometimes avoid a journey through several other controls.

Without an assignment:

leave current task

↓

find required function

↓

perform it

↓

return

With an assignment:

press

This does not mean that modes are bad.

Modes are what make the X-Touch powerful.

But if one operation repeatedly forces you out of the mode where you actually want to work, a custom button may provide a useful shortcut.

Expansion

Customisation changes what the existing hardware does.

Expansion changes how much physical hardware is available.

The Mackie MCU model was designed to support additional channel strips.

DrivenByMoss therefore supports multi-device configurations.

For the X-Touch family, the obvious companion is the X-Touch Extender.

Why Add an Extender?

A single X-Touch gives us eight channel strips.

That has shaped much of this guide:

Tracks 1–8

↓

BANK

↓

Tracks 9–16

An Extender gives us more physical strips simultaneously.

Conceptually:

X-Touch

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

+

Extender

9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16

Now sixteen channels can be available without banking.

Expansion Does Not Change the Mental Model

This is important.

An Extender does not invalidate everything we learned about banking and context.

It merely makes the visible window wider.

With one X-Touch:

Project

8 channels

With an additional eight-channel surface:

Project

16 channels

The idea remains:

The physical surface is a window onto the project.

The window is simply larger.

Main and Extender Roles

DrivenByMoss distinguishes between controller roles.

A device can be configured as:

- Main
- Extender
- MCU Extender

The Main device provides the full main-controller role, including controls such as the Master fader and transport functionality.

An Extender primarily contributes additional channel control.

Conceptually:

MAIN

- Channel strips
- Master
- Transport
- Main commands

EXTENDER

- Additional channel strips

This division reflects the physical design of MCU-style systems.

MCU Extender

DrivenByMoss also distinguishes an MCU Extender role for devices that use the original Mackie MCU Extender protocol.

This matters because not every additional controller communicates in exactly the same way as the main MCU unit.

For a straightforward X-Touch plus X-Touch Extender setup, choose the role appropriate to the actual hardware and connection rather than assuming that every expansion device should be configured identically.

Multiple Main Devices

DrivenByMoss also supports multiple devices configured as Main.

That is a more specialised configuration.

For most Project XTC readers, the simpler mental model is sufficient:

Main X-Touch
+
additional channel surface

More elaborate multi-device layouts should be configured only when there is a clear reason for them.

Restart After Extender Changes

Changes to the Extender Setup require the DrivenByMoss extension to be restarted before the new configuration takes effect.

This is worth remembering because otherwise the settings may appear not to have worked.

A sensible workflow is:

Change Extender Setup
↓
Restart extension
↓
Test banking and channel order

Do not repeatedly alter settings simply because the old state remains active before the required restart.

What Does More Hardware Actually Buy Us?

It is easy to think:

Sixteen faders must be twice as good as eight.

Not necessarily.

More physical channels offer some clear advantages.

Less Banking

The obvious advantage is fewer bank changes.

For a sixteen-track project:

One X-Touch

Tracks 1–8

↓ BANK

Tracks 9–16

X-Touch + eight-channel Extender

Tracks 1–16

simultaneously

That can make broad mixing considerably more immediate.

More Simultaneous Faders

Two hands can move several faders.

With more physical strips visible at once, more of the mix remains physically accessible.

This can be especially useful for:

- live mixing;
- automation passes;
- balancing Groups;
- performance-oriented work.

More Immediate Mute and Solo

The advantage is not only faders.

Additional strips also mean more simultaneously available:

- MUTE buttons;
- SOLO buttons;
- SELECT buttons;
- ARM buttons;
- V-Pots;
- display information.

The physical representation of the mixer becomes broader.

But More Hardware Also Means More Space

An Extender costs:

- money;
- desk space;
- another connection;
- more configuration;
- more physical reach.

The correct question is not:

Would sixteen faders be nice?

Of course they would.

The better question is:

Does banking interrupt my workflow often enough that more physical channels are worth the cost and space?

That is a much more useful decision.

Expansion and the Dub Mixing Desk

Our Chapter 20 dub workflow gives an obvious example.

With eight strips:

Drums
Bass
Skank
Organ
Percussion
Vocal
FX 1
FX 2

already fits rather neatly onto one X-Touch.

But a larger performance mix might contain:

Drums
Bass
Skank
Organ
Piano
Percussion
Vocal 1
Vocal 2
FX Return 1
FX Return 2
FX Return 3
FX Return 4

...

An Extender could keep considerably more of that surface physically available at once.

For a performance-style mix, that may genuinely change how the controller feels.

You bank less.

You react more.

More Controls Are Not Automatically Better

There is a useful parallel with custom buttons.

More functionality is only useful when it remains understandable.

A single well-learned X-Touch may be more effective than a huge surface whose layout you have not internalised.

Likewise:

4 useful custom assignments

may be better than:

20 assignments you cannot remember

The goal is not maximum capability.

It is maximum fluency.

Build a Personal Layer on Top of the Standard One

Project XTC has spent most of its time describing a common baseline.

That matters.

If every user begins with a completely different control map, documentation becomes impossible and troubleshooting becomes much harder.

So think of customisation as a second layer:

DrivenByMoss standard mapping



Learn the system



Personal customisation

Do not erase the standard mental model.

Build on it.

Keep the Obvious Things Obvious

If a button labelled PLAY plays, that is easy to remember.

If a custom button labelled F2 performs some personal action, that is also manageable.

Problems arise when familiar controls are remapped so aggressively that the surface no longer makes visual sense.

The printed legends are useful.

Use them where possible.

Save custom assignments for places intended to be custom.

Document Your Personal Setup

Once a controller becomes customised, your own documentation becomes valuable.

A simple file might record:

Project XTC Personal Configuration

F1 → ...

F2 → ...

F3 → ...

Footswitch 1 → ...

Footswitch 2 → ...

New Clip Length → ...

Track Navigation → Hierarchical

If the system ever needs to be recreated, this turns a reconstruction exercise into a checklist.

Customisation and Updates

DrivenByMoss evolves.

Bitwig evolves.

Available actions or configuration options may change.

After a major update, verify custom assignments just as you would verify normal controller behaviour.

A simple test might be:

F-buttons

✓

Footswitches

✓

Clip Based Looper

✓

Extender

✓

If something has changed, consult the current DrivenByMoss documentation before rebuilding the setup from scratch.

Leave Room for Discovery

One reason Project XTC grew from its original form was that the X-Touch could do more than we had initially realised.

An apparently obscure command such as:

OPTION + MARKER

led us to audit the complete DrivenByMoss MCU feature set.

That audit uncovered:

- Marker Mode;
- deeper modifier functions;
- Mixer Edit Modes;
- Automation;
- layers and drum pads;
- Master Mode;
- advanced recording;
- assignable controls;
- Extenders.

There will probably be further discoveries.

That is not a flaw.

It is what happens when a flexible controller meets actively developed software.

Don't Customise Away the Possibility of Learning

There is one subtle risk with customisation.

If we immediately assign a custom button to solve every unfamiliar task, we may never learn the standard DrivenByMoss workflow that already solves it.

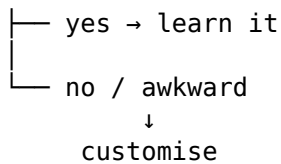
So when you encounter friction:

Problem

↓

Is there already a normal X-Touch method?

|



This preserves the common vocabulary of the controller while still allowing personal refinement.

A Sensible Customisation Process

A disciplined approach might be:

1. Use the normal setup

Work with it long enough to identify genuine friction.

2. Write the problem down

For example:

I repeatedly need to perform X and the current route interrupts me.

3. Look for an existing X-Touch workflow

There may already be one.

4. If necessary, choose a custom control

Use an F-button, footswitch or assignable Action.

5. Test it in a real session

Does it actually help?

6. Keep or remove it

Do not preserve a customisation merely because you spent time creating it.

7. Document anything important

Future you will be grateful.

Your X-Touch Does Not Have to Be My X-Touch

This guide needs a common baseline so that instructions remain meaningful.

But beyond that baseline, two users may reasonably develop different surfaces.

One might prioritise:

Automation

Mixing

Device control

Another:

Launcher recording

Clip Based Looper

Footswitch control

Another:

Large mixer

Extender

Many simultaneous faders

Another may change almost nothing.

All of those are valid.

The controller serves the workflow.

Not the other way around.

From Fixed Hardware to Adaptable Surface

When we first looked at the X-Touch, the hardware appeared fixed:

buttons
faders
knobs
displays

Now we can see several dimensions of adaptability.

Modes

↓

change what controls mean

Modifiers

↓

temporarily extend controls

Configuration

↓

change controller behaviour

Custom assignments

↓

add personal shortcuts

Extenders

↓

increase physical capacity

So although the hardware itself is fixed, the surface as experienced by the user is not.

The Important Idea

Customisation is not about making the X-Touch more complicated.

It should do the opposite.

A good customisation removes friction.

A good assignment shortens a repeated path.

A good footswitch keeps your hands on the instrument.

A useful Extender keeps the channels you care about physically available.

The test is simple:

Does this make the work easier to perform and easier to understand?

If yes, keep it.

If not, remove it.

End of the Numbered Chapters

We began with a piece of hardware.

Eight motor faders.

Eight channel strips.

Eight V-Pots.

A collection of buttons whose labels came from the Mackie Control world.

At first, the surface could look almost overwhelming.

But the underlying ideas turned out to be much simpler.

BANKS

→ move the window

SELECT

→ establish focus

MODES

→ change the view

MODIFIERS

→ temporarily extend a control

DISPLAYS

→ tell us what the controls mean

MOTOR FADERS

→ communicate in both directions

HIERARCHY

→ move between levels

CUSTOMISATION

→ adapt the surface to the work

Those ideas are more useful than memorising hundreds of commands.

Because when an unfamiliar function appears, we now have a way to understand it.

From Controller to Companion

The title of this project is X-Touch Companion.

That word matters.

A useful companion does not demand constant attention.

It does not make you think about its internal machinery every moment.

It becomes familiar.

Predictable.

Available when needed.

The same should eventually be true of the X-Touch.

At first:

Which button?

Which mode?

Which modifier?

Later:

I want the chorus.

I want the delay.

I want that fader.

I want to record this.

I want the snare quieter.

And your hands know what to do.

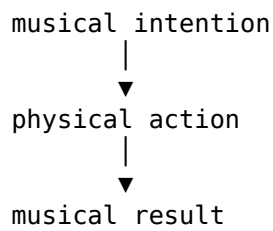
The Destination

The ultimate aim was never to become an expert in Mackie MCU button combinations.

It was never to avoid the mouse at all costs.

And it was never to use every feature simply because DrivenByMoss provides it.

The aim was to shorten the distance between:



When that distance becomes small enough, the controller itself begins to disappear from conscious attention.

You stop thinking:

I am operating the X-Touch.

You think:

The vocal needs more delay.

And then you do it.

That is where Project XTC has been heading all along.

What Comes After the Chapters?

The numbered teaching chapters are now complete.

But a guide such as this also needs something different:

a place to look things up.

The next section of Project XTC will therefore be the Quick Reference.

It will organise the verified DrivenByMoss/X-Touch commands in two ways:

- by physical control;
- by task.

The teaching journey ends here.

The reference begins next.